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LEADERS LIKELY TO MEET ON SUMMIT SIDELINES

As Modi, Trump head to G7, face-off over death of sailors

Jaishankar lodges protest over killing of 3 mariners; won't tolerate blockade violation: Rubio

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 13

AS PRIME Minister Narendra Modi and US President Donald Trump head to the G7 summit in Evian-les-Bains in eastern France for a possible meeting and discussion on trade, their first in over a year after the slide in bilateral ties, India and the US faced off Saturday over American missile strikes on commercial ships in the Gulf region, killing three Indian seafarers in one such attack on June 10.

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said he had spoken to US Secretary of State Marco Rubio — in a post on X, he said he had made the call Friday evening — and “reiterated”

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Prime Minister Narendra Modi at a diaspora event in Nice, France, Saturday. X/@NARENDRAMODI

Trump and Shehbaz say peace deal signing today, Iran questions timing

Eman Abouhassira, Steve Holland & Saad Sayeed
Dubai, Washington, June 13

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump and mediator Pakistan said Saturday an initial deal to end the war in the Middle East would be signed Sunday, although Iran denied the signing would

take place so soon.

Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif said the two sides had agreed on a framework for a peace deal and that Islamabad was preparing for an electronic signing Sunday, to be followed by technical-level talks next week.

Trump also said in a social

media post that the deal with Iran was scheduled to be signed Sunday and that the Strait of Hormuz, a vital artery for global oil supplies which Iran has blocked, would be immediately “open to all” after it was signed.

Earlier Saturday, Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

REBELLION AGAINST MAMATA GATHERS STEAM

TMC closer to split as heavyweight MP joins rebels, holds talks with BJP

Their count now 20, rebels to ask Speaker they be counted as a separate bloc

Manoj CG
New Delhi, June 13

IN A shot in the arm for the rebel faction of the Trinamool Congress (TMC) MPs, veteran party leader and six-time MP Sudip Bandyopadhyay Saturday signalled that he could join them as the dissidents prepare to meet Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Monday to urge him to recognise them as a separate bloc and allow them to sit alongside the MPs of the ruling BJP-led NDA in the House.

The development has caused a fresh setback for TMC

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Not just at top, cracks at grassroots amid anger against ‘syndicates’

Abhishek’s backyard to Kolkata and Bardhaman, *The Indian Express* tracks crumbling of TMC networks

Ravik Bhattacharya & Atri Mitra

Sonarpur, Kolkata, Jamalpur, June 13

A SMALL office made of asbestos and tin, in the blue and white colours of the Trinamool Congress, along the bustling Sonarpur Railway Station in South 24 Parganas, now sports a new look. Hoisted on it is a saffron banner saying ‘Bharatiya Mazdoor Sangha, Sarbarihat trade union, Sonarpur block’.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



A closed TMC office at Kamrabad in Sonarpur; a building linked to a TMC strongman in Belegkata being demolished. PARTHA PAUL

Centre takes possession of Delhi’s Jaipur Polo Ground

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, June 13

THE CENTRE took physical possession of the 15.20-acre Jaipur Polo Ground, one of Delhi’s prominent sporting avenues in the Race Course area on Saturday, a day after the Indian Polo Association (IPA), which manages the premises, failed to get court relief on an eviction notice.

Officials of the Land and Development Office (L&DO), Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, arrived at the Jaipur Polo Ground around 9 am Saturday. Accompanied by CRPF

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Happening today

● **ODI WORLD CHAMPIONS**
India face Pakistan in their first game of the ICC Women’s T20 World Cup in Birmingham.

● HER SON FIONGAL WAS ONE OF THE 52 BRITISH CITIZENS WHO DIED IN AHMEDABAD CRASH LAST YEAR

‘All we got to bury was a DNA sample’: British victim’s mother seeks answers

Ritu Sharma
Ahmedabad, June 13

AS SHE walks up with a bag full of ashes to the debris piled at the foot of a damaged hostel mess building in Ahmedabad, Amanda Donaghey has just one regret: that she still hasn’t found the remains of her son Fiongal, one of the 52 British citizens who died in the Air India plane crash of

AIR INDIA CRASH
a year later

June 12 last year.

“All we got to bury was a DNA sample of my son Finn that appeared to be about a centimetre square... I can’t tell you how much that hurts,” the 67-year-old says.

Thirty-nine-year-old Fiongal and his 45-year-old husband, Jamie Greenlaw-Meek, were among the 260 people who died when the AI 171 Boeing

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Amanda Donaghey, mother of Fiongal Greenlaw-Meek, one of the British victims, with her brother at the crash site in Ahmedabad

Lt Gen Dhiraj Seth next Army chief, first from Armoured Corps in 30 yrs

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, June 13

LIEUTENANT GENERAL Dhiraj Seth will be the next Chief of the Army Staff, the Ministry of Defence announced Saturday.

An Armoured Corps officer, Lt Gen Seth is currently serving as the Army’s Vice Chief. He will take over as the COAS on June 30 when current Army



Lt General Dhiraj Seth will take over as the COAS on June 30

chief, General Upendra Dwivedi, retires from service.

Lt Gen Seth will be the third Army chief from the 2nd Lancers, one of the oldest armoured regiments in the country, and the first Armoured Corps officer to be appointed Army chief in the last 30 years after General Shankar Roy Chowdhury (1994-97).

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

5 IAF personnel killed as AN-32 transporter crashes at Assam base

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, June 13

FIVE INDIAN Air Force personnel, including two officers, were killed Saturday when an Antonov AN-32 transport aircraft crashed during landing at Jorhat in Assam.

Of the six personnel on board, one was rescued and his

condition was said to be serious.

The IAF identified the five dead personnel as Sqn Ldr Prashant Singh, Flt Lt Shubham Kumar, Sgt Jitendra Sharma, Agniveervayu Khemaram Kumawat and Agniveervayu Danish Alam. A Court of Inquiry (Col) is being constituted to ascertain the cause of the accident.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

EXPRESS
interview

After 2 years of (India-Canada) tension, working methods better known to each other’

CHRISTOPHER COOTER
CANADA’S HIGH COMMISSIONER TO INDIA
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‘Brain-eating amoeba’ cases see surge in Kerala, 133 this year

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, June 13

A DECADE after detecting its first amoebic meningoencephalitis case in 2016, Kerala is seeing an alarming surge in the fatal infection, with 133 positive cases and 33 deaths in the first five months of 2026. A major chunk of the cases, according to the health department, are granulomatous amoebic encephalitis (GAE), caused by Acanthamoeba, a free-living amoeba found mainly in contaminated water.

The rise in amoebic meningoencephalitis cases is alarming, considering the state reported only eight cases between 2016 and 2023. However, the surge began in 2024, when Kerala recorded 36 positive cases and nine deaths across various districts. In 2025, the state reported 201 cases and 47 deaths. The figures have continued to rise this year, with positive cases already reaching 133 and deaths 33 till June 12.

Kerala’s figures stand out in sharp contrast to the number of detected cases in other states and abroad. Since the first recorded case of PAM in 1971, India had reported only around two dozen cases till 2023. Research papers on PAM state that only 381 cases were reported globally between 1965 and 2018.

According to Kerala Director of Health Services Dr K J Reena, the spike in cases is mainly due to the state’s rigorous testing of all unidentified encephalitis cases. “We are detecting more cases after all unidentified encephalitis cases are being subjected to all tests. Undetected encephalitis cases are very few in the state due to this rigorous testing and diagnosis,” Dr Reena told The Indian Express.

The DHS said that earlier, most amoebic meningoencephalitis cases were Primary Amoebic Meningoencephalitis (PAM), caused by Naegleria fowleri. “Now, the PAM cases have come down in Kerala and

most of the cases detected are GAE, caused by another free-living amoeba called Acanthamoeba, which is ubiquitous in water bodies, soil and even dust. Apart from the tropical climate of the state, poor quality of water is a contributing factor for the increased presence of this amoeba. Our water bodies have vegetation, which is another conducive factor for the increased presence of Acanthamoeba. Most of the affected persons are aged ones with compromised immunity. PAM has a global fatality rate of 97 per cent but GAE has a better survival rate,” she said.

In 2024, the Kerala health department designed a special treatment protocol and a standard operating procedure for the management of amoebic meningoencephalitis cases — becoming the first state in India to do so. This also helped early detection and reduced the mortality rate. The first Indian to survive the fatal infection was a 14-year-old in Kerala in 2024, and he was the 11th PAM survivor in the world.

Dr Anoop Kumar A S, director of Critical Care at Aster MIMS (North Kerala), also said rigorous testing is a key factor behind Kerala’s increase in cases.

“Western medical literature shows that most PAM cases were detected during postmortems. Many Western countries do not have regular screening for PAM/GAE. Whereas in Kerala, we are diagnosing the cases and saving lives,” he said.

Dr Anoop, who was instrumental in detecting the first Nipah case in Kerala in 2018, said water contamination can lead to an increased presence of Acanthamoeba. “Water quality is very poor in Kerala. High population density leads to contamination of water. Many households have their toilet pits close to open wells. Water bodies with high coliform bacterial counts are more likely to have a strong presence of Acanthamoeba, which feeds on various bacteria including E. coli,” he said, calling for a detailed environmental study.

3-yr-old’s death: 2 AIIMS Bhopal nurses booked for giving wrong injection

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, June 13

TWO NURSES at AIIMS Bhopal have been booked for allegedly administering a wrong injection to a three-year-old cancer patient who died in December last year, police said on Saturday.

The FIR, registered by Bagsewani police in Bhopal, names two nursing officers and draws extensively from findings of an internal AIIMS inquiry that concluded the child’s death was directly linked to the mistaken administration of formalin into his bloodstream.

Sarthak Yadav of Sagar had been admitted to AIIMS Bhopal’s on December 15, 2025. According to the FIR, the child was suffering from B-Cell Acute Lymphoblastic Leukemia (B-ALL), a form of blood cancer. Investigators found that doctors had scheduled a bone marrow aspiration and biopsy procedure for December 16. For the procedure, Nursing Officer Anuka Gujarati allegedly brought formalin into the ward in a 10-ml syringe after marking it for identification. Formalin, the FIR notes, is a “dangerous chemical liquid” used to preserve biopsy samples.

Officials at AIIMS Bhopal did not respond to queries seeking answers. On June 11, she performed a ‘hawan’ at Narayan Ghat on the Sabarmati River, offering letters from family and friends before dispersing their ashes on the heap of debris from the crash the next day.

“This sample was a piece of him large enough; there was obviously enough of him to take a sample from,” she tells *The Indian Express* in an exclusive interview. “So, where was the rest of him? What did they test? We never got that.” Gujarat Health Minister Praful Pansheriya says he was not aware of the case. On the reasons for confusion in handing over the bodies, Pansheriya says, “There is a possibility in cases of a disaster of such an extreme nature where the temperature went as high as several thousand degrees.”

Fiongal and Jamie were on a 10-day visit to India to celebrate their third wedding anniversary. They had visited India several times before. “They would visit India as part of a cleansing and clarifying process, visiting ashrams, an orphanage, and heritage sites,” Donaghey says. “They say it was part of their process of being spiritual guides.”

On June 22 — 10 days after the crash — Donaghey returned home believing she was carrying her son’s remains. The remains had been handed over after DNA identification.

ing a comment. The inquiry allegedly found that although the biopsy procedure was subsequently postponed, the syringe containing formalin was left on a locker next to the child’s bed.

The FIR states at around 7.15 am on December 17, Sarthak’s intravenous line got blocked. Nursing Officer Madhubala, who was on duty at the time, allegedly picked up the syringe on the locker to flush the IV canula without checking either the label on the syringe or its contents.

According to the police document, the three-year-old became unconscious as soon as the chemical entered his bloodstream. “Immediately after the chemical injection was administered, Sarthak became unconscious,” the FIR records. The child was rushed to the Paediatric Intensive Care Unit, where doctors attempted resuscitation but Sarthak died, the FIR stated.

A senior police officer said, “AIIMS Bhopal has suspended both nursing officers. We are on the lookout for them.”

Based on these findings, police registered a criminal case against both nursing officers under BNS sections relating respectively to causing death by negligence and negligent handling of hazardous substances.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Modi, Trump head to G7

India’s strong protest at the attacks by the US Navy in the Gulf that killed three Indian mariners” while underlining that “such lethal actions against commercial shipping are not justified”.

Hours later, the US Department of State pushed back. Deputy Spokesperson Tommy Pigott said, “Secretary of State Marco Rubio spoke yesterday with Indian External Affairs Minister Subrahmanya Jai-shankar. The two officials discussed recent events in the Strait of Hormuz. The Secretary stressed that all commercial vessels should immediately comply with orders from US forces as they seek to uphold peace and security in the Strait. He underscored that violations of the US blockade and the illicit transport of Iranian oil will

not be tolerated.”

The US statement, underlining its intent to enforce the naval blockade by making all commercial vessels comply with its orders, will escalate the row in India over the missile attacks on ships with Indian seafarers, and the death of three on board the MT Settebello.

Jaishankar, who was in Finland on a bilateral visit, called up Rubio, hours after the Ministry of External Affairs summoned the US charge d’affaires Jason Meeks for the second time in less than 48 hours over the attacks.

Rubio was in India last month, on a visit to repair ties that were severely strained in 2025 after Trump’s claims of mediation between India and Pakistan post Operation Sindoor and Washington’s deci-

sion to impose heavy tariffs on Delhi. The two countries are currently firming up a bilateral trade deal.

Modi, who reached France Saturday, will be attending the meeting of the G7 on June 16-17 and it is likely that he will have a conversation with Trump on the sidelines of the summit. This will be their first face-to-face interaction since February 2025 in Washington.

French diplomatic sources said President Emmanuel Macron will host a meeting on West Asia on the summit margins. Leaders from Saudi Arabia, the UAE and Oman are expected to attend. Modi and Trump too have been invited to the meeting — both the US and Iran have indicated that they are nearing a deal to end the crisis in West Asia.

Peace deal

Esmaeil Baghaei cautioned against commenting on the timing the signing.

“We will have to wait and see about the exact date of the signing of the memorandum of understanding, although it will not be tomorrow,” state media quoted Baghaei as saying. “The possibility of this happening in the coming days cannot be ruled out. However, due to the hesitation of the other side, we must be cautious in making any comments about this process.”

A US official who spoke to reporters later declined to be drawn on the timing but said: “It’s a great deal and a very strong deal.”

It is not the first time the two sides have appeared close to an initial agreement on ending the war that began on February 28 with joint US-Israeli strikes on Iran, but Sharif said on X: “We are closer to a peace deal than ever before.”

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said Friday that while changes in the deal were still possible, the tentative agreement showed his country had emerged stronger from the conflict. Hours after those remarks, US forces shot down multiple Iranian one-way attack drones heading toward Hormuz.

Iran has for months effectively blockaded the strait, and the US navy has blocked Iranian ports to reduce its oil exports.

The proposed memorandum of understanding calls for reopening the strait and lifting the US naval blockade, sources on all sides of the talks said.

Negotiations over Iran’s nuclear programme — Trump’s stated rationale for starting the war — would take place afterwards. “Iran is going to open up the Strait of Hormuz, that’s a requirement. It could be open with no tolls. As they do that, we will lift our blockade,” said the US official who spoke Saturday.

“It’s going to happen in conjunction, and part of the next step, the phase after that, is going

to be the demining of the straits,” the official said, indicating countries in the Group of Seven major powers could have a role in this.

Draft terms described to Reuters by multiple sources indicate the US would begin releasing billions of dollars in frozen Iranian assets and waive sanctions on its oil exports, in return for Iran opening the strait.

Iran’s Fars news agency quoted Baghaei as saying the release of Iran’s frozen assets was an integral part of the agreement and also that Iran would have to charge for services in the Strait of Hormuz. Iran’s nuclear programme would be addressed during a 60-day period of talks. A US official said the agreement would ultimately lead to the dismantling of Iran’s nuclear programme, with its stockpile of highly enriched uranium to be destroyed and removed.

But Araghchi said that Iran, which sources said has not accepted the dismantling of its nuclear programme, wanted to retain the uranium in diluted form. — REUTERS

Rebel bloc

E. EXPLAINED

Next move

chief Mamata Banerjee, with the party unravelling in the wake of its debacle in the recent West Bengal Assembly elections.

Bandyopadhyay landed in Delhi along with rebel TMC MP Satabdi Roy, following which they were seen entering the official residence of Union Minister Bhupender Yadav, who was the BJP’s in-charge for the Bengal polls. A group of dissident TMC MPs also had a meeting at Yadav’s residence earlier this week.

According to reports, Bandyopadhyay later also met Union Home Minister Amit Shah. While Bandyopadhyay did not make any comments, and the details of his meeting with the BJP leadership were not immediately known, the signal from the rebel TMC camp was that they had managed to enlist his support. Bandyopadhyay’s wife Nayna Bandyopadhyay is a TMC MLA in Bengal.

The rebel camp on Friday claimed that they have the sup-

port of 19 MPs, which account for two-thirds of the party’s Lok Sabha strength of 28 members. If Bandyopadhyay, a former leader of the TMC parliamentary party in the Lower House, joins them, their number would rise to 20.

The TMC leadership had last August appointed the party national general secretary and Diamond Harbour MP, Abhishek Banerjee, Mamata’s nephew, as its new parliamentary party leader in the Lok Sabha, replacing Bandyopadhyay. He has been grappling with health issues for

some time. Sources in the dissident camp said they are slated to have a meeting with West Bengal Chief Minister Suvenudh Adhikari in Delhi Sunday before meeting Speaker Birla on Monday in a bid to formally break away from the TMC and form a separate bloc. The TMC is currently the third largest Opposition party in the Lok Sabha after the Congress and the Samajwadi Party.

The rebel MPs want the Speaker to recognise them as the “real TMC”. Mamata has already lost control of her Legislature Party in Bengal after about 60 of the party’s 80 MLAs formed a separate bloc and elected Ritabrata Banerjee as their leader.

Hours after Sudip’s meeting with Bhupender Yadav, the TMC leadership removed him from his post as the party’s North Kolkata district president, replacing him with Mamata loyalist and MLA Kunal Ghosh. Sudip represents Kolkata Uttar in Lok Sabha. The TMC also removed another rebel MP Saayoni Ghosh as the party’s youth wing chief.

— WITH INPUTS FROM ATRI MITRA, KOLKATA

Jaipur Polo Ground

personnel and Delhi Police officers, they interacted with the Army personnel stationed there and showed them documents relating to the eviction, after which they were allowed entry inside. Most of the IPA’s major activities are managed by the Indian Army.

The L&DO officials entered the Jaipur Polo Ground premises and remained inside for nearly two hours. The officials pasted notices across the property and left around 11 am.

The notice read: “WARN-

ING, This land belongs to the Land & Development Office (L&DO), Government of India. Dumping garbage, encroaching on the land, carrying out construction, or engaging in any other unauthorized activity on this property is illegal. Anyone found doing so will face legal action and penalties under the applicable laws. By order, Land & Development Officer, Land & Development Office (L&DO), Government of India.”

The L&DO officials are learnt to have conveyed to the Army

personnel and the other representatives on the ground that they would return to complete the rest of the formalities on Monday. They also sealed the main gate of the ground and said no entry or exit would be permitted through the principal access point.

When contacted, IPA counsel Major (Retd.) Nirvikar Singh said the Association would challenge the move before the HC. “The Indian Polo Association maintains the eviction is wrongful, arbitrary and contrary to law. IPA is examining the order and will take all appropriate steps available in law to protect its rights and interests,” Singh said.

come to terms... I’m not searching for his remains. I know they’re gone. I’m looking for a solution to the identification.”

For Donaghey, the year after the accident was “all about trying to find him, and coming to terms”, not only with his death but also that of his father, who had been unwell and died soon after. “Those guys went out, clean of spirit. Happy as hell, in love to Earth’s end. Finn’s father died within the year. He didn’t have to see that.”

But isolating as grief is, what hurts more is the lack of closure. “Sometimes I feel like I’m shouting in the wind. I don’t think people understand how much it hurts to get the wrong person. I would have rather they didn’t

Meanwhile, news agency Reuters, quoting a senior US administration official it did not identify, said US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer will travel to India the week after the G7 summit for further discussions on a possible trade deal.

According to the official, trade would be discussed during Trump’s meeting with Modi, but no agreement on a trade deal was expected at the summit.

“We know that Prime Minister Modi is quite ambitious about the role he sees for India, the importance of the US-India relationship,” the official told reporters, according to Reuters. “We think a potential trade deal is part of that.”

Trump would insist on reaching “a very good deal,” the official said, adding: “We think a very good deal is possible. I don’t think we’ll close that deal at the G7.”

Army chief

Former Army chiefs General Maharaj Shri Rajendrasinhji Jadeja, also the first Chief of Army Staff of the Indian Army after Independence (1953 to 1955), and General Bipin Chandra Joshi (1993-94) were also commissioned into the 2nd Lancers.

Lt Gen Seth will oversee the ongoing absorption of technology, modern equipment and platforms in the Army, and the process of integration with the other services. He comes from a family with a military background, and people who have worked with him describe him as a meticulous officer and a keen sportsman. His brother is a senior naval officer.

An alumus of the National Defence Academy, Khadakwasla, he was commissioned into the Armoured Corps in December 1986.

The Ministry of Defence, in a statement, said Lt Gen Seth has extensive experience across operational, strategic, capability development and institutional domains in a distinguished military career spanning nearly four decades. He has contributed significantly to the Indian Army’s combat effectiveness and long-term transformation, it said.

His command assignments include an armoured regiment in the desert sector, an armoured brigade in the western theatre, and a counter-insurgency force in Jammu & Kashmir.

IAF crash

In a post on X, the IAF said it deeply regrets the loss of five personnel who made the supreme sacrifice in the line of duty.

“IAF extends its deepest condolences to the bereaved families and stands firmly with them in this hour of grief,” it said.

According to sources, the aircraft took off around 10 am on a paradrop sortie from Jorhat to Chabua. The crew, it is learnt, sought a landing soon after take-off. Upon landing, it veered off the runway, crossed the parallel taxiway, and broke into pieces before catching fire. Rescue efforts were launched immediately.

Sources indicated that the aircraft belonged to the IAF’s 43 Squadron and had undergone an overhaul and upgrade in recent years as part of the modernisation programme for AN-32s.

In a separate post on X earlier, the IAF said that the accident took place during a routine sortie in Jorhat. “Crash site management and initial enquiries are on at this time,” it said.

This is the third major crash of an AN-32 in the last 10 years. Bought in 1984 from the erstwhile Soviet Union, the AN-32 is a critical workhorse of the IAF.

find him at all.”

The ‘votive letters’ she brought, she says, were from friends and family — people who loved the couple. On Friday, as they burned in the holy pyre, she said a prayer, sharing her grief with Sita Patni, who lost her 13-year-old son Aakash after flames from the crash engulfed him as he slept outside their tea stall.

“For mothers who have suffered the same grief, language cannot be a barrier,” she says.

At the crash site, Donaghey spread the ashes where the aircraft’s tail was lodged. “We wanted to put them in the river, but the water in the river was too low. So, we returned to the site... I just feel close to them there.”

TMC cracks

It is the office of the autorickshaw union of the area, which has changed loyalties from the Indian National Trinamool Trade Union Congress (INT-TUC) to the BJP’s Mazdoor Sangh. The powershift in Bengal is one aspect of this transformation; the other is the rush to break the chokehold of the TMC’s “syndicate” system.

At the Sonarpur office, auto drivers talk about no longer having to pay “Rs 120 monthly per vehicle”, allegedly demanded by local TMC leaders.

It was just 2 km away from the railway station that TMC No. 2 Abhishek Banerjee was attacked on May 30 by a mob, which pelted him with eggs, shoes and stones — in what was seen as reflection of the large-scale anger against the TMC in general, and Abhishek in particular. Other TMC leaders accused of extortion or in alleged scams have also faced public fury, as well as arrests. Reports talk of leaders going on the run; found hiding, including under a stack of saris; or returning the “cut money” they took, in the hope of being spared.

It was under the Left’s 34 years in power that the syndicate system originated. However, under the TMC, it expanded and dug in deeper, with party leaders openly lending their weight to the system. From autorickshaw unions to supply of building materials and workers, from permission for construction to illegal buildings, and from sand mining to land grab, the “syndicates” ruled the roost.

Now, even as the TMC is cracking at the top, and Mamata Banerjee is fighting desperately to keep hold of her party, at the grassroot level too, the breach is spreading.

The Indian Express tracks this collapse across three places where TMC leaders find themselves in the dock:

Sonarpur

At Kamrabad’s Bhowmik Park, a half-constructed house stands out. Bapi Halder, who owns a workshop making iron grilles nearby, says: “Eight months back, construction started on the house. We don’t know how the government land was occupied, but no one protested out of fear. Since May 4 (when the Bengal results were declared), construction has stopped.”

TMC leaders and workers who would always be seen hanging around in the area that was a party bastion have disappeared, added Halder. “Everything has changed... We don’t see many BJP leaders too, but that is because there are none in this area.”

In the attack on Abhishek, the most prominent accused was a local TMC strongman. Of the other five arrested, one was a TMC booth worker.

At a Kamrabad railway gate nearby, the office of local councillor Anita Bose (Ward No. 9) is locked. Locals say she has hardly been seen since May 4. Calls to her phone get no response.

Bacchu Das, the chief of the local BJP unit or ‘Shakti Kendra’ in Kamrabad, says: “We could not even appoint booth agents in the area (during the elections)... Now people are slowly opening up. We are asking them to lodge complaints.”

About 2 km away, in Ghas-hiyara, Rupali Mondol (28) says she is back at home with her son, after a year. In August 2025, TMC workers allegedly loyal to local councillor Krishnapada Mondol (Ward No. 13) ransacked her roadside vegetable shop and part of her house, to erect a ‘Sha-hid Bedi (martyr’s memorial)’.

Rupali claims the councillor demanded Rs 20,000 to let her carry on her business. “I asked him if I could pay in instalments... He refused. So they ransacked my shop... I lodged a complaint with the police and National Commission for Women, but nothing happened.”

She says that after the results, she heard the councillor was on the run. His house was locked when *The Indian Express* visited. “So I am back home. I have pleaded with local BJP leaders to get my shop back,” she says.

About 6-7 km away, Councillor Tapash Halder of Ward No. 22, Rajpur-Sonarpur Municipality, and associates Biltu Mitra, Chiranjit Ghosh and Mannan Mollah are under arrest.

Rita Mondol, 41, whose husband Pranab is an autorickshaw driver and a BJP supporter, says that four days after the results, when they were away, their house was attacked by TMC workers. This time when they complained to police, the TMC men were arrested, she says.

The BJP’s Jadavpur organisational district secretary, Swarup Roy, says: “Syndicate *raja* and *goonda giri* of TMC is now almost over... In pockets where illegal activities are still on, administration has been told to take steps.”

Beleghata in Kolkata

Like Sonarpur, Beleghata was known as a TMC turf, with party candidate Kunal Ghosh winning from here in the recent Assembly elections. But since the BJP government took over, tremors have been sweeping through the area that is a hub of tightly packed buildings and high rises, with Kolkata Municipal Corporation (KMC) sending out notices to many of the structures and demolishing others.

All the TMC offices located along the Beleghata Main Road area are shut.

Dibas Dey, a CPI(M) area committee member, says: “Beleghata is famous for ‘thika’ tenancy (a tenant renting land and building on it),” and after the TMC came to power, they grabbed more and more land and made high rises. Almost all such buildings are illegal. Now the kingpins are on the run.”

Among the biggest allegedly was Raju Naskar, a TMC strongman and contractor. He is now under arrest, with one of his multi-storey buildings among those razed. Three weeks ago, during a post-victory rally in his Bhabanipur seat, CM Suvenudh Adhikari said: “I have given the Municipal Affairs Secretary and KMC Commissioner four names: Raju Naskar from Beleghata; Sona Pappu from Kasba; Abhishek Banerjee; and Javed Khan’s son... The BJP government will put these corrupt people behind bars.” Adhikari also attributed more than a dozen properties to each of the four.

A former associate and local youth TMC leader says: “Naskar remained on very good terms with police, political leaders and the KMC’s Building Department officials.”

A local youth TMC leader and a former Naskar associate says he controlled the area through “a huge team of goons... a women’s team and a men’s men”, who threatened land owners into signing agreements.

Somnath Dolui, a resident of Beleghata, says he was one of those landowners. After the 2021 results, Naskar allegedly first grabbed his family land, and then went back on a promise to give 50:50 share in flats. “Police declined to even register a complaint,” Dolui says.

While police refused to comment, a KMC official says that “more than a hundred” buildings” in Beleghata face action. “We are studying the cases and our team is doing surveys.”

The BJP’s Partha Chowdhury, who lost the recent Assembly polls from Beleghata to the TMC, says: “Not just the syndicate, people here are coming to police with complaints of other illegal practices of the TMC too.”

Jamalpur, Purba Bardhaman

About a hundred kilometres from Kolkata, in Shah Hussainpur village of Jamalpur block, a community centre and a flood shelter along the Damodar river are locked. The local INTTUC president, Tabarak Ali Mondol, and his wife Arifa, a panchayat pradhan, are under arrest.

Police say the two government structures were used as an office and restrooms by an illegal sand mining syndicate led by Tabarak, with villagers denied access to them. Police claim to have recovered from the two sites bags of fertilizers, rice and pesticides, apart from MNREGS job cards and other documents.

“Fertilisers and other items meant for distribution among villagers were sold in the black market. Job cards were also forcibly taken, and syndicate members decided what work would be done and who got it,” says a villager, Sheikh Mortej.

At the community hall, located in Fatehpur, two earthmovers reportedly owned by Tabarak are parked. Gopal Adak, 60, says: “Every day, 150 to 200 trucks carried out sand... No one protested out of fear.”

“Now, that fear is gone,” says Nimal Majhi, 40. “Apart from illegal sand mines, cut money was taken from people who got Banglar Bari (housing scheme)... We are planning to lodge complaints.”

Jamalpur BDO Parthasarthi Dey said: “We were not aware that such activities were on. However, police are investigating everything now.”

Says local BJP leader Mrityunjay Chandra: “For a long time, TMC leaders here indulged in such activities. People repeatedly complained but no action was taken. The BJP government is changing that.”

TO ERADICATE 5,000 DARK SPOTS, SAVE 4 CRORE UNITS OF ELECTRICITY

Smart street lights to make Delhi safer, save power: Govt floats tender for Rs 473-cr project

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, June 13

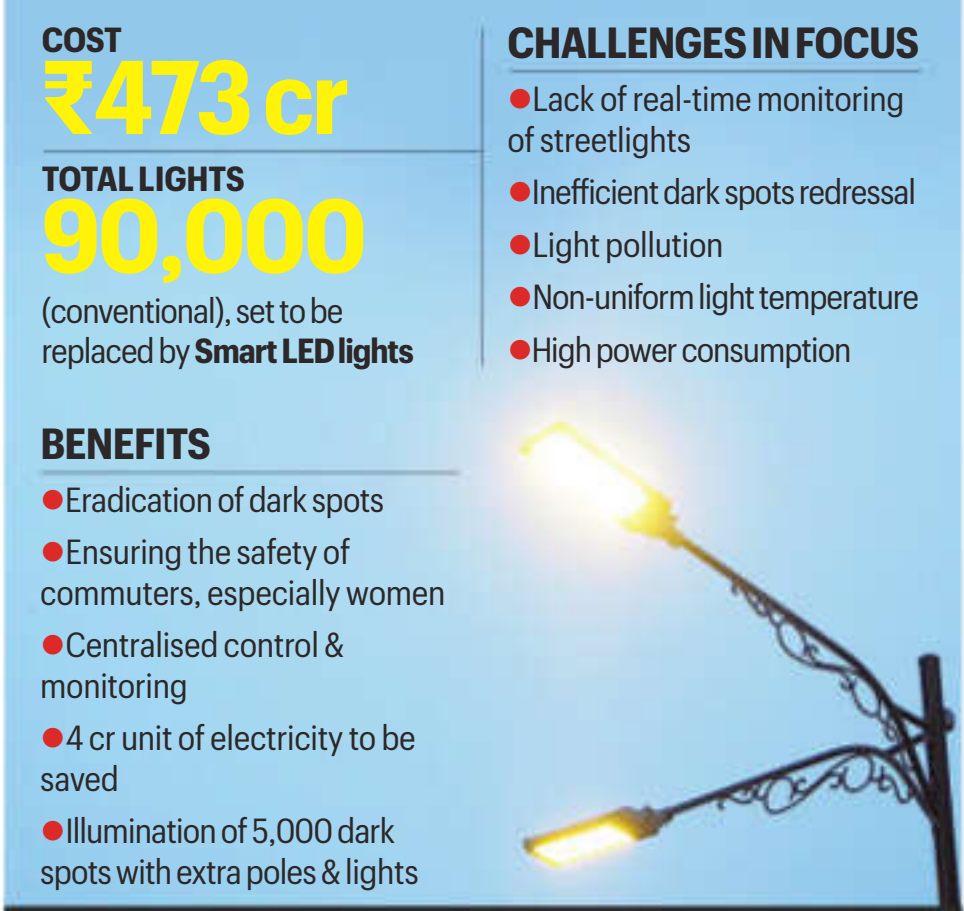
AIMING TO replace 96,000 streetlights installed on 51,160 poles with smart LED lights, save around 4 crore units of electricity, and eradicate 5,000 dark spots across the Capital, the Delhi government has floated tender for a Rs 473-crore project that is set to make the city safer.

Under this project, the Delhi government aims to ensure real-time monitoring of streetlights to address complaints without any delay, according to officials.

The project will replace all the existing HPSV (High-Pressure Sodium Vapor) and conventional LED streetlights with Smart LED street lights for judicious power consumption, and will target locations with missing poles as well as take into account future illumination requirements, said officials.

On the current set of challenges faced in management of streetlights in the city, Public Workers Department (PWD) Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh

Smart street lighting project



said, “The existing system lacks real-time monitoring of streetlight functionality and largely depends on a complaint-based maintenance approach. As a result, faults often go undetected for extended periods, leading to delayed

identification and rectification of dark spots...the inadequate illumination not only affects visibility and road safety but also contributes to uneven lighting coverage.”

As per estimates, the initiative is expected to generate an-

nual energy savings of around Rs 25 crore while also reducing the city’s carbon footprint, Singh added.

“It has also been observed that the conventional system consumes more power than necessary, leading to higher electricity costs and wastage, while inefficient lighting practices also contribute to light pollution (unwanted outdoor light). Thus, to address the challenges, we have come up with a smart street lighting project with an aim to eliminate dark spots on roads, enhance safety and security for women and improve road safety for motorists and pedestrians along with an overall better public safety and visibility,” the Minister said.

As per the PWD data, 45,000 of these total streetlights currently installed are HPSV, while another 51,000 are normal LED lights. PWD maintains 1,400 kms of road stretch including main arterial roads and over 106 flyovers and underpasses.

The department also has plans to set up a Centralised

Command Centre (CCC), which would enable real-time monitoring and management of all streetlights across the city, officials said.

The centre, they added, will enable individual light-level monitoring and control, making it possible to immediately identify non-functional lights and dark stretches.

“Unlike the existing complaint-driven approach, maintenance will be data-driven, allowing the department to detect faults and act quickly to fix it,” an official added.

On how the government plans to reduce electricity consumption and improve operational efficiency through the project, the Minister said, “The smart lighting network will have the capability to dim lights when required, optimising power usage without compromising public safety. For instance, I can monitor the situation while sitting at my office. If a particular stretch is less used, the lights can be dimmed and if there is a celebration we can adjust the system and illuminate the entire city...”

REGULATOR’S NOD TO DISCOMS FOR ADDING SURCHARGE

Consumers getting power subsidy won’t get affected: Minister

Around 80% of the domestic consumers or 48L households receive subsidy

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, June 13

AMID CRITICISM over the Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission’s recent nod (DERC) to discoms for raising a surcharge used to recover higher power procurement costs, which is set to increase electricity bills in the Capital, Power Minister Ashish Sood on Saturday said that consumers receiving subsidy would remain unaffected.

“I want to categorically state that all consumers receiving Delhi government electricity subsidies will face absolutely no impact on their electricity bills due to this regulatory adjustment,” Sood said.

Citing the impact of the ongoing West Asia crisis, headed, “The electricity laws of the country already permit power companies to adjust for the rising cost of fuel used to generate electricity. Due to the situation in West Asia and other prevailing circumstances, fuel costs have risen sharply, leading to a 31% increase in power procurement costs during the past month.”

The power regulator in the Capital approved an increase in the Power Purchase Adjustment Cost (PPAC) — a regulatory surcharge that allows distribution companies to recover fluctuations in fuel and power procurement costs — charged by power distribution companies on June 10.

Officials, however, underlined that PPAC has no impact on the electricity bills of consumers eligible for subsidy as the subsidy is linked to the number of units consumed and not to the bill amount.

An overview

POWER DISTRIBUTION COMPANY	PREVIOUS PPAC	REVISED PPAC
BSES Rajdhani Power (BRPL)	14.51%	17.94%
BSES Yamuna Power (BYPL)	11.71%	17.43%
Tata Power Delhi Distribution (TPDDL)	15.99%	16%

*PPAC-POWER PURCHASE ADJUSTMENT CHARGE.

● A household getting 400 units of electricity will pay ₹92 more in areas under BYPL

● In areas under BRPL, a household

receiving 400 units of electricity will have to pay ₹56 more

● Hike set to reflect for the bills that are generated from June

As per the official data, the number of electricity consumers in Delhi stood at around 73 lakh in 2024-25. Of these, 84% or 61 lakh are domestic consumers.

Around 80% of the domestic consumers or nearly 48 lakh households get subsidies in two categories — free electricity for monthly consumption of up to 200 units and a 50% subsidy for those using 201 to 400 units. Officials said the regulator allowed lower recoveries than what was sought by the discoms in some cases.

According to the DERC order, PPAC for BSES Rajdhani Power Limited (BRPL) has increased from 14.51% to 17.94%, while for BSES Yamuna Power Limited (BYPL) it has risen from 11.71% to 17.43%. For Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (TPDDL), the PPAC hike has been negligible — from 15.99 % to 16%. So, the biggest impact is set to be felt for consumers in East and Central Delhi served by BYPL.

A household getting 400 units of electricity will pay Rs 92 more in areas under BYPL and Rs 56 more in areas under BRPL. The increase is negligible for Tata Power areas. The hike is set to reflect for the bills that are generated from the month of June. The Minister’s clarification came amid criticism from opposition parties and RWAs. “The Central government has increased the prices of petrol, diesel, cooking

gas, everything. So the Delhi government seems to have thought, ‘Why should we be left behind?’ They have increased electricity tariffs as well. Now, it is difficult for the middle class to live in Delhi. School fees are almost doubling, electricity prices have been raised, and houses are being demolished. How can anyone live in Delhi under such circumstances?” asked AAP leader Saurabh Bhadrawaj.

BS Vohra, President of the East Delhi RWAs Joint Front, claimed that the regulator had approved the increase without an audit by the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) and demanded that the Delhi government intervene and conduct a review of the matter.

Officials underlined that PPAC enables discoms to recover power purchase costs already paid to generating companies and helps avoid liquidity stress in the sector.

According to officials, Delhi shifted to a monthly PPAC mechanism from April this year, replacing the earlier quarterly system.

They added that the Ministry of Power and subsequent amendments to electricity rules require state regulators to establish mechanisms for automatic pass-through of fuel and power procurement cost variations. More than 25 states and union territories have implemented a fuel surcharge adjustment formula, officials added.

2020 Delhi riots ‘larger conspiracy’ case: Umar Khalid, Sharjeel Imam move fresh bail pleas

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 13

CITING PROLONGED incarceration and delay in trials, Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam have moved fresh bail applications before a court in the “larger conspiracy” terror case linked to the 2020 Northeast Delhi riots.

Sharjeel Imam’s bail plea highlighted that despite more than six months since the Supreme Court’s judgment, which denied the two bail, there has been no meaningful progress in the trial proceedings. Currently, the case is at the stage of arguments on charge.

Meanwhile, Khalid’s plea argues that even as his earlier bail plea was rejected by the SC, subsequent judicial developments constituted a “change in circumstances”. He was referring to the court’s remarks in May in another case, asserting that “bail is the rule...” even under the draconian Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA).

Vacation Judge Dr Sumedh Kumar Sethi of Karkardooma Courts issued notice and sought a response on the bail pleas from the Delhi Police Special Cell while listing the matter for hearing July 4. On January 5, the Supreme Court refused bail to Khalid and Imam in the case while granting relief to co-accused Gulfisha Fatima, Meeran Haider, Shifa Ur Rehman, Mohammad Saleem Khan and Shadab Ahmad.

A bench of Justices Aravind Kumar and NV Anjaria then observed that there was a prima facie case against Khalid and Imam under the UAPA and held that all accused could not be treated equally in view of the “hierarchy of participation”. As per the Delhi Police Special Cell, which has been investigating the case, 18 persons orchestrated a “larger conspiracy” which eventually led to the violence which rocked Northeast Delhi in February 2020.

All 18 people were booked under relevant provisions of the stringent anti-terror UAPA and the Indian Penal Code. The Special Cell had argued that the riots were the result of a months-long “deep-rooted” conspiracy allegedly hatched after the Citizenship Amendment bill received Cabinet approval in December 2019. The “conspiracy” here involves the creation of 23 protest sites (which operated for 24*7) in “Muslim majority areas” close to mosques and main roads.

The accused claimed the Special Cell, wanted to “escalate” the protest to a “chakka jam” (road blockade) “once critical mass is generated” when US President Donald Trump visited Delhi in 2020. The goal of the accused, as per the Special Cell, was to create violence against police personnel and spread communal violence.

Delhi set to witness mega drive led by CM to clean Yamuna today

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 13

DELHI IS set to see a mega cleanliness drive across 28 ghats of the Yamuna on Sunday. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, who will lead the one-day campaign, said, “Yamuna is not merely a river but a cultural, religious and environmental heritage of Delhi. The protection and cleanliness of the Yamuna is not only the responsibility of the government but also the duty of every person. The campaign is being organised with the objective of taking this message to the people and encouraging collective participation.”

She added that cleanliness of Yamuna river is not a one-day programme but a continuous public movement that

requires participation from every section of society.

Cleaning Yamuna was one of the key poll promises of the BJP in the run up to Assembly polls last year. “The Delhi government is committed to transforming the rejuvenation of the Yamuna into a people’s movement...a large-scale effort had also been undertaken last year through the ‘Meri Yamuna, Mera Kartavya’ (My Yamuna, My Duty) campaign to clean the Yamuna and its ghats. Thousands of volunteers participated in that campaign, and more than 12 tonnes of waste were collected and scientifically disposed of,” asserted the CM, appealing to the residents to join her in large numbers and make the drive successful.

According to officials, Gupta will lead the cleanliness

drive at Thokar No 14, Geeta Colony Ghat from 6 am, where she will also be joined by thousands of volunteers.

In a statement, the Chief Minister’s Office (CMO) said that around 500 social, religious, educational and voluntary organisations, along with thousands of volunteers and Delhi residents, will participate in the campaign. The campaign will also witness participation from several ministers of the Delhi government and other dignitaries, officials said.

According to the CMO, cleanliness and public awareness activities will be carried out simultaneously across various ghats, riverbanks and river-front areas of the Yamuna on Sunday. The campaign will be conducted simultaneously at several prominent locations.

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LOOK OUT NOTICE

It is hereby notified for the information of the general public that Avijit Biswas, S/o Shri Narayan Biswas, R/o Simurali, Inayetpur, Nadia Simurali, West Bengal-741248, is wanted in connection with FIR No. 02/2024 registered at Police Station CICE, Jammu under Sections 419, 420, 120-B IPC read with Section 66-D of the Information Technology Act, 2000.

The above-named accused is required in the said case and his present whereabouts are not known. Any person having information regarding his whereabouts, location, movement, or any other relevant details is requested to immediately contact Police Station CICE, Jammu on Mobile No. 9484320617 (9419165466 I.O. of the case) or provide the information through any nearest police establishment.

The identity of the informant shall be kept strictly confidential. The particulars and photograph of the accused are furnished below for identification purposes. Details of the Accused: -

- Name :- Avijit Biswas
- Parentage :- Narayan Biswas
- Address :- Simurali, Inayetpur, Nadia Simurali, West Bengal-741248
- Sex :- Male



Sd/-
Investigation officer
PS CICE, Jammu.

DIP/J-3632/26, DATE 13 JUNE 2026

Prayer Meeting



Cdr. V.K. Tuli *VM*

1937-2026

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June 14, 2026 | 4:00 - 5:00 PM

DLF Magnolias Club

Golf Course Road, Sector 42, Gurugram

Prof. S.M. Tuli
Veena Tuli
Mila & Sunil, Vipul & Shruti
Riddhi & Nicholas, Amrita, Aditi
Tuli and Nanchahal Families

Traffic policeman run over by tempo; dies

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 14

A 39-YEAR-OLD head constable of the Delhi Traffic Police died after he was allegedly run over by a tempo in North Delhi’s Kashmere Gate area on Saturday, said officers.

The incident happened when Head Constable Anil Kumar was stationed at the road from Shanti Van to Chandgi Ram Akhara. He fell on the ground before a tempo coming right behind ran over him. The tempo driver was arrested from the spot, a police officer said.

Anil, a resident of Chattarpur in Delhi, was quickly rushed to Sushruta Trauma Centre in Civil Lines, but the doctors couldn’t save him, said officers. His family, who lives in Behror region of Rajasthan, have been informed about the incident. Police are now looking at the CCTV cameras and establish the chain of events.

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2. Housekeeping Operation 3. Food & Beverage Service
4. Front Office Operations 5. Bakery & Confectionery
Age: No age limit | Duration - 1 Year & 6 Months

FOR CLASS 10 PASSOUT CANDIDATES
CERTIFICATE COURSE IN FOOD PRODUCTION/VEGETARIAN
Age: No age limit | Duration - 1 Year & 6 Months

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Age: No age limit | Duration - 6 Months

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Notification No. : IIITDM/M.Tech/Admission/02/01/2026 Dated : 02.06.2026

IIITDM Kancheepuram located at outskirts of Chennai is an Institute of National Importance setup by the Ministry of Education, Govt. of India. IIITDM Kancheepuram invites online applications for spot admission to M.Tech. programmes for 2026 session.

Online application form and information regarding academic qualifications, eligibility and financial assistance are available on the Institute website (<http://www.iiitdm.ac.in>). Contact us on pgadmission@iiitdm.ac.in for additional information.

Starting date for online application: 15.06.2026
Last date for online application: 10.07.2026 Registrar

Jaipur Polo Ground sealed: ‘It has such a rich legacy of 100 yrs’

Pragnesh and Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, June 13

IT WAS a usual, sunny summer morning at the Jaipur Polo Ground in Delhi. Inside the Air Force camp near the Kemal Ataturk Road, workers were getting ready on Saturday to water the grass spread across the 15.2-acre stretch, a stomping ground for national polo tournaments — featuring princes and kings of erstwhile provinces, diplomats, Army men, and businessmen — -for over a century, and the only parcel of playing turf which the Indian Polo Association (IPA) has.

The viewing terraces were to be broomed, and a gigantic statue of the ‘noble horse’ — carved with white stone and named ‘Rajesh’ — overlooking the VIP sitting area, was to be dusted.

But officials at the venue knew it wouldn’t be like every other morning. On Friday, a sessions court had refused to grant a stay on the execution of the eviction order, passed on

May 20, which stated that the 15.20 acres of Jaipur Polo Ground would be used “for a larger public purpose and benefit” by the Centre, without details of the said purpose or benefit.

And then their fears came true when at about 9:00 am, officials of the Land and Development Office (L&DO), which comes under the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, arrived with 150 personnel from the CRPF and Delhi Police. They were there to seal it all — a century of elite sports history, and take control of one of the most valuable parcels of land in Delhi.

“We were not going to argue with them. They started clicking pictures of the area, and even their own selfies. We took the opportunity to collect some of our stuff from the ground. They then started to go around pillars and placed government notices on them,” said an official who works there.

Nearly a century ago, Maharaja Savai Man Singh II of the erstwhile Jaipur province had gifted a parcel of his Delhi estate



The sealing exercise began around 9 am at the ground spread across 15.2 acres. PRAVEEN KHANNA/ SAKSHI CHAND



to the now dissolved Delhi Polo Club in 1930.

During the season, 300-400 people come to watch the games, with the circumference of the ground packed with parked vehicles, after no space is left in the parking area outside the vicinity.

“And now it won’t be there. We started to prepare for the next season, but I knew after the Gymkhana...this land will go too. There is no other ground in Delhi which has public-access to polo matches,” the official said.

“They say it’s for ‘defence’ infrastructure that they are taking it. Most high-ranking officials on the board (of IPA) are Army men. General Upendra Diwedi is the President. How about you ask them,” another official said.

It was on March 29, when the last match of the season was played at the ground between Jindal Panthers and Jaipur Achievers — the finale of the Northern India Polo Championship. Two days before that, industrialist Naveen Jindal had said that Polo was India’s “gift to the world”

“The matches would resume here in October, after the season starts in August from Bangalore polo ground. Matches are conducted in multiple cities throughout the season in different cities. Delhi has its first one in October,” said the official.

Sahil, 32, who comes from Shahdara to work on the turf everyday, said he has spent his life on this ground. “I have been here since I was a kid, learning to be a caddie from other seniors here. My whole life has been about this place. I don’t know

what my position will be here now,” he recalled.

Roshan, 23, a lanky young man standing with his t-shirt tucked inside his trouser — just like the golfers and polo players he assists — lives in a jhuggi near Lok Kalyan Marg. He said that he thought that his house would be on the chopping block next. “The jhuggis are being cleared. The places that employ people living there are also being taken by the government. Gymkhana gaya, ye bhi gaya. It’s moving so fast, I don’t know where to go,” he said.

Soon after, two men, in their 60s, hopped on the golfing turf attached to the polo ground, stretching their arms and moving and asking a caddie for a couple of golf balls. Both retired army veterans, they gave an almost cynical smile, almost together, when asked about the sealing of the polo ground.

“I don’t understand what’s the point of this. It hasn’t been a problem for 100 years. It’s such a beautiful green pasture of land. It has such a rich legacy. There are not many places like this in Delhi. I have always loved coming here,” one of them said.

The ground is not going to see another season of tournaments as of now. It has lived well though, with horses — ridden by men wearing skinny pants, boots, and helmets, swinging around 50-55 inch long wooden mallets — galloping at the centre of the Capital, celebrities like Shah Rukh Khan and Shilpa Shetty coming for Pataudi Cup Matches, and international events like equestrian events and Asian Games all being played here.

• Skywatch



Forecast: June 14, 2026

Partly cloudy sky, possibility of thundery development

MAX: 36-38

1.9°C below normal

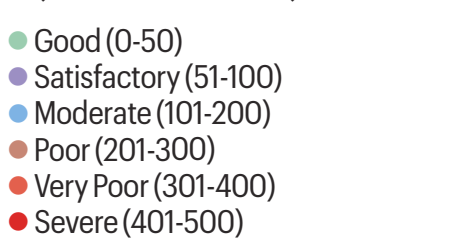
MIN: 23-25

5°C below normal

• *Sunrise: 5:23 AM (June 15)*

• *Sunset: 7:20 PM (June 14)*

• AQI Tracker



Held captive for two years, faced abuse: Woman rescued from Gurgaon flat

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, June 13

FORCED TO work 16 hours a day, beaten up over minor issues and barred from calling up family members — this is the alleged ordeal a 39-year-old tribal woman from West Bengal’s Birbhum district faced for nearly two years as she was held captive as a bonded labourer at a flat in a residential society in Gurgaon’s Sector 91. The smart locking system at the home prevented her from stepping outside the residence, said police. It was only after a recent visit by a technician to the house that she was able to raise the alarm and get in touch with her family.

Following a coordinated operation by the West Bengal Police, Gurgaon Police, the district administration in Gurgaon, and civil society organisations, she was finally rescued on Saturday, officers said.

After her rescue, officers added, the survivor claimed that consistent physical abuse by her employer had left her unable to lift her right arm or hear from her right ear. She further reported being assaulted so brutally on her head and face on the morning of her rescue that she feared she

would die.

The woman, officers said, was brought to Delhi and then Gurgaon to work as a domestic help after an advance payment of Rs 40,000 by the family. The circumstances under which she was handed over are still under probe.

Her employers allegedly frequently locked her inside the house when they went out.

When a service technician recently visited the house, the survivor seized the opportunity and convinced him to let her use his mobile phone and called her family, said police.

On June 4, an FIR was registered at a police station in West Bengal.

The survivor’s sister travelled to Gurgaon to assist in ensuring her release. A team from The West Bengal Police also travelled to Delhi. Speaking with *The Indian Express*, Assistant Sub-Inspector Rajesh Khawal of the Sector 93 police post said the family was not at home at the time of the operation.

Another officer privy to the probe said, “We pasted notices outside the home of the accused family to join the probe. The employer threatened to harm and chop her to pieces. The woman is traumatised.”

EDUCATION DEPT STEPS IN TO ENSURE STUDENTS DON’T DROP OUT

Counsel students who failed Class IX, govt schools told

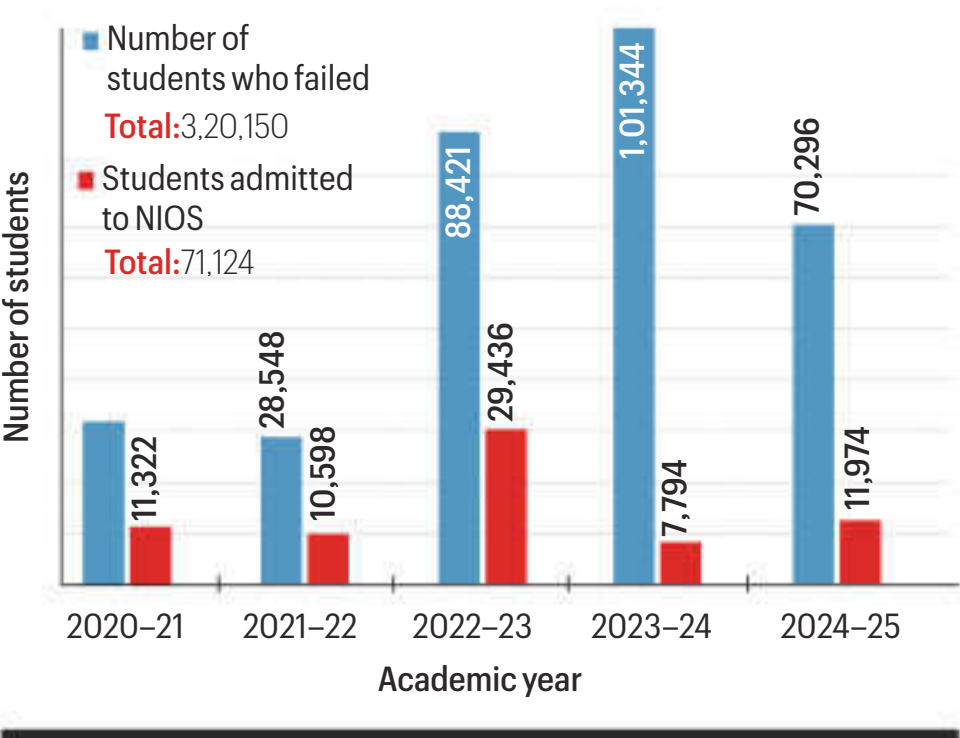
Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, June 13

IDENTIFY STUDENTS who have failed Class IX twice or thrice and counsel them and their parents to ensure that they continue schooling; this is what the Directorate of Education (DoE) has directed the heads of the government schools in the Capital as the number of students dropping out of schools after Class IX continues to be a major concern.

The latest direction was issued through a circular, dated June 4, by the NIOS Project of the Education Directorate. The circular was issued after the declaration of Class IX compartment examination results. “There is an urgent need to identify, counsel and guide the students who have failed twice or thrice in Class IX,” it said. An “absence of proper guidance and motivation” has been flagged by DOE officials to be causing a “risk of discontinuing” their education. The department’s direction also points to special attention for parents as it states they require “motivation, counselling and assurance that the school will continue to support the child”.

The department has described the exercise as a drop-out-prevention measure and underlined that the initiative by

What numbers reveal



heads of schools can help “save many innocent students” and that the “ultimate goal” is to ensure that all children complete at least their school education.

Over the last five academic years, 3,20,150 students failed Class IX across the government schools in the city while 71,124 were admitted to the National Institute of Open Schooling (NIOS), according to the records of the Education Department. This means only about 22% of Class IX students who failed moved to NIOS — an autonomous organisation under the Ministry of Education that provides academic, vocational, life

enrichment and community-oriented courses at the secondary and senior secondary levels.

The first instruction to schools is to retain the students in regular schooling. School heads have been asked to counsel students and parents on the importance of completing schooling and to “motivate and encourage them to continue their education in their regular school itself”. Regular school is seen as the first option and students should first be encouraged to continue in the regular school system, the directions noted.

NIOS has been positioned as

the alternative route where the student or parent is unwilling to continue in regular school and seeks a ‘school leaving certificate’. In such cases, schools have been asked to counsel them to take admission directly in Class X through the NIOS Project of the Directorate of Education.

According to DOE officials, “This would allow students to continue their education through NIOS Board, which is a government body, at their own pace and in subjects of their choice and can help in saving a precious year of a student’s academic life”. Schools have also been asked to tell parents that under the NIOS scheme, “tough subjects like Maths are not compulsory” and students can opt for “lighter subjects of their choice”. All heads have been asked to procure a list of students who have failed Class IX more than once. They have also been directed to personally call such students to school as per the convenience of their parents. A key assurance to parents is that students passing Class X through the NIOS Project will be eligible to return to their parent school for Class XI. The order says parents should be convinced that “after passing class Tenth through NIOS Project, the students are eligible to be enrolled in their Parent School for Class XI”.

• ORGANISED GANG, POLICE SAID, MASTERED THE ART OF MONETISING LONELINESS

‘Panic is biggest weapon’: How a gang in Delhi turned Tinder dates into traps

From fake profiles to fake police raids, this gang turned dating apps into a nightmare for the people using them. Here is how they operated

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, June 13

ON A warm night in the first week of May, a 45-year-old married man was scrolling through Tinder when a woman’s profile caught his eye. Her name was ‘Kriti’ and she was based out of Delhi. Her pictures looked genuine. Her profile was sparse but seemed believable; she was interested in music, travel and meaningful conversations.

The man swiped right. Moments later, they matched. The two hit it off immediately. For days, they exchanged messages, often late into the night. They spoke about work, family pressures and loneliness.

By the time they agreed to meet on May 10 at an eatery in Janakpuri, the man believed he was meeting someone he had come to know and trust. What he did not know was that ‘Kriti’ did not exist.

He walked into a carefully planned extortion trap run by an organised gang that, police said, had mastered the art of monetising loneliness using dating platforms.

Manufacturing trust

Police said the gang operated on emotional grooming.

The six-member group, including two women, created multiple fake profiles on dating platforms such as Tinder and QuackQuack. Then, they identified their targets and started chatting. The objective, police said, was to build familiarity.

Most of the conversations, investigators found, were not even conducted by women. Instead, male members of the gang posed as women online.

Inspector Pawan Kumar explained, “The first interaction would begin online, usually through fake female profiles operated by male members of the gang. They would spend days chatting with targets, gaining their confidence and persuading them to meet in person.”

The accused discussed family issues, personal struggles and everyday frustrations. Inspector Kumar said there was no rigid script; the men adapted to whatever emotional need the target appeared to have.

By the time meetings were arranged, victims believed they

were meeting someone they already knew.

The gang required an actual woman only during the final in-person meeting, DCP Pankaj Kumar said. Police said her role was limited but crucial: meet the target in a public place, establish legitimacy and then persuade him to accompany her to a nearby rented accommodation. “The woman would only enter the picture during the final stage; on the day of the physical meeting,” added Inspector Pawan. “The gang had only one intention, to make sure the victim agrees to meet — whether in a public place or elsewhere — and extort money.”

Walking into a trap

Back at the Janakpuri eatery, the 45-year-old man and Kriti were talking when she told him that she had forgotten an important medicine at her home nearby and needed to collect it.

The man initially refused to accompany her, police said, but eventually gave in after she repeatedly insisted that the medicine was essential. She then led him to a nearby rented accom-

modation. According to police, minutes after the pair entered the accommodation, three men burst in. One was dressed in a police uniform, the others pretended to be his associates.

They accused the man of sexually exploiting the woman and threatened him with jail time. Before he could process what was happening, he was forced into his vehicle and driven across multiple locations in Delhi and NCR. Investigators said the constant movement was deliberately meant to exhaust, intimidate and psychologically break the victim — and to make police tracking more difficult.

At one point, the accused took him outside DDU hospital and spoke about getting his ‘medical examination’ conducted as part of a police procedure. They allegedly took his Aadhaar card and even got medical-related paperwork prepared to make the threat appear authentic.

What made the operation particularly effective, police said, was the extent to which the gang recreated the atmosphere of an actual police investigation. “It was a well rehearsed show

like a real investigation,” Inspector Pawan said. He added that the victim was made to believe that an actual criminal case had been registered against him, would panic instantly, and comply without resistance.

Only then came the demand for money. The gang then allegedly pressured the man to arrange money immediately in order to ‘settle’ the matter. Police said the accused eventually took the victim towards Gurgaon and forced him to withdraw cash from ATMs.

The bust
Unbeknownst to the gang, the police were already on their tail.

Investigators had already begun receiving inputs about a possible online dating extortion racket operating in parts of West Delhi. Officers laid a trap on May 10 and began tracking the gang’s movements.

The operation eventually culminated near a jewellery shop in Gurgaon where police intercepted the vehicle in which the accused and the 45-year-old victim were present. Four men were arrested.

Deepak was apprehended on the spot. The others — Sushil,

Neeraj and Vinod — managed to flee initially, police said, but were arrested within the next five to six hours following raids conducted at multiple locations.

During questioning, police said, the men revealed their roles within the operation. Sushil allegedly posed as a police officer during the extortion scenes. Neeraj would assist in intimidating and handling victims while Deepak and Vinod allegedly operated the fake dating profiles.

During analysis of the phones and WhatsApp chats, police found contact details and conversations linked to at least 40 individuals. An officer said, “The main motive of the gang members was to ensure the victim moves from the dating app to chatting on WhatsApp... The accused did not even speak proper English and made multiple grammatical errors too. So, some people did not end up meeting them, while some still continued chatting.”

Police said such gangs exploit anonymity, loneliness and the promise of companionship to lure victims into extortion schemes.

Police officers said the gangs rely less on violence and more on psychological pressure.

“The biggest weapon in these cases is panic,” an officer involved in the investigation said. “Once victims believe they are trapped in a criminal case invol-

ving a woman, many become willing to pay immediately just to avoid public humiliation.”

Victims stay silent

The biggest challenge, officers said, is that many victims never report such crimes.

Officers said they contacted around 10 to 12 of the 40 individuals whose conversations they found. Most admitted they had chatted with women and were persuaded to meet, but claimed they never actually went through with the meetings.

Police said most of them looked for a physical relationship, but some just wanted a companion to talk to. Many of the men also said they did not want to come forward because of fear, embarrassment and social stigma — particularly in cases involving married men.

The fear of exposure often proved more powerful than the financial loss itself. “Our team has been constantly on calls with several victims but most of them refused to come forward. Some of the victims said they were okay spending a lakh or two rather than approaching the police,” said Inspector Pawan.

The police recounted two cases. “One of the victims; a sexagenarian who ended up paying the alleged accused, agreed to come forward after multiple attempts. But he had several conditions,” said Inspec-

tor Pawan.

An official who spoke to the victim stated that he asked them not to come home or call him for questioning without intimidating him. The victim even asked the police to not send a summons or notice on WhatsApp as his wife might come to know.

“The second victim was a little over 60, with his children settled out of the city. His wife suffered from medical issues. When we spoke to him, he said he did not have anyone to talk to as his children don’t call much, he did not have anyone to go out with for a meal. So he went on the application and became friends with one of the alleged accused,” the official added.

In his case, police said, all he was looking was for some companionship.

Officials added that the accused men threatened him and asked him to pay up. “In this case too, the victim was ready to pay up rather than risk exposure. They took his debit card but since it did not have much cash, they forced him to ask someone to transfer and then let him go. They never returned the debit card,” an official said.

For investigators, the challenge now is determining how many people may have been targeted before the gang was intercepted. Police suspect the actual number could be significantly higher.



At the site of the blaze. FILE

mother Sushila Devi (70). Pankaj’s younger sister Moni (18) and mother Guddi (50) are being treated for injuries.

Police said that initial inquiry suggests that an electrical short circuit on the ground floor may have triggered the fire. The flames subsequently engulfed several parked vehicles. However, officers said the exact cause of the blaze will be established only after a detailed investigation.

According to the police, a PCR call regarding the blaze was received at Govindpuri police station around 2.24 am on Friday. The fire quickly spread through the building, trapping several residents inside due to heavy smoke.

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— Narendra Modi
Prime Minister

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‘Canada offers range of energy options to India... after 2 yrs of tension, working methods better known to each other’

Visas have been an irritant, we need to do better... want to ensure people don't feel this was a painful process, says Cooter

IT'S BEEN almost a year since India and Canada hit reset and announced their new envoys after relations plummeted in 2023 over then PM Justin Trudeau's allegation of "potential" involvement of Indian government agents in the killing of Canada-based Khalistan separatist Hardeep Singh Nijjar—a charge that India rejected as "absurd" and "motivated".

PM Narendra Modi and his Canadian counterpart Mark Carney met at the G7 leaders' Summit in Kananaskis in June 2025, marking the beginning of the restoration of ties. As PM Modi heads to France for the G7 leaders' Summit next week where he is expected to hold talks with PM Carney, Canadian High Commissioner to India, **Christopher Cooter**, sat down for a wide-ranging interview to Shubhajit Roy, where he talked about the transformation in ties, security concerns due to Khalistan elements, cooperation in energy, defence, uranium supply, the West Asia war, and the changes he observed after returning to India where he was posted from 1997 to 2000 as a diplomat. Edited excerpts:

How did the transformation happen after PM Carney assumed office?

First, PM Carney leads a government focused on pragmatic relations with other countries. From the time he was first elected and came into office in March 2025, unexpected pressure came from the US on our economy. For 80-odd years with the US, we've had a very advanced relationship. And to have that challenged so directly, I think pushed the Canadian government into looking around where we can find other reliable partners.

And so a real push for diversification began in early 2025 and as the PM has said, India is the breakout country, particularly in the Indo-Pacific.

Second, a decision was taken to move the relationship forward. We had two years of trouble, tension, and he was determined to rectify that situation and move us forward in the relationship with India. India is an extremely important country for Canada and has been for decades. We've had our ups and downs, not only the last couple of years, but even when I was posted here in the 1990s. And I think he is committed to putting

this relationship back on track. And so the two Prime Ministers met. The Prime Minister invited Prime Minister Modi to Kananaskis G7 summit back in June last year. The two saw very much eye to eye... that we both needed to go forward together. And so it was agreed at that time that the two countries would appoint their two High Commissioners, myself and Dinesh Patnaik, to resume the relationship in September. Since then, when we both arrived, things have gone much faster than we expected. Both sides have had an accelerating commitment to an improvement in the relationship.

I want to ask about the security cooperation since the concerns of security have been there from pro-Khalistan as well as criminal groups, which the Indian government has mentioned several times. How are you tackling those concerns?

I think a lot of progress has been made in dealing with that. And the main thing that has been accomplished is the establishment of trust between the relevant agencies. So that really took off when after I arrived here, not long a very senior delegation of our security officials, led by the national security and intelligence advisor, came and met the Indian counterparts, and had a very frank discussion. It was followed by discussions virtually between the two sides over the next few months. In January, NSA (Ajit Doval) came to Canada with a delegation. And so essentially, they have established a kind of a regular dialogue, institutionalizing that discussion. Now, the outcome is they know each other better. Their working methods are better known to each other, the way in which we approach an issue versus the way India approaches it. Very practical things, but we made a lot of progress over the last eight months. I think that's just going to continue as the temperature of the relationship, that part of that relationship, which was very tense, that's moved on, and I think we're now in a much better place. There will be bumps in the road. But we've got mechanisms which will allow us to deal with things in a more professional manner.

What is the status of the



EXPRESS
interview

CHRISTOPHER COOTER
CANADIAN HIGH COMMISSIONER TO INDIA

investigations and the trial in the Nijjar case which had disrupted the relationship?

That's within the judicial process in Canada. So it's going through those stages and, and that's really all I can say about that at this point.

One of the fallouts of the disruption in the relationship was the issue of visas of students and travellers, because there's a huge Indian diaspora in Canada. What is the status of that?

On the question of immigration and visas, there has been a slowing down in the last couple of years. A lot of people came to Canada. We didn't really have housing. And for those seeking education in Canada, there were some institutions that were taking advantage of them. A lot of work has been done to clean that up. In doing so, they imposed some limits on how many students would come in. I think there was a wrong impression given in India that Canada somehow wasn't welcome. This is not the case. And the PM himself said several times when he came here, Canada is proud to host 400,000 Indian students. That's about 1% of our population, and that represents more students that are hosted by the EU, UK and Australia. It's more than the US has... And in fact, those caps are not filled. There's quite a bit of space between the cap and the number of students we're actually receiving.

So it's actually a good time to apply for an education in Canada, which is still, from a price perspective, excellent value. And Indian students are very highly regarded. We've had 26 Canadian university presidents come to India in the eight months or so... We understand that visas have been an irritant, not just that the numbers were lower or seemed to be lower, but also that it's difficult and slow. So one of the outcomes of all these visits is we have been told in no uncertain terms by Indians, students, businesses and others

that we need to reform this. We need to do better at visas. We've taken that on board. I don't know where that stands right now back home in Ottawa, but I know people are looking at that very seriously. We want to make sure the experience of someone applying for a visa... that they don't feel this was a painful process. It should be a fair process.

When PM Carney visited India early this year, the defence dialogue was established. What are the sectors of cooperation being looked at?

Our defence sector at home is ramping up rapidly. We've established a defence procurement office, etc, so we're just working that out, which will undoubtedly lead to some kind of commercial links we don't have now. We do have a small defence footprint in India and we have quite a large defence industry in Canada, but overlooked because it's been historically quite integrated with the US. But we're looking to diversify that and do it rapidly. So I expect something coming out of the dialogue in private sector or commercial arrangements.

We are much more interested in the Indo-Pacific than we were in the past. So the two PMs discussed cooperation in space, and we have an old MoU between ISRO and Canada Space Agency... I think we'll see a linkage between aerospace and defence.

The two sides have set a deadline for CEPA by 2026-end. What's the progress? Are you confident it can be achieved by them?

I am confident because both Prime Ministers have said it shall be done. We had a long process that ended in 2023. We didn't get very far with it. This is a fresh approach, it's intended to be comprehensive.

With the political will being there, it will get done, and I think it will be good for both sides. So I think the trade agreement will elevate. We've got so much we can do together and the comple-

mentarity of the economies is so great I don't think we're going to let this opportunity go.

And what about the uranium deal for long-term uranium supply. India and Canada have been discussing this for at least a decade, are we going to see the uranium supply again?

Yes, so it's not entirely new. With a shipment many years ago, we have an agreement, a nuclear agreement that goes back to 2015, we can proceed with this. Canada is a logical partner, because we have a very sizable amount of uranium. We have a lot of technology. We have the first SMR coming online in the near future. We have engineering companies that are experts in this field. So there's a lot we can do beyond just the uranium itself.

When you're talking about critical minerals, we're talking about mining, energy infrastructure, and it does take a significant understanding of the path ahead. PM Carney said in his Davos speech that most of the countries are not very happy with economic coercion. They don't want to be told you have to buy from this country or you can't sell to that country. So when it comes to things like critical minerals, Canada offers a lot of options, and we know other countries have weaponised their source of critical minerals.

Does the war in West Asia make a case for a stronger India-Canada cooperation?

Absolutely, I think let's hope it ends tomorrow. Let's hope it ends today. No more casualties, stability returns. And undoubtedly, the Gulf countries would then resume their supply of LNG, LPG... But I think in Canada we offer something that would be more reliable and stable.

So the Indian demand for energy, 35% of all growth in energy demands over the next few years will come from India. We happen to be an energy superpower. Canada has the fourth largest oil reserves in the world, the fifth largest in LNG, fifth largest in LPG, the second or third largest in uranium. It's number two in hydro. It's doing a carbon capture. It has fuel cell technology. We're the only G7 country producing batteries for EVs from indigenous materials. Canada has this huge range of energy options that are available now to India.

Maybe we won't be more than 5% or 10% of your supply, but that's enough to remove that shortage, which puts pressure on the price because of the near-closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

It's also beyond fuel, it's also fertilizer which has affected urea

supply. We produce urea in Canada. We have a lot of LNG for which urea is produced. But we also produce potash. We do supply some potash to you. We would love to supply more. We would give you another source of supply on fertilizer, because India's fertilizer demands are large and growing.

So those are two areas that the Gulf war has really highlighted... Canada is saying we offer you a partnership that is solid and reliable...

India has had a very complicated relationship with China and your PM was recently in Beijing. How do you view China's rise and its approach in the Indo-Pacific, especially because Canada also came out with this Indo-Pacific strategy?

So, we've also had a complicated relationship with China. And I think the primary answer is, of course, China is going to be a huge player, not just in the Indo-Pacific, but globally... we will be adapting to that continuously. What we don't want, however, is to be too dependent on China, both for supplies of certain things or as a market. And that drives us again to think about India as a major alternative to China. And we want to make sure Canada is diversifying more towards India. And while having a strong relationship with China, it'll be a different kind of relationship. We're also democracies or members of the Commonwealth. We have a large diaspora in Canada... we respect China. We want to have a good relationship with China. The PM was just there, but it will be qualitatively different with India and at the same time, the relationship will also expand. We have set 2030 for doubling trade. But I think we can be much more ambitious than that.

You were posted here 26 years ago as a diplomat. What has been the biggest change you saw after returning here?

There are obviously physical changes. Cities are bigger and that kind of thing, but the biggest change is actually the attitude. In the 1990s, you were just coming out of the license raj. Your economy was still highly protectionist and closed. When I arrived in 1997, there was a kind of defensive attitude as well. That's gone now. Now, India is very open to the world. You had the G20 Summit... The confidence Indians have now wasn't there 26 years ago. It's a very nice confidence, not hubristic. Actually, we would like India to be more engaged in the world and take on a bigger role.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi departs for the six-day visit to France and Slovakia, Saturday. PTI

Modi in France: Tech, innovation to dominate bilateral agenda

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 13

E. EXPLAINED

Focus on new partnerships

PM Narendra Modi's participation in Bharat Innovates at Nice and Vivatex Summit at Evian in France will spotlight India as a global hub for innovation, digital transformation and entrepreneurship, and is expected to catalyse new partnerships between Indian and European technology ecosystems.

to our discussions on pressing global issues of mutual interest as well."

Additional Secretary (Europe West), MEA, Piyush Srivastava said: "Bharat Innovates is a landmark initiative that showcases India's innovation journey to a global audience, our startup ecosystem, deep tech startups, our digital public infrastructure, our advances in defence space and clean energy, and contributions of Indian talent to global technology. The PM's presence with President Macron at this event is itself a significant symbol of the depth of bilateral relationship in the domain of technology and innovation. Especially this year, which we are also celebrating as India-France Year of Innovation."

French diplomatic sources said about a dozen pacts and outcomes are expected to be signed and announced, with a focus on innovation, science and technology, economy, cultural and people-to-people ties.

In Evian, PM Modi will participate in the G7 Summit on June 16-17. "This is the 8th consecutive G7 Summit to which India has been invited. At the G7, India will not only speak for itself, but it will also give voice to the aspirations of the Global South," Modi said in his statement. The PM will visit Paris on June 18, where alongside President Macron he will attend the VivaTech Summit, Europe's largest tech and startup event.

Rahul to kickstart Cong anti-paper leak protest from Kota on June 17

New Delhi: The Congress on Saturday announced that Lok Sabha LoP Rahul Gandhi will lead "large student conventions" starting with Kota (June 17), Prayagraj (July 10), Patna (July 11) and Delhi (July 14), bringing together students, aspirants, youth organisations, educators and all those directly affected by "examination scandals".

The conventions, Congress said, were part of a national campaign against paper leaks, exam irregularities, unemployment and issues concerning youths.

Congress has announced the first phase of a nationwide campaign against the crisis of paper leaks, exam irregularities, unemployment and systematic betrayal of youth by Modi government, said the party, in a statement by Congress general secretary (organisation) KC Venugopal. The campaign, the party said, will highlight hardships of youth whose futures are being jeopardised by paper leaks, rising exam costs and government's failure to ensure a fair recruitment and education system.

• WHILE SOME ARE CONCERNED THAT ASSOCIATION WITH TMC REBELS COULD HURT THE PARTY'S IMAGE, OTHERS WORRY ABOUT LEFT'S REVIVAL

For BJP, TMC's collapse brings gains, but some see need for caution

CAPITAL CONTEXT
BY LIZ MATHEW

A WEEKLY LOOK AT POLITICS IN A STATE FROM THE VANTAGE POINT OF NEW DELHI

FOR THE BJP, the advantages of TMC collapse are many. The primary one is the edge that it will get in Parliament as the third-largest Opposition party fragments, bolstering the chances of pushing through some of the ruling party's key legislative agenda.

However, the rapid disintegration of the TMC's legislative party in Kolkata and the parliamentary party in Delhi, and the BJP's role in this, has also created a sense of unease among many BJP leaders who view this as a strategic liability in the long run.

The concerns are chiefly two-fold. First, a section pointed out the "bad optics" of BJP's role in engineering this split. On June 8, as several TMC rebel MPs gathered for a meeting at Union Minister Bhupinder Yadav's Delhi home, West Bengal CM Suwendu Ad-



West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari leaves TMC MP Satabdi Roy's residence after meeting rebel MPs in New Delhi. EXPRESS FILE

hikari also dropped in to meet them. He met some of them again later that night at TMC MP Satabdi Roy's home.

TMC MP Kakoli Ghosh Das-tidar has told *The Indian Express* that the rebels, who claim that their strength is 20, have, as of now, decided "to be with the NDA, giving it full support". She added, "Later, we (rebel MPs) will sit together and decide what kind of support it should be." Sources in BJP said more TMC

MPs were expected to jump ship as Mamata Banerjee is in a "precarious" situation when it comes to the demand to sideline her nephew and heir apparent Abhishek. This demand has come even from the beleaguered TMC chief's loyalists.

Given that the voters have placed their faith in BJP and rejected the perceived "arrogance", alleged corruption, and the alleged high-handedness of TMC, many in the ruling party believe

any association with breakaway groups of TMC leaders will be detrimental in the long run. The fear is BJP rule may then come to be viewed as an extension of the previous regime and give rise to the perception that change has been cosmetic.

Before the revolt by the MPs, a group of 58 of TMC's 80 MLAs backed Ritabrata Banerjee, whom the organisational leadership had expelled, as the LoP in the Assembly. This was in direct opposition to the leadership's choice of Mamata confidant Sovande Chattopadhyay as the LoP. Ritabrata now claims to have the support of at least 64 MLAs and has said he is ready for a floor test next week.

"In this case, the state government has chosen the Opposition and it can decide where it should be kept. As long as they are a separate party and the BJP does not have to share power, it will be fine in the honeymoon period. But in the long run it's damaging for the party," said a senior BJP office-bearer.

Bengal BJP functionaries have expressed concerns about

admitting TMC leaders into the party. "I shed no tears for TMC's self-destruction. My only hope is that the political culture of the vandals doesn't start contaminating the W Bengal BJP. We in the BJP have to be always wary of false friends who are today cosying up to us because they need to wash away their past sins. The detox of Bengal cannot be left incomplete," Finance Minister Swapan Dasgupta posted on X on June 4, a day after Ritabrata's revolt.

As TMC MLAs first raised the banner of rebellion, BJP state chief Samik Bhattacharya also emphasised that his party's doors were closed to leaders and cadre of the Mamata-led party. "Trinamool-isation of BJP will never happen. Our doors are closed to the TMC. We reached the number 208 without importing anyone. People voted against TMC leaders. Our strategy this time started from the grassroots. How can we include those who are tainted?" he said.

"It is an all-India problem for BJP," said the BJP functionary. "We wanted a Congress-mukt Bharat (Congress-free India), but

now BJP is becoming Congress or Opposition-yukt party (party that has inducted Congress or Opposition leaders)."

Such leaders are concerned that weakening Opposition parties by breaking them and inducting their leaders because of short-term electoral gains may create deep vulnerabilities in the long run and change the foundational culture of the BJP, a cadre-based party that emphasises discipline.

Left's revival

The second concern about TMC's collapse is the vacuum may provide the right conditions for the Left's revival. The BJP leadership is conscious of the support the Mamata-led party still enjoys — its vote share was 40.8%, about 5 percentage points behind the ruling party — and if it fragments, a major chunk could move towards the CPI(M), giving it a fresh lease of life. In this election, the CPI(M) received a mere 4.45% of the votes.

At least three leaders, including an MP and an MLA from the state, said TMC should not dis-

appear as BJP would find it easier to manage it than a strengthened Left. "It (TMC) is a party without an ideology. It is easier for BJP to deal with such parties. But a vacuum in the Opposition space could revive the Left parties," said one of the leaders. He also wondered how the Adhikari government would act against the "corrupt and criminals" from the TMC years if most of its leaders come over to the BJP's side.

However, another leader ruled out the Left's revival. "The Left becoming an alternative is not possible as it has no relevance in today's politics."

Even if that does not come to pass, a section of BJP is maintaining a close watch on Mamata's attempts to rally the INDIA bloc and use the Opposition bloc to get her party back on its feet. The coming together of Mamata-led TMC, the Congress, and the Left could, in theory, pose a tough challenge to the BJP in the future. But it appears to be a long shot as of now given the deep divide that exists between the Opposition parties on the ground in Bengal.

LAND EXTORTION CASE

Raids at Abhishek home in search of bodyguard; ‘political vendetta’: TMC

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, June 13

HIGH DRAMA unfolded at Trinamool Congress (TMC) MP Abhishek Banerjee’s residence in Kolkata early Saturday after police teams and central forces arrived at the spot to search the premises in connection to a land extortion case allegedly linked to his bodyguard Sumit Roy.

The gates to the premises were locked and had to be opened using a gas cutter. The search continued for over two hours before police, sources said. “Nothing was found,” a senior police officer said.

According to sources, police were looking for Roy, who is allegedly linked to a land extortion case registered at Salboni police station. Officers, who had been tracking his movements for the past few days, allegedly traced his phone location to Abhishek Banerjee’s residence.

Around 3 am, a team of officials from Salboni police station in West Midnapore—led by a deputy superintendent of

police and assisted by local police and central forces—reached Abhishek’s Patuapara residence, Kalighat police sources said.

They called out to Banerjee’s security to open the gates, which were locked from inside. When repeated knocks went unanswered, a gas cutter was brought in nearly two hours later and the locks were cut with assistance from state Disaster Management Department officials. The entire operation was recorded on video.

As news of the search operation spread, former West Bengal chief minister and TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee arrived at the spot.

Speaking to reporters later, Abhishek said, “Yes, they broke the lock and searched the entire premises. Everything is on record.” Asked if Roy was at the residence, he said, “You should ask police who searched my house thoroughly. I am not their spokesperson.”

The TMC reacted sharply to the police action. In a post on X, the party said, “Political vendetta gets from bad to worse.”

Rahul draws fire from Pinarayi over remarks at INDIA bloc meet

Manoj CG
New Delhi, June 13



LoP Rahul Gandhi. FILE

LESS THAN a week after the leadership of the INDIA bloc met and decided to reinvigorate their alliance, fresh rifts surfaced in the Opposition coalition Saturday with its key constituent CPI(M) taking potshots at top Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, saying his political approach does not strengthen the bloc and often ends up helping the BJP.

Days before the INDIA alliance’s June 8 meeting, CPI(M) general secretary MA Baby had written to Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, conveying his party’s strong displeasure over the attacks made during the recent Kerala Assembly elections by Gandhi and other senior Congress national leaders on the then chief minister and CPI(M) stalwart Pinarayi Vijayan.

This issue was also raised by CPI(M) leader John Brittas, a Rajya Sabha MP, at the meeting.

The fresh attack by the CPI(M) came a day after the Congress on Friday released the audio and text of Gandhi’s address to the INDIA bloc meeting.

According to sources, some of its constituents, including the Samajwadi Party and the RJD

besides the CPI(M), had questioned the Congress’s style of functioning, including its decision to break up with the DMK following Tamil Nadu elections, at the closed-door meeting.

In his speech concluding the meeting, Gandhi, who is also the Leader of the Opposition (LoP) in the Lok Sabha, said, “It is not my place to answer any of the things that were said today about the Congress party. It is my place to — like in the Shaiva tradition — swallow everything. The idea of the blue-necked One (Shiva) who drinks all the poison. Whatever more you want to say, whatever criticism you have of me or Congress party, we will accept it, and we will accept it happily, with a smile on our face. We will try to make you happy,

because our role is fundamentally different from yours. I do not say this with arrogance. Our role, as many of you have stated, is to unite all of you together with love and affection.”

Gandhi, according to the text released by the Congress, went on to say: “Get rid of the notion that we are not coordinated and do not act together. These are all ideas the BJP is putting out. This is not true. I am 100% sure, and I can vouch right now for the DMK. When it comes to defending the idea of India, every single person will be in this room. We have our fights, but if you are asking me to go and hug the ex-chief minister of Kerala. I cannot and I will not, because I have an ongoing political fight with him. So we have to be flexible and we have to realise that there is a full-scale assault on us, trying to prove the Opposition is weak.”

Hitting back at Rahul Saturday, Vijayan said hugging is not a common phenomenon in politics. “It is rare for people to hug each other. When I and Rahul Gandhi meet, we generally greet each other or shake hands. But we all saw the photograph of Rahul Gandhi hugging Narendra Modi. I don’t have any problem with him

hugging Modi. But, what he said (at the INDIA bloc meeting) was portraying it in a different way. It reflects Rahul Gandhi’s style of talking, how he sees the INDIA bloc.”

Vijayan also said, “The situation in which the INDIA bloc finds itself today, because of that situation, it is not only us, but Akhilesh Yadav, Tejashwi Yadav and other major non-Congress parties, they also spoke against the Congress position (at the meeting). We know where the DMK stands now. All this is because of the Congress’s approach and particularly because of Rahul Gandhi’s approach. The reality is that this approach does not strengthen the INDIA alliance. It often ends up helping the BJP. Through such actions, Rahul Gandhi often ends up becoming an aid of the BJP.”

CPI(M) chief Baby, too, slammed Rahul. “Nobody is asking Rahul Gandhi to hug Pinarayi Vijayan. On the contrary, all that we are asking is that he stop being a facilitator for the ED and the Modi government by demanding the arrest of Pinarayi Vijayan and other Opposition leaders. That is not the job of the Leader of the Opposition,” he said.

Devaswom special pleader resigns after CM seeks his exit over link to Sabarimala case

Express News Service
Thiruvananthapuram, June 13

IN AN embarrassment for the V D Satheesan government, the Kerala Cabinet’s pick as special pleader for the Devaswom Department, Advocate K B Pradeep, turned out to be a lawyer who had previously appeared for an accused in the Sabarimala temple gold theft case.

As the state government faced protests and allegations that the appointment was meant to undermine the Sabarimala probe, Chief Minister Satheesan sought Pradeep’s resignation on Saturday, three days after the appointment. Pradeep stepped down from the post following the CM’s order. Satheesan also handles the law portfolio. Sources at CMO said Pradeep’s appointment resulted from an oversight in the vetting process.

The Sabarimala temple is under the Devaswom Department. Pradeep had appeared for Chennai-based Smart Creations, which had been accused of removing gold from the temple items entrusted to them for electroplating by key accused Unnikrishnan Potty. Its CEO had been arrested in the case.

Senior Congress leader and Devaswom Minister K Muraleedharan told the media on Saturday that Pradeep’s appointment had upset the devotees, who raised doubts about the fate of the cases pertaining to Sabarimala gold theft. Hence, the CM sought his resignation, he said.

Earlier, Muraleedharan had told mediapersons that he was not privy to Pradeep’s appointment and it was the decision of the Chief Minister.

Attacking the Congress-led UDF government, Leader of Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan said strange things are happening with regard to the Devaswom Department’s counsel’s appointment. “Appointing the lawyer of the accused as Devaswom special counsel is tanta-

“Appointing the lawyer of the accused as Devaswom special counsel is tantamount to helping the accused. Minister Muraleedharan alleged that the CM had personally created a non-existent post to facilitate the appointment.”

PINARAYI VIJAYAN,
LEADER OF OPPOSITION

mount to helping the accused. Minister Muraleedharan alleged that the Chief Minister had personally created a non-existent post to facilitate the appointment,” said Vijayan.

Senior BJP leader Kumbham Rajasekharan said the UDF government has betrayed the faithful. “The appointment is a challenge to the faithful. Although the lawyer has quit, the mystery engulfing his appointment lingers. The truth behind the appointment should be brought out. The Chief Minister and the Devaswom Minister should tender an apology to the faithful,” he said.

The controversy comes close on the heels of allegations of nepotism against the Satheesan government over the appointment of ministers’ personal staff. KPCC president and Electricity Minister Sunny Joseph appointed his brother-in-law Benny Thomas as an additional private secretary. Sunny justified the recruitment saying Benny was one of the general secretaries of the District Congress Committee in Kannur.

However, last week, Benny was forced to step down following resentment from within the Congress. The Opposition CPI(M) had turned the issue into a launch pad of agitation against the Congress government.

UP govt forms SIT to probe allegations of Ram Temple donation misappropriation

Maulshree Seth
Lucknow, June 13

THE UTTAR Pradesh government on Saturday constituted a three-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) to probe allegations of irregularities and misappropriation of donation funds in works related to the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Temple in Ayodhya.

The committee has been directed to submit a preliminary report in seven days and a final report within 15 days, the officials said.

According to officials, the SIT was formed following a request from the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust itself, after allegations re-

lated to the handling and utilisation of funds gained traction in the recent weeks.

The Trust is learnt to have sought an independent inquiry to establish facts and address concerns arising from the accusations. The SIT will be headed by Lucknow Divisional Commissioner Vijay Vishwas Pant with Inspector General of Police (IGP) Kiran S and Special Secretary (Finance Department) Neel Ratan as members.

The development comes less than a week after Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav raised the issue and demanded judicial intervention into reports alleging that crores of rupees from donations made to the Ram Temple had gone missing.

In a post on social media platform X, Yadav had termed the reports “a matter of grave concern for devotees across the world” and described the alleged disappearance of donation funds as “extremely shameful” for the temple trust.

He had sought suo motu cognisance by the judiciary, saying the issue was directly linked to the faith of the global Hindu community, while questioning the government’s silence over the allegations.

The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust had, however, rejected the allegations at the time.

Trust general secretary Champat Rai had stated periodic internal audits were con-

ducted by the Trust as well as the State Bank of India and that no significant irregularity had been detected. He had said the audit process, which was currently underway, had so far not revealed anything noteworthy.

The controversy subsequently escalated, with former BJP MP Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh claiming he was aware of alleged misuse of donations but declining to reveal details, and senior BJP leader Rajneesh Singh writing to Prime Minister Narendra Modi seeking public disclosure of the trust’s finances, assets, donations, expenditures, bank accounts and land transactions.

Rajneesh Singh said devotees who had contributed to the

construction of the temple had a right to know how donations, including cash, ornaments and other valuables, were being utilised.

Responding to the controversy, Uttar Pradesh minister Surya Pratap Shahi had said the trust had already initiated an inquiry and would take action in accordance with its rules and regulations, while maintaining that the matter primarily fell within the trust’s jurisdiction.

Uttar Pradesh Congress chief Ajay Rai also demanded an independent probe headed by a sitting high court judge.

PTI reported that “one of the members of the SIT declined to comment on the scope or timeline of the inquiry. “Any task

that is assigned to us by the government will be carried out. Beyond this, I have nothing to say,” he said.

Meanwhile, Nripendra Mishra, chairman of the Ram Temple Construction Committee, was in Ayodhya on Friday for a meeting to review the progress of the temple project and remaining works.

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, Mishra said the meeting was unrelated to the controversy over the alleged fund misappropriation and was convened to review the final handover of completed structures by Larsen & Toubro (L&T) and assess the status of the remaining works, which are in their final stages.

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Classifieds

PERSONAL

I, Yasmeen Khatoon W/o Aftab Alam R/O RC-371, Sangam Park, Khora Colony, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201001, have changed my name from Yasmeen Khatoon To Yasamin Khatun. Henceforth I would be known by the name of Yasamin Khatun for all future purposes.

0071042014-1

I Himanshu Khandaka D/o Shree Kumar Khandaka and W/o Ashish Kumar Bansal R/o Rp-32, Pitam Pura, Pitampura, Saraswati Vihar, North West Delhi, Delhi - 110034, have changed my name to Himanshi Khandaka Bansal. 0071042034-1

I PRAVEEN KUMAR S/o Prem Kumar R/o 2/199, Block-2, Trilokpuri, Delhi - 110091 changed name to DHRUV SHAH vide affidavit dated 09/06/2026 Delhi. 0050291209-1

I Rakesh Bansal S/o Pawan Kumar Bansal R/o 70-71, Third Floor, Pocket-8, Sector-23, Rohini, Delhi-110085 declare that Rakesh Bansal Pawan, Rakesh Bansal P, and Rakesh Bansal are the names of one and the same person. I shall henceforth be known only as Rakesh Bansal for all purposes.

0040860562-1

I, ANJU BALA @ ANJU BANSAL C/o Vijay Kumar, A-14, UGF, Jawahar Park, Devli Road, Khanpur, Delhi-80 have changed my name to ANJU.

0071041949-1

I, Amarpal Singh Yadav S/o Shri Harsaran Singh R/o Village Basai Brauddin Nagar, Sector-70, District- Gautam Buddha Nagar, UP -201301, have changed my name to Amarpal

0071041950-1

I, Ansar Ahmed Ansari, S/o Mohammad Raza Ansari R/o. G-53/14, First Floor, Batla House, Sir Syed Road, Jamia Nagar, New Delhi-110025, have changed my name Ansar Ahmad to Ansar Ahmed Ansari permanently.

0040860499-1

I,CHAUDHRI VINODKUMAR RAMBACHAN,S/O- RAMBACHAN CHAUDHRI/R-O- CHITARGAUDHIYA,DUBAULI-DUBEY,RATAS URF KAPTANGANJ, DASTI, U:P-272131, have changed my name to VINODKUMAR RAMBACHAN CHAUDHRI.

0040860559-10

It is,for general information,that I,KM ILMMA NAZ,w/o-Syed Mohd Imaad,D/o-Rahisuddin residing,at H.No.1823,Gali Mohamaddin,Elaichi Wali,Turkman Gate,Delhi-110006,declare that,has change,my name to ILMMA NAAZ,for all purpose. It is,certified that I,have complied,with other,legal requirements in this connection.

0040860563-7

I,Virendra Nagar,S/o-Ramprakash Nagar,R/o-H.No-369,Achheja,Achheja,Gautam Budh Nagar,U.P,have changed my minor's son name Vansh to Vansh Chaudhary.

0040860559-6

I,Vidhiyansh Raj Gupta,S/o-Shambhu Kumar Gupta,R/o-K-2,Leela-Homes, Sector-4,Vaishali,Ghaziabad-201010,h have changed my name to Vidyansh Raj Gupta.

0040860559-4

I,Tej Vir S/o-Chhatar Singh,R/o-House No.478/22,Block-C,Sangam-Vihar, Delhi-110062,have changed my-name to Tejveer Singh.

0040860563-6

I,Shambhu Kumar,S/o-Arjun Prasad Gupta,R/o K-2,Leela Homes,Sector-4, Vaishali, Ghaziabad-201010,have changed my name to Shambhu Kumar Gupta.

0040860559-5

I,SAROJINI,W/o-VIPUL SHARMA,R/o-75,second Floor,Near-Aakash Hospital,sector-3,Karuna KUNJ,Dwarka sector-3,South West,DELHI-110075,have changed my name to SAROJINI VATS Permanently.

0040860563-1

I,SALOCHNA DEVI JAIN alias SALOCHNA JAIN W/o Pawan Kumar R/O-UP-93 FF, Pitampura Delhi-110034,have changed my name to SULOCHNA JAIN.

0040860559-12

I,Rekha W/o Virendra Nagar R/o Achchheja, Dadri, Gautam Budh Nagar, have changed my name to Rekha Vaisla.

0040860559-7

I,Rajni Maver Spouse of GS188804K rank JE(E&M) Nitin Kumar,R/O-H.No.K-Block-14/10,Gali.No-16 West Ghonda,Bhajanpura Delhi-110053,have changed my name,from Rajani Maver to Rajni Maver vide affidavit, dated 12-June-2026, Executive Magistrate Yamuna Vihar, Delhi.

0040860559-8

I,Pramod Kumar S/o Gulab Chand R/o C-96, Sector-50, Noida,(U.P-201301) have changed my name to Pramod Kumar Gupta for all future purposes.

0040860521-1

I,PAWAN KUMAR JAIN S/o Puran Chand Jain R/o-UP-93 FF, Pitampura Delhi-110034,have changed my name to PAWAN JAIN.

0040860559-11

I,NITI d/o Rajinder Kumar,R/o-First Floor,Khasra.No-21/12/3 and-21/11/3, Street.No-11A,Block-B,Himgiri Enclave,Burari,Delhi-110084, have changed my name to Niti Rajinder Kumar.

0040860563-5

I,NAMRATA SINGH,W/O.SUNNY SINGH,R/O-D-2404,24th Floor,Tower-dD,Apex Athena,Sector-75, Noida, Gautam Budh Nagar,UTTAR PRADESH-201301, have changed my name to NAMRATA MANOJ SINGH.

0040860563-8

I,Mohammad Asjad S/o Mohd Nazim,RZ A-80-B, Pul Pahlad Pur, Badarpur, Delhi-44, have changed my name to Mohd Asjad.

0040860559-2

I,MAUSAM SINGH,W/o-SUJIT SINGH, R/O-N-419,SECTOR-25, NOIDA, GAUTAM BUDH NAGAR,UTTAR PRADESH-201301, inform that my, son's name Piyush Kumar and Piyush Singh, both names are same person. My minor son's correct name Piyush Singh,for all,future purposes.

0040860559-9

I,Shreyaa Roda W/o Jatini Kumar Roda R/o C-13/163, Sector-3, Rohini, Delhi have changed my name to Shreyaa Sharma Roda permanently.

0040860531-1

I,MANOJ KUMAR S/O-MANMOHAN SHARMA,R/O-DAMDAMA SIKANDARA RAO HATHRAS U.P.204215,have changed my name to MANOJ UPADHYAY,for all future purpose.

0040860559-1

I,GAURAV S/O SATISH KUMAR R/O-820, SECTOR-23, SONIPAT, HARYANA -131001, have changed my minor child name from BABY TWO OF RITU to UDDISH BHARDWAJ.

0040860559-3

I,DIPAK KUMAR,S/O-Ram Kumar,R/O-H.No.81A,Gali No.9,Sainik Vihar,Mohan garden Part-3,Uttam Nagar,Delhi-110059,have changed my name to DEEPAK KUMAR

0040860563-4

I,AKSHITA MUDGAL, D/o VIPUL SHARMA,R/o-75,Second Floor KARUNA KUNJ,Near-Aakash Hospital sector-3,Dawarka South West, Delhi-110075,have changed my name to AKSHITA, permanently.

0040860563-2

I, YASHIKA KAUSHIK D/O SANJEEV KUMAR R/O 148, CHANDER LOK ENCLAVE, UPPER GROUND FLOOR, DELHI-110034 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO YASHIKA KAUSHIK GUPTA FOR ALL FUTURE PURPOSES.

0071041953-1

I,Sheelu D/o Shri Amarpal Singh Yadav R/o Sector-70, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, UP-201301, have changed my name to Sheelu Yadav.

0071041951-1

I, Sapana W/o Rahul Chopra R/o :- D-84, 3rd Floor, Surajmal Vihar, Delhi - 110092, Change My Name to SAPNA CHOPRA New Name Permanently.

0040860562-2

I, Resmy A V. W/o Sh Unnikrishna Kurup D/o of Sh. Govinda Pillai Ayyappan Nair, Resident of C-61, Soochana Apartments, Vasundhara Enclave, East-Delhi, Delhi-110096, have changed my name from Resmy Unnikrishna Kurup to Resmy A V. Henceforth, I would be known by the name of Resmy A V for all future purposes.

0040860468-1

I, Rajesh Kumar S/O Ram Kumar, R/o House Number-G-71/3, Street Number-4, Brahmipuri Garhi Mendu North East Delhi Delhi - 110053, have changed my name and shall hereafter be Known as Amarjit Pal.

0071042013-1

I, Minakshi Kumari W/o Manonit Deep Samrat, resident of F1109, Officer city-2, Rajnagar Extn, Ghaziabad have Changed my name from Minakshi/Minakshi Samrat to Minakshi Kumari.

0071042038-1

I, MITA Mohila W/o Pradeep Mohila R/o House No. C-704, Plot B-9/1A, Designers Park,Sector-62, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh-201301 have changed my name to MEETA MOHILA for all purposes.

0040860466-1

I, KARAMVEER S/o Jagdish, a1, Basantpur Village, Sector-91, Faridabad, Haryana-121013, have changed my name to KARAMBIR.

0071041948-1

I, Jogendra Singh S/O Khan Singh R/o Flat.No B-1902, ACE City,Plot.No GH-01, Sector-1 Greater Noida West,Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh-201306 has changed my name from JOGENDRA SONGH to JOGINDER SINGH for all future Purposes.

0071042004-1

I, Gourav S/o Suresh R/o 107/6, Gali No.6, Prem Nagar-2, Kirari Suleman Nagar, Delhi-110086, have changed my name to Gaurav for all future purposes.

0040860483-1

I, Faheemuddin S/o Islamuddin R/o 46, 12, Taiyyaba Masjid, Zakir Nagar, Jamia Nagar, Delhi -110025 have changed my name to Mohd. Fahimuddin for all future Purposes.

071042030-1

I, Dipti W/o Raghav Bhandari R/o Flat No.3, Aravali Apartment, Alaknanda, Kalkaji, South Delhi, Delhi- 110019, have changed my name from Dipti to Dipti Bhandari. Henceforth I would be known by the name of Dipti Bhandari for all future purposes.

0071041947-1

I,LALIT S/O Om Prakash R/O Flat No-26,Antriksh apartment, Dwarka Sector-4, Delhi-110078, have changed my name to LALIT KHATRI.

0040860563-3

I,BRUEISH KUMAR S/O RAJKUMAR TYAGI R/o B-506, 5TH FLOOR, GREEN ACRES, LAVENDER ASHADEEP, ASHADEEP, NEEMRANA, ALWAR, RAJASTHAN-301705 have changed my name BRUEISH TYAGI for all future purposes.

0071042032-1

I, BABITA RANI, W/O ADESH SHARMA, R/o F57 HIM KUNJ DWARKAPURI NAVIN, SHAHDARA, SHAHDARA, EAST DELHI PIN-110032 have changed my name BABITA SHARMA for all future purposes.

0071041952-1

LOST & FOUND

We,Anil Kumar Jain And Sunil Jain,S/o Late,Shri Mahender Kumar Jain,R/o-8/300, Old Post Office Street,Chhota-Bazar,Shahdara,Delhi-32,And-1/7038,D-floor,Shivaji Park,Shahdara,Delhi-32,have lost original-documents of our property No.8/340,old no.300,old post-office street,Shahdara,Delhi-32,Relinguishment Deed-Duly Regd. As Doc.

No.2026/18/1/1260,In Book No.1.Vol. No.6243,On Pages-107 To 118 On-Dated 12/02/2026 In The Office Of S.R.IV-B,Vivek-Vihar,Delhi,on the way on-01/05/2026 from above said address,LOST REPORT,LR.No-365240/2026 dated-11.06.2026, P.S.Farsh Bazar,

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0040860565-1

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PUBLIC NOTICE

GENERAL PUBLIC IS HEREBY INFORMED THAT MY CLIENTS ANIL KUMAR GUPTA SO LATE SHRI D C GUPTA AND SMT. ASHA GUPTA W/O ANIL KUMAR GUPTA, BOTH R/O K-1, MODEL TOWN DELHI-110009 HAVE DISOWNED THEIR DAUGHTER ELIZA GUPTA FROM ALL THEIR MOVABLE AND IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES/ASSETS AND HAVE SEVERED ALL RELATIONS WITH THEM DUE TO THEIR CONTINUOUS DISOBEDIENCE AND ACTS OF OMISSION. ANYBODY DEALING WITH THEM SHALL DO SO AT HIS/HER OWN RISK AND MY CLIENTS SHALL NOT BE RESPONSIBLE FOR ANY OF THEIR ACT(S) WHATSOEVER, IN FUTURE.

Sd/- SATYENDRA KUMAR SINGH Advocate Ch. No. L-1902, T-15 Hazari Courts, Delhi-54

PUBLIC NOTICE

Under instructions from my client, Shri Manoj Kumar Bagai, S/o Late Shri Bishamber Lal Bagai, it is hereby notified that he has acquired ownership rights in respect of Property No. 62% and Shop Nos. 63-64, situated at Masjid Tehwar Khan, Naya Bans, Delhi, by virtue of the Will dated 03.06.2022, duly registered with the Sub-Registrar, Delhi, executed by his late mother, Smt. Darshana Rani. Any person(s) having any claim, right, title, interest, objection, lien, charge or encumbrance whatsoever in respect of the aforesaid property are hereby requested to intimate the undersigned Advocate in writing, along with supporting documents, within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which such claim(s), if any, shall be deemed to have been waived and no objection shall be entertained thereafter.

Sd/- Preetesh Pandey (Advocate) Chamber No. 302-A, Civil Wing, T-15 Hazari Courts, Delhi

PUBLIC NOTICE

The Public at large is hereby notified on behalf of my clients Mr Karan Singh Jaggi, S/o Sh. Kuljit Singh Jaggi and his wife Smt. Anika, both R/o J- 8/77D, Third Floor, Nehru Market, Rajouri Garden Delhi-110027 hereby declare that due to personal reasons and irreconcilable differences, My clients have severed all social, financial, and personal relations with his Elder brother Mr. Mandeep Singh Jaggi and his wife Ms. Sarmeet, both R/o H.No. J- 8/77D, Third Floor, Nehru Market, Rajouri Garden Delhi-110027. From the date of publication of this notice, I shall not be responsible for acts, deeds, liabilities, obligations or commitments made by him. Any person dealing with him shall do so at his/her own risk, cost and responsibility.

Ritesh Tanwar (Advocate) Enrol No. D/2411/2010 CB 144, Ring Road, Naraina, ND-28

PUBLIC NOTICE
General Public is hereby informed that my clients Sh. Ajit Singh S/o Sh. Mithu Singh & Smt. Radha w/o Sh. Ajit Singh R/o Plot No. 31, Second Floor, Pocket-E, Shree Shyam Apartment, Sector-82, Tikri Khurd, Near CNG Pump, Delhi-110040 has severed all their relationship and disowned their son Ravi and debarred from inhering any of movable and immovable properties of my clients. That son Ravi is not behaving properly with my clients. That my clients are not responsible in any manner of any acts, deeds and conduct of their son Ravi.
Deepak Kumar Chopra (Adv) Enrol. No.D/1266/2012

PUBLIC NOTICE
I, a publicly informed that My Client/ies Sandeep Malik S/o Late Shri Satya Prakash Malik R/o CC-31/F, 2nd Floor, G-8 Area Rajouri Garden, Hari Nagar, Delhi, hereby declare that he assigned Shri Satya Malik S/o Late Shri Satya Prakash Malik are the co-owners of LUG Flat No.CC-31/F, 2nd Floor, G-8 Area Rajouri Garden, Hari Nagar, Delhi, and my client declare that he has lost Original/Abstract/Title Possession Letter/Share Possession, NCC, Bank Chalan alongwith other West. Documents in respect of above said Flat. My Client has also lodged the necessary NCR, vide LR No.308548/2026, Dt. 12.06.2026. Any Person who may found such documents shall deliver the same at the above said address of my client. And now my client intends to retransfer the above said property. Any person who has possession of the said property, or any claim, right, title, interest, objection, lien, charge or encumbrance whatsoever in respect of the said property, shall contact either my client in writing at this address or via e-mail at: advocate@rajgauravjain@gmail.com, within Fifteen Days from the date of this Notice, failing which such objection shall be treated as null and void.
DHARMA CHARLA (Advocate)Enrol. No.028610388

"IMPORTANT"

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L.No. 715/E-Tender/79 Dated: 11.06.2026

ई-निविदा सूचना

उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम, की ओर से अद्योत्तापरी द्वारा जनपद आगरा में मानसिक स्वास्थ्य संस्थान एवं चिकित्सालय, आगरा के पी.जी. हॉस्टल के रीनोवेशन व अन्य मरम्मत एवं रखरखाव के कार्य अनुमानित लागत ₹ 163.65 लाख (जी.एस.टी. रहित एवं लेबर सेस सहित) हेतु सी. एण्ड डी. एस. के अन्तर्गत यथोचित शेषी में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से दिनांक 13.07.2026 के अपराह्न 17-00 बजे तक ई-निविदा आमन्त्रित की जाती है। उक्त कार्य हेतु ई-निविदा प्राप्त दिनांक 12.06.2026 से दिनांक 13.07.2026 के मध्य उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार की e-procurement वेबसाइट <https://etender.up.nic.in> से डाउनलोड किये जा सकने हे तथा ई-निविदा दिनांक 14.07.2026 को 14:00 बजे परियोजना प्रबन्धक, युनिट-35, सी. एण्ड डी.एस., उ.प्र. जल निगम (नगरीय), आगरा में खोली जायेगी। ई-निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य ₹10,000.00+ GST (18%) कुल ₹11,800.00 देय होगा।

निविदा से सम्बन्धित विस्तृत विवरण विभाग की वेबसाइट www.cdsupjn.org एवं प्रोक्योरमेन्ट पोर्टल <https://etender.up.nic.in> पर उपलब्ध है। समस्त शुद्ध पत्र (Corrigendum) <https://etender.up.nic.in> पर ही अपलोड किये जायेंगे, इनका एकूत्र से कोई प्रकाशन नहीं किया जायेगा। निविदादाताओं को सलाह दी जाती है कि वे उक्त वेबसाइट का समय-समय पर अवलोकन करते रहें।

DRDO demonstrates ballistic missile defence capability

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, June 13

IN A significant development earlier this week, the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) successfully tested a Multi-layered Ballistic Missile Defence (BMD) capability.

This system can engage targets including Intercontinental Ballistic Missiles (ICBMs). With this advancement, India joins an elite group of nations that possess the ability to defend against ICBMs.

The DRDO, on June 10 and 11, conducted three consecutive flight tests to demonstrate multi-layered defence against long-range ballistic missiles and anti-ship capability at medium range, the Defence Ministry said in a statement.

The Multi-layered BMD capability was successfully demonstrated during the tests, which were conducted on June 10 and 11. "The interceptors successfully engaged their respective targets. The systems



A missile during a flight test conducted by the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO). PTI

are designed and developed with the latest technologies to address the emerging missile threats," it said.

The statement highlighted that these tests have put the country in the elite group of nations having BMD capability to engage up to Intercontinental Ballistic Missiles.

The maiden flight test of the Naval Anti-Ship Missile-Medium Range (NASM-MR)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

(See Section 82 Cr PC/84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Mukesh Kumar S/o Raj Vansh R/o H.No. G-125, Tagore Gali, Jagatpuri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **GD No. 105A, Dated 09.02.2024 U/s 40A Delhi Excise Act at PS: Jagatpuri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Mukesh Kumar** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Mukesh Kumar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Mukesh Kumar of GD No. 105A Dated 09.02.2024 U/s 40A Delhi Excise Act of PS: Jagatpuri, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 14.07.2026.**
By order
Anushtha Srivastava
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05
Shahdara Distt. Room No. 07,
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/7842/SHD/2026

PUBLIC NOTICE
GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
EXCISE & TAXATION DEPARTMENT
NOTICE FOR INVITING APPLICATIONS FOR THE ALLOTMENT OF WHOLESALE LICENSES OF IMFL (L-1) AND COUNTRY LIQUOR (L-13) FOR THE POLICY YEAR 2025-27 IN ALL THE DISTRICTS OF THE STATE.

The applications are hereby invited for grant of wholesale licenses of IMFL in the form of L - 1 and wholesale licenses of Country Liquor in form of L-13 for all the excise districts in the State. The Wholesale licenses of IMFL (L-1) and Country Liquor (L-13) shall be granted to the applicant amongst the retail outlet allottees/licensees of Indian Made foreign Liquor (L-2) and Country Liquor (L-14A) respectively. The L-1 and L-13 licenses shall be granted on the basis of quota contribution of Indian Made foreign Liquor (L-2) and Country Liquor (L-14A) (of the policy year 2025-27), amongst the applicant allottees/licensees of retail zones within an Excise district. The quota contribution for the purpose of grant of L-1 & L-13 licenses shall be calculated on the basis of retail liquor zones allotted as on 16.06.2026 for receiving such applications for grant of L-1/L-13 licenses. The L-1/L-13 license(s) shall be granted only to those eligible applicants who apply for the License(s) within the date fixed/extended by the Excise and Taxation Commissioner, Haryana. The Excise Policy provides that the Excise and Taxation Commissioner may invite applications for such number of L - 1 / L - 13 licenses as he may deem fit. The Excise and Taxation Commissioner may also conduct the process of allotment in multiple rounds of inviting applications.

Sr. No.	Districts	Number of L-1 (s) to be granted	Number of L-13 (s) to be granted
1	Ambala	1	1
2	Bhiwani	1	1
3	Faridabad	3	2
4	Fatehabad	1	1
5	Gurugram (East)	3	2
6	Gurugram (West)	2	3
7	Hisar	1	1
8	Jagadhari	1	1
9	Jhajjar	2	2
10	Jind	2	2
11	Kaithal	1	1
12	Karnal	2	2
13	Kurukshetra	2	2
14	Mewat	1	1
15	Narnaul	1	1

Wisdom dawns but challenges remain



ACROSS THE AISLE
BY P CHIDAMBARAM

THE ECONOMIC situation at the close of May 2026 was quite dismal. There was a flurry of government activity at the start of June. The RBI announced a significant measure — the Fully Accessible Route (FAR) to government bonds was expanded to include new 15-year, 30-year and 40-year government bonds for investment by foreign investors. Besides, several limits and caps on foreign portfolio investors were removed. Simultaneously, the government promulgated an Ordinance to exempt foreign investors from long-term capital gains (12.5 per cent) and withholding tax (20 per cent) on sale of the bonds. RBI also allowed banks to attract FCNR (B) deposits with a generous offer to cover the hedging costs.

These are tried and tested measures. They are expected to attract more foreign currency inflows: the estimate is USD 30-40 billion — may be more — to augment the foreign exchange reserves. The depreciation of the rupee may be stemmed: the sliding rupee had become a political issue for the Hon'ble prime minister who promised in 2014 that the rupee-dollar exchange

rate will be controlled at Rs 40, much like King Canute ordering the tide to halt!

No other option

There are risks. We need not dwell on the risks now because there were no other options before the government and the RBI. The risks of doing nothing were greater. The government was in denial for many months, especially since the imposition of the Trump-tariffs, the US-Israel vs Iran war, the oil price shock, and the derailment of the supply chains. Foreign investors were wary of investing in India. The consequences were showing up in the numbers and yet the alarm bells were not ringing in the government:

● The current account deficit (CAD) was growing every month and the year 2025-26 is expected to have closed with over USD 25 billion. Adding to the worries, the estimate of the goods trade deficit for the year is USD 333 billion and the estimate of gold imports is USD 72 billion. We know where the shoe pinches.

● Net FDI was a paltry USD 6.9 billion, showing the lack of confidence of foreign investors in the prospects of the Indian economy and in the stock market. In most months of 2025-26 foreign investors in the Indian equity market were *net sellers*, reaching a high of Rs 1,17,775 crore in March 2026.

● Gross Fixed Capital Formation (GFCF) at constant prices has been stuck at 32.3 per cent since 2022-23. GFCF is more or less equally divided among the government sector, the household sector (real estate and

These are tried and tested measures. They are expected to attract more foreign currency inflows: the estimate is USD 30-40 billion — may be more — to augment the foreign exchange reserves

construction) and the private sector. Despite persuasion, cajolery, threats and investment summits, the private sector is unwilling to step up investment, especially in manufacturing. The share of manufacturing in GVA at constant prices (GDP = GVA + net taxes on goods) has been stuck at 17 per cent for many years under the NDA.

Not resilient, but fragile

The complacency was induced by the RBI's monthly bulletins and the Ministry of Finance's monthly reviews. Many knowledgeable economists pointed out that the two reports were too sanguine and hid the real picture and the potential threats. The word constantly used by the government's spokespersons was 'resilience', but experts pointed out that the word was a thin cover for 'fragility'.

The government may be tempted to stop with these measures, but that would be a huge mistake. In an interview to Marya Shakil of *India Today*, Mr Anantha Nageswaran, Chief Economic Adviser, summarised the government's current thinking. On imposing restrictions on gold imports, he evaded a direct answer, and said that he was "not aware of" any restrictions that may be imposed on gold imports. He is the chief *adviser*, he must have a *view*, and he must have rendered his *advice*. Naturally, he is reticent in public because he is aware of Mr Narendra Modi's words in 2013-14 ("FM is stealing your *mangalsutra*") when the then government had placed severe restrictions on gold imports. I am afraid the government has no choice but to throw some sand

in the wheels of gold imports.

Acknowledge challenges

Moreover, the government must acknowledge that household debt has risen (41 per cent of GDP), household financial savings have decreased (< 6 per cent of GDP), and consumption expenditure has fallen (except among the small sliver of people who buy luxury goods). The government must not believe the self-serving numbers that the MoSPI and ministries put forth on 'achievements'. It must put money in the hands of the people. There are several ways to do that: raise minimum wages to match inflation, cut taxes on consumption, scrap vanity and environmentally harmful projects like the Great Nicobar container port-cum-airport, scale up the number of educational loans, restore labour-intensive public works like MGNREGS and, unlike in 2025-26, spend the allocated funds fully on drinking water, village roads, rural development schemes and urban housing.

Government must — and prevail upon state governments to — fill the vacancies in sanctioned government posts particularly in Class III and IV, and posts of doctors, teachers, nurses, jawans in police forces and central armed police forces, workmen in the Indian Railway, etc. to which the youth of the middle classes and lower middle classes aspire.

There are *objectives* before the government that will galvanise and instill hope in the people. Mr Modi should devote his energy to pursue those objectives rather than waste his time chasing divisive, polarising and unproductive goals.

Modi's achievements and flaws



FIFTH COLUMN
BY TAVLEEN SINGH

LET ME begin by confessing that I did not think it was an 'achievement' for Narendra Modi to have become the longest serving prime minister in Indian history. And I found something puerile about the BJP 'bhakti' brigade on social media and in real life making comparisons with how long Jawaharlal Nehru served and the way they debated which year Nehru's term should be counted from. Why is this relevant? Is it just me or have you also noticed that BJP trolls and Modi's most ardent fans seem to have an inferiority complex when it comes to Nehru?

There is no reason for it. Modi's achievements as Prime Minister have been extraordinary. Not to mention that, as your columnist has mentioned before, he succeeded in throwing into the garbage bin of history the entire English-speaking ruling class that worshipped Nehru. So why go on and on and on about a prime minister who has been dead for more than sixty years? Let him finally rest in peace.

Now let us return to talking about a prime minister who is still alive. Perhaps the most significant of Modi's achievements is that since he became prime minister, his policies have lifted 250 million people out of poverty. In Nehru's case, the sad truth is that there were as many poor Indian people when he became prime minister as when his long, long rule ended.

There are other things Modi can well be proud of. When he became prime minister, India had only 93 kilometres of access-controlled expressways; today there are 3,052 kilometres of expressways. The national highway network has grown by more than 60 per cent and the number of airports has more than doubled. The number of universities went up from 760 to 1,334 and instead of just seven All India Institutes of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) we have 23 today. Rural Indians now have access to toilets, domestic gas, bank accounts and free rations. Utilities like electricity and drinking water are more available than ever before as is the Internet.

While I was making a list of these achievements I came upon an editorial in this newspaper that reminded me of the reason why despite significant successes Modi is seen by many in India and in western democracies as an autocrat and not a democrat. The editorial was about the Delhi High court's strictures against the Enforcement Directorate (ED) in the case that was brought against the news portal, NewsClick. The founding editor of this news portal spent seven months in jail because the ED charged him with non-bailable offences like money laundering and anti-national activities.

The Delhi High Court dismissed these charges and accused the Delhi police of 'a gross abuse of the process of law'. It said, 'Aside from bald assertions of there being a criminal conspiracy, there is not a whisper of any incriminating allegation'. Harsh words but hopefully they will make the Prime Minister realise that by being allergic to dissenting opinions he is doing himself a disservice. We in the media should be telling him this more often but because of what happens to journalists who dare express dissenting opinions, we have all learned to pull our punches. While watching the news channels cover Modi's big moment last week, what struck me was how they fell over themselves as they competed to sing the praises of the Prime Minister. This is not good for Indian journalism, but it is also not good for the man who guides the ship of India in these troubled times.

It was to the credit of Modi's government that it did not arrest the founder of the Cuckooch Janata Party when he landed in India despite the BJP's social media trolls having maligned him brutally. It was also good that he was allowed to hold a rally in Delhi and more recently in Pune. He has so far stuck to raising only one demand, which is for the resignation of the education minister on the valid grounds that he failed to prevent yet another paper from leaking in the NEET exam. Dharmendra Pradhan has not deigned to explain why there is such a mess in the very centralised examinations that are conducted under him. And this could be because the disdain for dissenting voices has become the defining characteristic of the Modi government.

Dissent is the lifeblood of democracy. When it is crushed or treated with contempt, the damage done is incalculable. It does not manifest itself instantly but slowly and insidiously and in the end, it harms those who express dissenting opinions less than those who choose not to hear them. What happened to the editor of NewsClick should not have happened and should not happen ever to journalists who take a critical view of the government. The relationship between media and government in healthy democracies is necessarily adversarial because if we are on the same side, then what is the point of that fourth pillar of democracy?

In the twelve years that Modi has been prime minister that fourth pillar has become weaker than ever before. When the applause and the plaudits die down and the Prime Minister has time to reflect and brood, he would do himself a real service if he spent a moment or two thinking about why he is seen as an autocrat and why the democracy watchdogs of the world have demoted India to being an electoral autocracy.



INSIDE TRACK | BY COOMMI KAPOOR

PRICEY PRESIDENTIAL PERKS

After the Congress's fraught delay in nominating V D Satheesan as Kerala Chief Minister, the focus has shifted to 83-year old Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge. Some complain that Kharge is turning into a bit of a liability because of his excess baggage. Kharge violates the principle of one man, one post — apart from being party president, he is also Leader of the Opposition in Rajya Sabha and enjoys the perks that come with the office. Kharge's son Priyank has just been appointed Home Minister in the new D K Shiv Kumar government in Karnataka. For the forthcoming Rajya Sabha elections, Kharge has selected his aide Pranav Jha as the Congress candidate from Jharkhand, when there were several more deserving candidates. Earlier, Kharge's protégé, Neeraj Dangi, got a Rajya Sabha ticket from Rajasthan. Rahul Gandhi is particularly upset with Kharge's lack of judgment in the Tamil Nadu poll. The party president, along with P Chidambaram, insisted that the Congress not break its long-standing alliance with the DMK, although Rahul Gandhi was keen for an electoral tie-up with the charismatic film star C. Joseph Vijay, who eventually ended up as chief minister. The Congress ditched the DMK only after the results. It won a mere five seats with the DMK alliance. If Kharge demits the president's post, the obvious replacement is K C Venugopal, who is already party general secretary in charge of the organisation and has Gandhi's ear.

ENDURANCE TEST

Last month's marathon four-and-a-half hour meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi, his Cabinet ministers and secretaries concerned at the Seva Teerth was not merely an assessment of the performance of the different ministries; it was also an unspoken test of the endurance and physical fitness of Modi's ministers. One minister who failed the test by dozing off — though not quite as conspicuously as US President Donald Trump who has often been captured on camera snoozing at meetings in the Oval Office of late — had to be nudged awake by a senior secretary.

MAMATA'S SEARCH FOR SAFE SEAT

The day after the West Bengal election results, Mamata Banerjee found her world turned upside down. During the night, all photographs of Banerjee in Kolkata were removed and posters of Svendula Adhikari pasted in their place. She learnt that many of her trusted legislators were planning to switch to the BJP. Though isolated and vilified, Banerjee retains her fighting spirit and feels that at this juncture, Delhi would be a better option than remaining in Bengal. She is looking for a safe Lok Sabha seat. (A Rajya Sabha ticket is not an option since even if a TMC MP steps down for her, a by-election would automatically favour the BJP.) The initial speculation was that cricketer Yusuf Pathan might vacate his Baharampur Lok Sabha seat to make way for didi but Pathan has turned rebel. Now Banerjee has zeroed in on the Basirhat Lok Sabha constituency where a by-election is due and the voter breakdown favours the TMC. No stranger to struggle, the feisty Banerjee has fought singlehandedly in the past to carve her political legacy. Between 1999 and 2001, she was the lone TMC member in the Lok Sabha. Old-time parliamentary scribes recall that she once angrily threw a paper, which she claimed was a flawed voter list, at the acting Speaker. Ironically, she charged that the voter list was replete with infiltrators from Bangladesh, while in the recent Bengal poll, she took the diametrically opposite stance against the BJP on the same issue.

TEMPLE TOURS RECORDED

The string of ministers from both the Centre and states who visited temples last Wednesday to offer prayers for Prime Minister Modi in appreciation of his remarkable feat as the longest serving Indian Prime Minister was in response to phone calls from the party head office. So that their presence would not go unnoticed, many alerted TV channels in advance. While applauding Modi's achievements, some RSS seniors cautioned against the BJP aping former Congress president D K Barooah who had famously defied Indira Gandhi with his "India is Indira" remark. While the RSS does not normally intervene in political decisions, it has reservations about a potential tie-up between the BJP and the DMK, a party which has never hidden its anti Sanatan sentiments.

REALITY, NOT JUST COCKROACH BYTES

Those who expected an instantaneous mobilisation of youth support for the Cuckooch Janata Party at Janatar Mantar, on the lines of the overnight success of Anna Hazare and Arvind Kejriwal's campaign against corruption in Manmohan Singh's government in 2011, forgot that Kejriwal's initial crowd support was partly provided by RSS cadres and activists camped there for several days. Even phenomenal social media numbers take time and effort to translate into feet on the ground.

Inside two of India's oldest legislatures, a legacy of reforms



HISTORY HEADLINE
BY CHAKSHU ROY

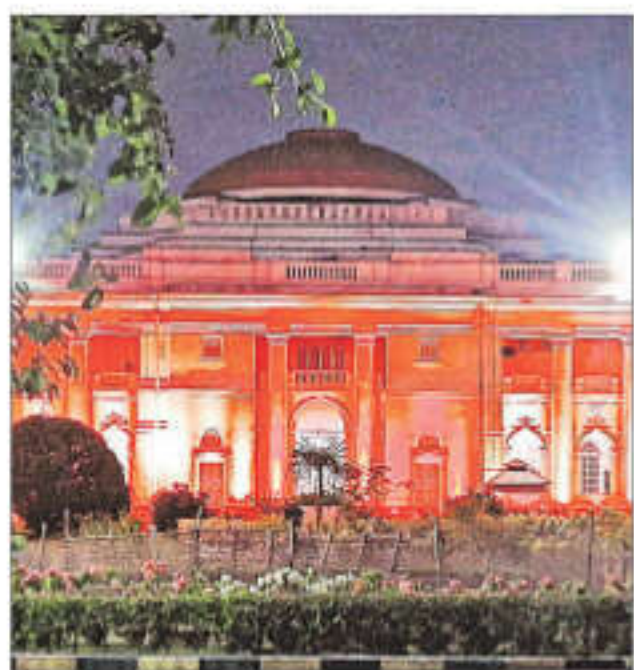
IN THE third week of June, the West Bengal and Tamil Nadu legislative assemblies will meet for their Budget session. The general public and political observers will be closely watching these legislative proceedings to see how the new governments address campaign promises made during elections.

In both states, roughly half of the Members of Legislative Assemblies (MLAs) are first-time legislators. They will be stepping into the hallowed halls of legislative institutions with a history spanning a century.

Modern legislative institutions in India can trace their beginnings to the presidency towns of Bombay, Calcutta and Madras. It was in these cities that the East India Company's trade, administration, and law-making were carried out by a small council of the company's officers, meeting in council rooms/houses. Over time, the British Parliament began to take an interest in India.

Calcutta became the seat of British administration, with the Governor General at the helm of affairs. He was advised by a four-member council, and later, a law member joined this group. The British government also set up provincial councils, but it was not until the 1919 reforms that modern national and provincial legislatures were created. Then, in 1921, the Duke of Connaught came to hunt tigers and to inaugurate the legislatures being set up under these reforms. He inaugurated the provincial legislatures in Madras and Calcutta, and finally the national legislature in Delhi.

Legislative institutions are defined by the passionate debates of legislators and identified by the buildings where these debates take place. In Madras, the Tamil Nadu Legislature meets in a building located inside Fort St George. The location is unique because both the legislature and the executive are within the same compound.



PARTHA PAUL

Bengal is set to hold the Budget Session at Bidhan Bhavan, Tamil Nadu at Fort St George.



PTI

Inside the fort, and not far from the assembly building, is St Mary's Church, the oldest Anglican church in the country. It was the venue for the marriages of Elihu Yale (whose donation of books and materials led to Yale College bearing his name) and Robert Clive, the "unstable sociopath" who pivoted the East India Company from a trading corporation to an imperial power.

In 1921, the West Bengal Legislative Council first met in the iconic Town Hall in Calcutta. And ten years later, it moved into its own dedicated, imposing building, now called Bidhan Bhavan. Within its boundaries are several fruit trees, a library, a museum, a century-old fire alarm box and a temple.

The Bengal assembly has a British-style ceremonial mace that signifies the authority of the House. It is still in use, kept in front of the Speaker when the assembly is in session. A painting in the building depicts a pre-Independence scene, showing barefoot, liveried Indian men carrying the mace ahead of British officers wearing shoes. (The Tripura legislature also has a mace, and in 2019, an MLA ran off with it as a sign of protest.)

The Bengal assembly was always at the forefront of technological innovation. Shortly after Independence, it began recording the audio of its debates. It was also the first to introduce machine voting in its proceedings. The success of machine voting in the Bengal legislature (albeit with a few hiccups) led to the technology's adoption in the Parliament of India. The assembly also became the first to implement a comprehen-

sive system of subject committees to ensure government accountability — a mechanism later adopted by the national parliament.

The Tamil Nadu legislature has also not been far behind in its innovation and contribution to the country's legislative fabric. In 1921, the Madras legislature became the first one to allow some women to vote in elections and by 1927, the government had nominated Dr S Muthulakshmi Reddi to the legislative council.

In the 1960s, it was the first one to seriously discuss the declaration of assets and liabilities by its MLAs to address the issue of probity in public life. When political slugs-fests in the legislature were leading to changes in the record of its proceedings, it adopted a rule to protect their accuracy. Its rules now specify that a record of the proceedings, once published, cannot be altered or deleted by the Speaker or the House itself. It is perhaps the only legislature in the country which on two separate occasions suspended its rules to discuss the role of the Governor in the state.

When the newly elected MLAs from Tamil Nadu and West Bengal meet for their Budget sessions, in two of the country's oldest state legislatures, the people of their states would hope that their public representatives stick to the original mandate of these institutions — to make laws for the "peace and good government."

The writer looks at issues through a legislative lens and works at PRS Legislative Research

Are you being served?



ON THE LOOSE
BY LEHER KALA

ing partner in my neighbourhood who had her chowkidar follow us 10 feet behind, to chase away stray dogs. Like Prince Philip walked respectfully behind Queen Elizabeth all his life, my friend (and countless others) unknowingly follow the House of Windsor protocols in Delhi. (I ended up changing my walking time.)

The creature comforts available in a poor country have made the rich Indian fat, unfit and chronically lazy, unwilling to lift a finger to do the simplest of chores. Go to any wedding, there'll be an endless buildup of traffic to the entrance. God forbid that any aunt should have to get out of her car and walk the last 50 yards in her finery, no, she will only disembark on the steps. It was a national embarrassment some years ago when statistics emerged that 30% of Indian passengers on India-US flights ask for wheelchairs, unscrupulously scamming the priority boarding system. The lame excuse in their defence was that when you're not a regular traveller, international airports are

endlessly confusing, and this way, the responsibility of making a connecting flight is on the airline. Well, the answer to that is, fine the hell out of them and they'll learn their way around terminals mighty fast.

If airlines charged for a chaperone service, there's no chance Indians would pay. They're jugaadu enough to extract privileges where they can but cannily circumspect when it comes to wasting money. Make no mistake, there is a cost to slothful inactivity. Over a 100 million adults live with diabetes here. Simple household chores burn calories too but if you're too push to mow, vacuum or dust — or simply don't move — you risk rapid physical decline over time. Compare a Western woman in her 60s with her Indian counterpart from the same economic strata, no prizes for guessing, the Westerner wins hands down in strength. The Indian is likely to be waddling breathlessly, with a minion holding her purse.

The writer is director, Hutkay Films

Before next polls, SC wants SIR exclusion cases decided: A reality check from Assam

In 1997, around 3 lakh voters in Assam marked 'Doubtful' during intensive roll revision; ahead of this year's polls, the state had 93,000 'D' voters still, with cases dragging on

Sukrita Baruah
Guwahati, June 13

UPHOLDING THE legal validity of the SIR of electoral rolls by the Election Commission (EC) on May 27, the Supreme Court held that those excluded from the list will face "adjudication of their citizenship". It also directed that such cases be referred "within 4 weeks to the Competent Authority... (which) shall take the necessary decision in accordance with law, preferably before the next Parliamentary, Assembly, Local Body elections, whichever is earlier".

The Assam example is illustrative of why it will not be as easy as that.

It is the only state where the presence of voters in electoral lists has been contested on grounds of citizenship at this scale. In 1997, around 3 lakh of them were first marked 'D-voters' or 'Doubtful Voters' during an intensive revision of rolls. Ahead of this year's Assam As-

sembly elections, over 93,000 were still 'D' voters, with cases dragging on through tribunals and courts. There is no clear data on how many have been marked 'D' voters since 1997.

The revision of electoral rolls held nearly 30 years ago in Assam involved "verification" by 'Local Verification Officers (LVOs)' of cases of people who had been provisionally included in the draft voting list but where "linkages could not be established with earlier rolls". Establishing linkages with previous SIR in respective states is one of the prime requirements of the EC's ongoing SIR exercise too.

In Assam's case, the LVOs submitted reports to respective Election Registration Officers (EROs), and where the EROs "had reasonable doubt about the citizenship of any person", they forwarded the cases to the "competent authority", which was the SP of the district concerned. Police then referred these cases for "determination" to Foreigners'

Tribunals (FTs) or Illegal Migrants Determination Tribunals (IMDT), in place since 1964 and 1983 in Assam, respectively, due to its long history of immigration and citizenship anxieties.

After the IMDT Act was struck down as "unconstitutional" in 2005, all cases were transferred to FTs. Unlike in the case of IMDTs, where the onus on proving citizenship was on the complainant and the authorities, in the case of FTs, those accused of being suspected foreigners had to prove their case. (The Supreme Court's order giving the EC a four-week window to report the SIR deletions also essentially shifts the burden on the deleted individual to prove their citizenship.)

'D' was put after the names in the voter list of all people in Assam whose cases had not been decided by tribunals — indicating that their citizenship status was disputed or 'Doubtful'. If declared Indian, they would remain on the voter list,

with the 'D' mark removed, but if ruled to be foreigner, they would have their names deleted and be moved to detention centres pending deportation.

Following a Supreme Court order, those who have spent two years in detention centres without having their cases cleared can now be released on bail.

Lawyers who have been working on citizenship matters in Assam tell *The Indian Express* that the biggest round of mass marking of people as D-voters took place in 1997, but people were also tagged thus in 2005, when an intensive revision was conducted in Assam last.

In 2012, a 'White Paper on Foreigners Issue' brought out by Assam government recorded 2,31,657 such references to competent authorities. The paper said that between 1998 and July 2012 (14 years), 6,590 people had been declared foreigners by tribunals, while more than six times that number, 44,220, ended up being declared Indian.

In a recent submission before the Assembly, the Assam government said that until January 31, 2025, a little over 77,000 'D' voters had been declared Indians, while 1.18 lakh cases were

still pending.

Ahead of the Assam elections this year, the EC conducted a Special Revision in December 2025 — unlike the SIR in other poll-bound states, due to the different citizenship processes in Assam. In the voter list released after the Special Revision, the number of people marked as 'D' voters was 93,021.

The functioning of FTs has been frequently criticised as being "arbitrary", apart from drawing criticism over the long delays when cases reach them.

Senior Advocate Hafiz Rashid Ahmed Choudhury, who has represented many people before FTs, says the long drawn-out process means many wait years just for the chance to defend themselves at tribunals.

Choudhury points to another gap. "Once the 'D' was put against a name, it didn't mean a person had to come before a tribunal immediately... The ERO has to refer it to police, who in turn must refer it to the tribunal. Over the years, we have seen so many 'D' voters who are not able to fight their case in tribunals because it has not been referred, and they have not got the notice."

FTs are presided over by

quasi-judicial officers. A former FT member told *The Indian Express*: "Once a person appears before a tribunal with a written statement and documentary evidence, a case can be disposed of within a month. But there is institutional lethargy from all directions, as well as systemic problems like a lack of staff and facilities at tribunals."

There are currently 100 FTs in Assam. A Gauhati High Court Bench which monitors the functioning of these tribunals, in an order as recently as June 2, remarked on the lack of facilities in them, noting: "This also demonstrates that the intention of the Govt. is not to allow the Foreigners Tribunal to function in an appropriate manner."

Even after a person has been declared a foreigner by FTs, he or she has the option of moving the High Court and Supreme Court. In the most recent case, the Supreme Court ordered status quo on the deportation of five women, after they had lost their case before the Gauhati High Court and an FT.

Since last year, the Assam government has escalated a process of "pushbacks" or informal deportations into Bangladesh of declared foreigners.

How can a 'friend' be so insensitive: Tharoor on Indian seafarers' death in US missile strike

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 13

CONGRESS MP and chairperson of the Parliamentary Committee for External Affairs Minister, Shashi Tharoor, weighed in on the row over the killing of three Indian seafarers in a US missile strike, and asked how can a "friend" and "strategic partner be so deeply insensitive".

Tharoor made the comment on a day US Secretary of State Marco Rubio defended Washington's blockade in the Strait of Hormuz after External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar lodged a strong protest over the deaths of Indian seafarers in attacks on commercial vessels off the coast of Oman.

"Deeply shocking to read this official US statement, which contains absolutely no expression of regret or condolence for the loss of innocent Indian lives. How can a 'friend' and strategic partner be so deeply insensitive?" said Tharoor.

He asked why couldn't a non-compliant commercial vessel have been stopped using other, non-lethal means and if

it is not possible to disable a ship's propulsion or steering without firing missiles targeted to kill civilian crew members.

"Practically every merchant ship navigating these crucial waters has Indian crew on board. Are they all considered fair game for US missiles now?" he said, adding that he hoped Indian External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar had said so to Rubio. Congress Media and Publicity department chairman Pawan Khera also released a statement saying India should have demanded — and received — an unconditional apology for the killing of three young Indian sailors. "Instead, Secretary Rubio reportedly chose to issue a warning, declaring that failure to comply with the orders of the US military will not be tolerated. That is the language of command, not contrition," said Khera.

"There was no acknowledgement of the lives lost, no acceptance of responsibility, and no apology," he said. Khera said the appropriate words for America's actions are: illegal, reckless and unacceptable.

Won't accept younger brother role: Puri on BJP-SAD alliance buzz ahead of Punjab polls

Raakhi Jagga
Ludhiana, June 13

AMID SPECULATION over a possible revival of SAD-BJP alliance ahead of the 2027 Assembly elections, Union Minister Hardeep Singh Puri Saturday said the BJP would never accept the role of a "younger brother" (junior partner), asserting that the party is the country's as well as the world's largest.

Puri's remarks came days after SAD chief Sukhbir Singh Badal brushed aside speculation about the possible alliance with the BJP, saying that his focus was on strengthening his party.

In Ludhiana, Puri told reporters, "Presently, the BJP is the largest political party in India and in the world. If somebody thinks that you can make us a younger brother by entering into an alliance, it will not happen."

At a separate event in Amritsar, when Union Minister Manohar Lal was asked about the SAD alliance rumours, he said, "It is a

policy matter, our party's central leadership will decide the strategy. Strategy can't be disclosed before it is finalised."

Asked if the BJP is capable of fighting all 117 Assembly seats on its own, Lal recalled the party's electoral success in West Bengal, where it had gone solo and won 207 seats. Meanwhile, sources said BJP's Punjab leadership has been asked to start preparing for all 117 seats during a high-level organisational meeting at party headquarters in New Delhi, Friday, which was attended by Union Home Minister Amit Shah, BJP chief Nitin Nabin and Punjab BJP brass. It was the first comprehensive session of Punjab BJP leadership after the appointment of Kewal Singh Dhillon as the new state chief.

BJP leader Parminder Singh Brar said, "BJP will contest elections all 117 seats on its own strength and form government. There will be no alliance with any party."

Emerging tech has altered warfare, small powers can cause heavy losses: Rajnath



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh at the Air Force Academy in Dundigal on Saturday. PTI

Press Trust of India
Hyderabad, June 13

ASSERTING THAT recruits to the Armed Forces must be mentally prepared for the evolving nature of modern conflict, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Saturday said major powers no longer hold an edge on the battlefield as even smaller forces can inflict significant damage using specialised tactics.

Addressing the Combined Graduation Parade (CGP) at the Air Force Academy at Dundigal, Singh also said emerging technologies have altered the very definition of warfare. "Earlier, it seemed that the big powers had a decisive edge on the battlefield. But now, comparatively, even small powers can cause heavy losses with their small but dangerous weapons and new tactics. ... you should be mentally ready for any form of warfare," he said.

"In contrast to the visibility of soldiers and equipment earlier, many systems such as radars, satellites, drones, sensors and robotics are deployed in modern warfare. Such scenarios are being witnessed now in which traffic systems and CCTVs of adversaries are being controlled," he said. According to him, the definition of warfare has changed. Newly commissioned officers should understand modern warfare and adapt, adopt, and, if necessary, amend them.



President Droupadi Murmu with the nine women cadets who were commissioned as officers in the Indian Army, at the Indian Military Academy in Dehradun on Saturday. MINISTRY OF DEFENCE

FIRST TIME, A PERMANENT COMMISSION FOR WOMEN OFFICERS

First batch of NDA-trained women cadets commissioned as officers

Express News Service
Pune, New Delhi, June 13

A YEAR after they walked past the symbolic Antim Pag — the final step — at the NDA in Pune, the first batch of 17 women cadets trained at the NDA was commissioned Saturday as officers, marking a significant milestone in the evolution of women's participation in military service.

This is the first time women officers will be joining the forces with a permanent commission. This was made possible by an interim order passed by the Supreme Court in August 2021, while hearing a plea seeking directions to let eligible women take the NDA and Naval Academy entrance exams conducted by the UPSC.

The first batch of women cadets joined the NDA in July-August 2022 as part of its 148th course.

So far, short service commission women officers could join the forces, and later seek permanent commission after completion of 14 years of service.

The batch of 17 women cadets have successfully completed their rigorous pre-commission training at their respective service academies, the Ministry of Defence said in a statement on Saturday.

"The commissioning marks a defining chapter in the transformation of the Defence Forces and reflects the nation's commitment to equal opportunity, merit and excellence in military service," the statement noted.

In the Indian Army, nine

women officers were commissioned during the Passing Out Parade of 158th Regular Course at IMA, Dehradun, on Saturday. The parade was reviewed by President Droupadi Murmu.

In the IAF, five officers were commissioned during the Combined Graduation Parade of 217th Course at the Air Force Academy, Dundigal, Hyderabad, on Saturday. The parade was reviewed by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh.

In the Indian Navy, three officers were commissioned during the Spring Term 2026 Passing Out Parade at the Indian Naval Academy, Ezhimala, Kerala, on May 28. The parade was reviewed by Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief, Southern Naval Command Vice Admiral Sameer Saxena.

7 get life term for lynching MP man in 2022 over cow smuggling claim

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, June 13

A SESSIONS court in Madhya Pradesh's Narmadapuram district has sentenced seven men to life imprisonment for the 2022 lynching of Nazir Ahmed, who was beaten up on suspicion of cow smuggling, holding that they "assaulted the deceased with extreme brutality".

In a judgment delivered on June 12, First Additional Sessions Judge Tabassum Khan held that the prosecution had proved beyond reasonable doubt that the accused participated in the attack that led to Ahmed's death and injuries to two others travelling with him.

Recording its principal finding, the court held, "The prosecution has succeeded in proving beyond reasonable doubt that at the time and place of the incident, the accused persons, armed with lathis and sticks, formed an unlawful assembly and committed rioting by using force and violence." It held they assaulted Ahmed with the intention of causing his death or such bodily injury as was likely to cause death, thereby committing his murder.

The incident took place around 12.30 am on August 3, 2022, on Nandawada Road near Barakhad village in Seoni Malwa. According to the prosecution, Ahmed was travelling in a truck with Sheikh Lala and Syed Mushtaq when they were attacked by a crowd armed with lathis and sticks on suspicion of cow smuggling.

Ahmed was brought to the Community Health Centre at Seoni Malwa in an unconscious condition, where he died. The post-mortem recorded multiple injuries, including lacerated wounds to the head, fractures of the skull and extensive contusions across the face and body.

A striking feature of the trial was that several key witnesses did not support the prosecution's case before the court. Sheikh Lala and Syed Mushtaq,

who survived the attack, did not identify the accused during the trial. A man, whose statement under Section 164 of the CrPC had named the accused shortly after the incident, also denied being an eyewitness when examined in court.

The court acknowledged this difficulty, but noted his statement before a magistrate had been recorded on the day of the incident.

The court placed significant reliance on what it described as corroborative circumstances. It referred to identification proceedings conducted by an executive magistrate, Lalit Soni, in which the accused were identified shortly after their arrest.

The judgment recorded Soni's testimony regarding the identification parade "remained unshaken during cross-examination". The court observed that although the identifying witnesses later retracted, it appeared probable they had been "influenced" before deposing during trial.

The court also relied on disclosure statements and recoveries during probe. According to the prosecution, several accused led police to bamboo sticks allegedly used in the assault and to clothes said to have been worn during the incident.

The defence argued that the investigation was suspect because no separate action had been taken against persons allegedly involved in transporting cattle in the truck. The court rejected the contention. "Merely because no separate legal action was taken," the court held, "it cannot be inferred that the accused persons were not involved in the incident."

The judgment recommended that compensation be paid to Ahmed's wife, children and surviving parents under the victim compensation scheme. The court also ordered that Rs15,000 each be paid to survivors Sheikh Lala and Syed Mushtaq from the fine amount after expiry of the appeal period.



A forensic team at the pharmacy shop in Chandigarh, Saturday. ANI

13 rounds fired from auto pistol: Cashier killing rocks Chandigarh

Express News Service
Chandigarh, June 13

A CASHIER at a pharmacy shop in Chandigarh's Sector 11 was shot dead by two assailants inside the store on Saturday. The victim has been identified as Janki, a native of Himachal Pradesh, who was working as a cashier at Shree Kumar Medicos.

According to police, 13 rounds were fired at Janki from a close range by one of the assailants from what is believed to be an automatic pistol. The assail-

ants fled the scene on a scooter. Janki succumbed to his injuries at PGIMER.

According to preliminary information, two men wearing caps entered the store. Police sources said the two spent some time inside waiting for an opportunity to strike. Police are also examining motives behind the killing. The pharmacy shop owner had reportedly received threat calls. A social media post from a page identifying itself as "Goldy Dhillon Group" claimed responsibility for the attack.

had taken them to Thailand.

Patel took up the matter with the Ministry of External Affairs, formally requesting emergency consular assistance, coordination with Lao law enforcement, and, if necessary, flagging the case with Interpol and anti-trafficking units.

In a written communication to the MP's office on June 4, the Indian Embassy confirmed that both girls had been rescued by the Lao police from the Houaphan Province. "With persistent follow-up and close coordination with Lao authorities, both women were rescued from the Houaphan Province," the Embassy had stated.

The women were first

brought to Vientiane for official formalities before being repatriated to India. On Friday, MP Patel visited their residence and inquired after the women.

"From the moment this matter came to my attention, we remained in constant contact with the MEA. Under the guidance of PM Narendra Modi and External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, the Ministry and the Indian Embassy in Laos worked on a war footing," Patel said.

Earlier, Patel's office had intervened in rescuing two Anand residents who had been stranded in Azerbaijan while attempting to reach the United States through the 'dunk' route.

STAND-UP COMEDY SHOW CONTROVERSY

MBBS student sent on forced leave

Purnima Sah
Mumbai, June 13

MUMBAI'S KEM Hospital on Saturday sent MBBS student Sejal Pawar on a 15-day forced leave over her remarks on male cadavers during stand-up comedian Pranit More's show. The hospital administration also proposed a five-member committee to conduct a detailed probe into the row and submit its findings within seven working days.

KEM's decision follows its preliminary inquiry, which found Pawar's comments to be "objectionable and insensitive" and falling short of the standards of dignity, empathy and professional responsibility expected from a medical student.

KEM authorities had called Pawar's parents to the institute Saturday to counsel her in their presence. The MBBS student had on Friday submitted a written apology, acknowledging that some of her statements were inappropriate and may have caused distress.

"Today (Saturday) the student has been handed over to the care of her parents and concerns regarding her safety and mental well-being are also being considered. We have sent her on a 15-day forced leave and suggested the parents arrange for her counselling. All action concerning the student would be taken in accordance with applicable rules and guidelines, given that she is still pursuing her medical education," KEM Hospital dean Harish M Pathak said.

In an official statement issued Saturday, KEM said it had taken cognizance of public concern over Pawar's remarks and initiated a preliminary fact-finding process immediately after



KEM authorities had called Sejal Pawar's parents to the institute Saturday to counsel her in their presence

receiving complaints. "Respect for patients, deceased persons, body donors and their families is a foundational value of medical education. The matter will be handled with seriousness, sensitivity and procedural fairness. No final conclusion should be inferred at this stage, as the comprehensive inquiry process is presently under way," it said.

Pathak said while "certain facts" emerged during the preliminary assessment, "a broader and impartial investigation was considered necessary before arriving at any conclusions."

The proposed committee comprises one retired faculty member, three current senior faculty members and one journalist. The hospital administration said Pawar will be given full opportunity to present her version before the committee, which will examine the statements made in the viral video, complaints received, the student's conduct, social media activity surrounding the incident and the impact on the institution's image.

The controversy erupted after video clips of More's show, where Pawar made the remarks as an audience member, went

viral. Maharashtra Cyber Police have since registered an FIR against More, Pawar and another audience member Himanshu Jangra, who made a comment on physical intimacy in exchange for money spent on a date. Jangra has since been fired from his Gurgaon-based company.

Meanwhile on Saturday, More issued a public apology on his Instagram account, which he had previously deactivated. In a video, he said he got carried away during the interaction and deserved the backlash.

"You must have seen the crowd-work video for which I have been receiving a lot of hate. And rightly so. I deserve this criticism because during that crowd interaction, I made multiple derogatory remarks. People laughed, and I got carried away. It was a lapse in judgment," he said.

More said he should have stopped the interaction rather than giving it a platform. "I will fully cooperate with all legal proceedings. I just want to request that you give me another chance to work on myself and my content," he said.

Off the clock, but always on — and accountable

Heena Khandelwal
Mumbai, June 13

RECENTLY, 22-YEAR-OLD Himanshu Jangra was at a comedy show, as part of an audience participating in crowd-work. There, he implied that spending Rs 370 on biryani on a date entitled him to "something" from the woman. The room laughed. Comedian Pranit More laughed and later uploaded the clip on social media. The internet did not laugh.

Jangra's employer, Vivek Vishwakarma, founder of Gurgaon-based design and marketing agency Starvik Design, terminated his contract, stating that the effect of his statements had hampered their work and it was a business decision.

Jangra's case is the latest in a stream of incidents when companies are taking note of an employee's conduct after office hours. "Incidents like this are a good reminder that everything you say or do is potentially in the media's eyes now. There's no real 'private' space when it comes to public platforms," says Divye Agarwal, co-founder, Binge Labs, a social media strategy company.

Agarwal asserts that your workplace is an integral part of your identity today. "Your identity isn't just 'I'm a person living in Delhi.' It's 'I'm a person living in Delhi who works at X company.' That part follows you everywhere, even if it's only 20-30% of who you are."

Agarwal drew a parallel to

cricketers KL Rahul and Hardik Pandya who were dropped from the team (in 2019) after their comments on Koffee With Karan landed badly. "Humour and jokes are absolutely fine, we encourage that, it's part of any healthy culture. But there's a line, and that line is at things like misogyny or anything that puts someone else down. That's not humour anymore, that's just disrespect dressed up as a joke."

Myah Payel Mitra, a Bengaluru-based coach, who works with organisations such as LinkedIn, Microsoft, Amazon and Myntra to create safe work cultures, says, "We are living in an always-on culture, which means you are at work even if you aren't." HRs, she adds, are now actively checking digital footprints, and leading MNCs like KPMG have formal guidelines on what employees can and cannot post.

The question of who bears responsibility when something goes wrong in a public setting is blurred. Jangra's firm was working out of a co-working space. "We're not in a position to take disciplinary action against individuals who aren't our employees," says Guncha Khare, Senior Director of Strategy at Dextrus, which runs four co-working spaces in Mumbai. "But where conduct affects how people experience our shared workplace, we would raise it with the company concerned — both to flag the concern and to understand what steps they are taking to address it."

The chairman of a leading PR company, on the condition of anonymity, shares: "Every employee is a brand ambassador of that firm, be it a board member, CEO or a junior. Professional and personal behaviour are both sides of the same coin. You cannot switch your conduct on or off from one place to another."

Not too long ago, in 2018, Michelin-starred chef Atul Kochhar, was fired from a Dubai restaurant after a tweet in which he stated that Muslims had "terrorised" Hindus for thousands of years — a comment he later apologised for. "People should distinguish between personal life and professional life, but they don't. In today's times, it has become most important to not say anything," he says.

That caution is now institutional. Tripti Bhatia, founder of Mumbai-based PR and marketing firm Detales Brand Communication, says her team avoids online opinions altogether. "You aren't getting anything by being vocal, so it is better to be quiet and do your work." On Jangra, she is unequivocal: she would have terminated him too.

Agarwal sees a distinction worth preserving. "Everyone's entitled to their opinions — political, religious, whatever side of anything. But the moment it puts someone else down, that's where we draw the line. It's not about restricting people, it's about building a culture people actually want to be part of."

• BRIEFLY



A miner at an illegal coal mine in Ramgarh district. EXPRESS

JHARKHAND

Four workers die after inhaling toxic gases in illegal mine in Ramgarh

FOUR MEN died after allegedly being exposed to toxic gases inside an illegal coal mine in a forest area along the Giddi-Ramgarh border in Jharkhand's Ramgarh district on Saturday, triggering a political row. The deceased were identified as Ashish Rajwar (25), Kishore Rawani (35), Deva Kumar Bedia (25) and Dablu Bedia (30). State BJP president Aditya Sahu demanded stringent action against officials and those responsible for the alleged illegal mining activities. "The repeated review meetings and announcements had failed to translate into effective ground-level action. We demand accountability from all the agencies responsible for regulating mining activities and ensuring public safety," said Sahu. ENS

Shimla school director shot dead near home

THE DIRECTOR of Saraswati Paradise International Public School in Shimla was shot dead outside her house in Sanjauli on Saturday. Sources said two assailants riding a two-wheeler approached the victim, Meenakshi Mittal, 40, and asked her about some address. As the woman answered, one of the assailants opened fire. Mittal died on the spot. ENS

Four youth on picnic drown in Goa waterfall

FOUR YOUTH drowned in the Dudhsagar river in South Goa on Saturday. The youngsters, part of a group of five, had gone for a picnic near a waterfall and entered it thinking it was shallow, said the police. The deceased have been identified as Ramanna Mader, 19, Laxman Mader, 19, Hiranna Mader, 21, from the same family in Chicalim and Vijay Sajili, 20 from Vasco. ENS

Rajasthan: In-principle clearance for coal block in Hasdeo-Arand

It will be mined by Adani group

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, June 13

ACCEPTING THE recommendation of its forest advisory committee, the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC) has granted in-principle forest clearance to divert 1,742.6 hectares of Hasdeo-Arand forest for Kente extension coal block allotted to Rajasthan government and to be mined by the Adani Group.

The ministry's "in-principle forest clearance" (not clearances) comes even as a 2021 biodiversity assessment done by Wildlife Institute of India (WII) and Indian Council of Forestry Research (ICFRE) for Hasdeo-Arand coal fields (HACF) had stated that no mining should be carried out in HACF, except in the already operational Parsa East Kente Basan mine.

The biodiversity assessment had also highlighted the landscape's significance for elephants and had stated that any further threat to elephant's intact habitats could deflect human-wildlife conflict into newer areas in Chhattisgarh.

The coal mining project in Suruga, Chhattisgarh, will involve felling of 4.48 lakh trees, as per official documents, including 97,837 trees in the first five years of mining. Compensatory afforestation in lieu of the forest diversion has been approved over 130.6 hectares of non-forest land and 4450.326 hectares of degraded forest land. Meanwhile, the state forest department has also been directed to translocate 67,414 trees which are below 60cm in girth.

The coal mined from Rajasthan Vidyut Utpadan Nigam Limited's (RVUNL) Kente extension coal block (KECB) will feed the Chhabra and Suratgarh coal plants in Rajasthan. The coal block was allotted to RVUNL in October 2015 for captive use at these power plants.

The in-principle forest clearance issued on June 9 is subject to specific conditions that the mining shall be done in two-phases; first during a 15-year period and restricted to 1,001.95 hectares of forest land. Phase-II of mining on the remaining 740.65 hectares will be linked to reforestation and biodiversity management in Phase-I, as per the clearance document.

"Permission for mining in phases shall be subject to exhaustion of the coal reserve within the phase-I mining area

boundary or completion of a period of 15 years, whichever is earlier," the forest clearance document stated.

The Chhattisgarh government has also been directed to ensure that a site-specific wildlife management plan as per the recommendations of the Biodiversity assessment study done by ICFRE and WII and it is to be implemented with funding from RVUNL. The moderately dense to dense Hasdeo-Arand forests, which one earmarked as a no-go zone for mining by the UPA government, have already seen deforestation for two coal blocks — Parsa coal block and Parsa East Kente Basan open cast mines. The Hasdeo-Arand area, home to dense Sal forests, spans Korba, Surguja and Surgapur districts in northern Chhattisgarh and is estimated to be spread over 1.75 lakh hectares.

The forest area to be diverted for KECB is rich in biodiversity, home to nine Schedule — I species, including leopards, sloth bears and elephants. It is also a catchment for Hasdeo River and Bango Dam and it is situated within 10-km distance from Lemru elephant reserve.

The Chhattisgarh Bachao Andolan had also raised environmental and tribal rights concerns with the government last month.

UDANTI-SITANADI RESERVE HAS SEEN ITS TIGER POPULATION GO DOWN FROM 18 TO ZERO

A stray tigress makes a new home, giving a struggling Chhattisgarh reserve hope of revival

Jayprakash S Naidu
Raipur, June 13

A FOUR-YEAR-OLD tigress that wandered into Chhattisgarh's Udanti-Sitanadi Tiger Reserve (USTR) earlier this year and stayed through the scorching summer months has kindled fresh hopes for a reserve that has watched its tiger population vanish over the past three decades.

For forest officials, the tigress's decision to remain in the reserve through the harshest season of the year, when water and prey becomes scarce, is being seen as a sign that the habitat may once again be capable of sustaining a breeding tiger population.

The optimism stems partly from a success story elsewhere in Chhattisgarh. At Achanakmar Tiger Reserve, a tigress named Jhumri played a key role in reviving the big cat population after years of decline. Its arrival and subsequent breeding helped boost tiger numbers in the reserve, offering conservationists a rare example of natural recovery in the state.

Udanti-Sitanadi, however,



The big cat does not match any tiger officially recorded in India by the WII, so forest officials have named it 'Paheli'.

has had a far more troubled trajectory.

In 1998, the then Udanti Wildlife Sanctuary was home to 18 tigers. By 2006, that number had fallen to just three. During the same period, the population of wild buffaloes — Chhattisgarh's state animal — crashed from around 80 to seven. Today, only one wild buffalo survives in the reserve.

The decline was not limited to tigers and buffalo. Populations of panthers, gaur, sambar, nilgai, spotted deer and wild boar also dwindled over

the years.

In 2009, the state government merged the Udanti and Sitanadi sanctuaries, spread across 1,842.54 sq km, and notified them as a tiger reserve. Tiger numbers briefly rose to eight, but the gains proved short-lived. By 2023, no resident tiger remained in the reserve, which had effectively become a transit landscape for dispersing big cats.

Against this backdrop, the arrival of the tigress in January has emerged as a rare bright spot.

Because the animal does not match any tiger officially re-

corded in India by the Wildlife Institute of India (WII), forest officials have named it "Paheli" (riddle).

Officials say Paheli has not only endured the summer but has also been involved in territorial encounters, including with elephant herds moving through the landscape.

Asked about measures being taken to encourage the tigress to settle permanently in the reserve, USTR Deputy Director Varun Jain said, "Regular foot patrolling, camera trapping and use of thermal drones are being undertaken. We are planning to radio-collar her so that monitoring can continue if she moves into Odisha or other districts of Chhattisgarh and faces danger."

The reserve is also undergoing habitat improvement works in anticipation of future tiger translocations. More than 500 hectares of grassland are being developed, and water bodies are being created to improve water availability for wildlife.

Officials said that over the last three to four years, nearly 956 hectares of encroached land have been cleared from the core

and buffer areas of the reserve, despite the presence of more than 100 villages within its boundaries.

Anti-poaching efforts have also intensified. During the same period, authorities carried out 15 inter-state operations with assistance from the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI), leading to the arrest of more than 100 alleged poachers involved in leopard and pangolin trafficking.

Investigators also busted illegal country-made firearm manufacturing units.

After receiving approval from the National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA) to translocate one male and two female tigers from neighbouring Madhya Pradesh, forest officials have focused on improving prey availability — a key condition flagged by the NTCA for the reserve's revival.

Alongside efforts to restore tiger numbers, authorities are also attempting to revive the wild buffalo population. Three female wild buffaloes have been brought from Assam and are expected to be released into the reserve soon.

SWABHIMAN NIDHI PROPOSAL SENT TO MAHARASHTRA GOVT FOR APPROVAL

BMC plans Ladki Bahin-style aid for domestic workers

Pratip Acharya
Mumbai, June 13

AFTER THE state government's Ladki Bahin scheme transformed Maharashtra's political landscape, Mumbai's newly elected civic body has proposed its own version for women working in the informal sector. *The Indian Express* has learned.

Three months after taking office, the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) has sent a proposal to the state government seeking approval for 'Swabhimani Nidhi', a monthly financial assistance scheme for domestic workers, cooks and other women employed in the unorganised sector. The scheme proposes to provide beneficiaries between Rs 1,500 and Rs 2,000 per month and could potentially cover up to five lakh women in Mumbai, adding an estimated Rs 75-100 crore to the civic body's monthly expenditure.

The proposal's journey is politically significant because it originated as part of the Shiv



The Ladki Bahin scheme has around 1.7 crore beneficiaries. FILE

Sena (UBT)'s manifesto for the January BMC elections but has since received backing from the BJP-led ruling side in the civic body, where the Mahayuti enjoys a majority.

The proposal was formally moved in March by Kishori Pednekar, Shiv Sena (UBT) corporator and Leader of Opposition in the BMC, to Ganesh Khankar, BJP corporator and Leader of the House. Khankar endorsed the proposal and forwarded it to the BMC Standing Committee chairman Prabhakar Shinde,

recommending that the civic administration examine the feasibility of making budgetary provisions for the scheme.

"Domestic helps shoulder the responsibility of supporting their families and providing education to their children despite having modest incomes. Illness, old age and sudden financial emergencies often push them into precarious situations as most of them do not have any form of social security or assistance," Pednekar wrote.

In 2024, the state govern-

ment launched the Mukhyamantri Majhi Ladki Bahin Yojana, under which eligible women receive a monthly direct benefit transfer of Rs 1,500. According to government data, the scheme has around 1.7 crore beneficiaries and costs the state exchequer approximately Rs 2,500 crore every month.

Unlike the Ladki Bahin scheme, the proposed BMC initiative is aimed specifically at women employed in the informal sector, such as domestic helps and cooks, and wouldn't have an upper age limit.

The proposal has been sent to the state government for approval. According to civic officials, if approved, the BMC will conduct a survey through its 26 ward offices to identify and register eligible beneficiaries.

Officials said the final standard operating procedures would be prepared only after the proposal is approved by the state government. However, they indicated that only registered domestic workers would be eligible for the benefit. Since most do-

mestic workers belong to the unorganised sector, officials said the E-Shram database is likely to be used as the primary verification mechanism.

"For those who are not yet registered, enrolment may be made mandatory to avail of the scheme. In addition, local ward offices may seek certification from housing societies confirming that the applicant is employed as a domestic worker," a civic official said on the condition of anonymity. Officials added that NGOs and self-help groups working with domestic workers could also be involved in the verification process.

According to estimates from labour department and domestic workers' unions, Mumbai has nearly five lakh domestic workers. Officials noted that while the BMC supports women's self-help groups and livelihood initiatives through various departments, this would be the first instance of the civic body facilitating a monthly cash transfer scheme for workers in the informal sector.

Kashmiri Pandits' homecoming is 'truest victory', says L-G Sinha

Naveed Iqbal
Srinagar, June 13

JAMMU & KASHMIR Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha Saturday said that a moment of "transformation" is here for the Kashmiri Pandit community and the homecoming of "those uprooted from their homeland," is the truest victory.

Sinha was speaking at the Global Kashmiri Pandit Conclave in Srinagar and he called upon the distinguished members of Kashmiri Pandit community to set up industries, academic and cultural institutions in Jammu Kashmir that will become the immortal story of their heritage and provide opportunities to generations to come.

"Lives marked by pain and struggle gave the Kashmiri Pandit community two choices—despair or rebuilding. They chose creation, rebuilding and selfless service and in doing so, the community



J&K L-G Manoj Sinha lights a lamp during the launch of the e-edition of the collected works of Pt. Madan Mohan Malaviya, in Srinagar on Saturday. ANI

made history. Carrying the weight of massacre, they never turned away from their purpose," Sinha said.

Members of the community from India and abroad arrived in Srinagar to celebrate their journey of "resilience, renaissance and return".

Termining this a landmark event, Sinha said: "The moment of transformation is here. Those once uprooted from their homeland return and this homecoming is the

truest victory. The presence of business leaders, corporate heads, technology entrepreneurs, and cultural icons sends a powerful message of confidence in the peace of Jammu Kashmir, and trust in the administrative stability under Prime Minister Modi".

He added that the journey of Kashmiri Pandit Community has been "scarred by genocide, exile and struggle," however, the community chose a different path. "They refused to be defined by wounds and struggle. Instead, they transformed that pain into strength," the LG said.

Sinha noted that despite the "unimaginable brutality" faced by the community during the 1990s, "Hardship never broke the spirit of the Kashmiri Pandit community. Suffering did not silence their ambition. Instead, they shaped their own destiny by building industries, founding institutions, driving innovation, and earning respect across the world."

TEHRAN SEEKS TO PRESERVE ENRICHMENT RIGHTS, NUCLEAR KNOWHOW AND FUTURE THRESHOLD CAPABILITY

With a deal seemingly close, US faces an Iran willing to withstand pressure

Steven Erlanger
June 13

THE UNITED States and Israel went to war in Iran seeking regime change. Nearly four months later, there has been regime change, but not the kind they wanted. The Islamic Republic 3.0, as some call it, is now less a theocracy and more a military junta dominated by the powerful Islamic Revolutionary Guards Corps.

Washington and Jerusalem also went to war to eradicate Iran's nuclear program and end the threat it poses. So far, this conflict has only produced a wounded Iran more willing to take risks and more likely to persist in its goal of advancing its nuclear program.

The United States and Iran traded blows this past week while trying to find a path toward settling the war. By Friday, despite accusations of duplicity from both sides, officials in

Tehran and Washington said they were closing in on a deal, while emphasizing that an initial agreement, known as a memorandum of understanding, had not been finalized. Iran's foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, said that an agreement had "never been closer."

Even agreement on the



A small motorboat passes anchored vessels in the Strait of Hormuz off Bandar Abbas, Iran. FILE

memorandum will leave Tehran with some leverage, as the two sides engage in serious negotiations on Iran's nuclear program and its future role in the Strait of Hormuz. Many details would be left to a 60-day period for negotiations, which may or may not succeed.

In the course of this war, Iran has gone from appearing weak and defenceless to a regime not only surviving, but also retaining important military and nuclear abilities. Iran's extensive se-

curity apparatus seems firmly in control of all aspects of governing, society and foreign policy.

Iran is now led by "a younger, more brazen generation in power," said Sanam Vakil, the director of the Middle East and North Africa program at Chatham House, in what Aaron David Miller, a former American diplomat at Carnegie Endowment, called "a transition from divine power to hard power."

These new leaders believe they can survive even a major re-

newal of fighting without significantly altering their negotiating positions or their larger regional aims. Those aims include to restore their power of deterrence so that they cannot be attacked again as they were in February.

They also want to maintain the right to enrich uranium, even at low levels after a period of suspension, and will retain the scientific knowledge and equipment that would allow them, should they choose, to again become a nuclear-threshold state,

E. EXPLAINED

Tehran gains leverage after war

After US-Israeli strikes aimed at regime change and stopping Iran's nuclear program, Tehran has survived with its military and nuclear capabilities intact. Negotiators now near a limited deal, but Iran is demanding enrichment rights, frozen assets and leverage over the Strait of Hormuz in talks.

one that would have all the elements of a nuclear weapon without having put one together.

The new Iranian government has shown itself to be a tough negotiator willing to accept a high level of pain to preserve its core interests.

This attitude is very different from the caution shown by the former supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who was assassinated on the first day of the war, Feb. 28. He had for years banned the production of a nuclear weapon and always worked to avoid a joint Israeli-American attack on Iran. NYT

Funeral for slain Supreme Leader Khamenei set for July 4, says Tehran

Associated Press
Islamabad, June 13

IRAN'S STATE-run news agency said Saturday funeral processions for its former Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, would be held in July, as mediators say an agreement to end the war is close.

The funeral, burial, and farewell ceremonies for Khamenei would take place between July 4 and 9, Iran's state-run television, IRIB, reported. Khamenei was killed in the opening salvo of the war that Israel and United States launched against Iran in late February. He has since been replaced by his son, Mojtaba, who is seen as less compromising.

Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif said Saturday that a deal aimed at ending the war in the Middle East is closer than "ever before" and expected to be finalized within 24 hours. Pakistan is preparing for the electronic signing of the agreement, followed immediately by technical-level talks next week.

In a post on X, Sharif said: "We would like to thank United States of America and Islamic Republic of Iran for their ongoing commitment during the negotiations, and we extend our sincere appreciation to our brothers in region for support."

Lebanese army pulls out of border village after Israeli advance

Associated Press
Beirut, June 13

THE LEBANESE army on Saturday withdrew its troops from a base in a southern Lebanese village after Israeli troops advanced in an area nearby, a military official said.

The departure from the army barracks in Kfar Tebnit came as the Israeli military issued an evacuation warning for about 20 locations, including the southern city of Nabatiyeh and nearby villages.

Lebanon's state-run *National News Agency* reported airstrikes on Saturday on different villages near Nabatiyeh, including one that killed two people in

Deir al-Zahrani. It added that Nabatiyeh was subjected to artillery shelling Saturday.

A senior Lebanese military official told *The Associated Press* that the Lebanese army moved its forces from the Kfar Tebnit barracks following an incursion by Israeli forces into the area.

Israeli troops were likely trying to capture the strategic Ali Taher hill on the edge of Kfar Tebnit that overlooks large parts of Nabatiyeh and some of the roads that link the city with nearby villages. Israeli troops held the Ali Taher hill for 18 years until they withdrew from Lebanon in May 2000.

In late May, Israeli troops captured a nearby strategic



A car sits wrecked among debris left by an Israeli airstrike in the southern port city of Tyre, Lebanon, on Friday. FILE

mountain topped with the Crusader-built Beaufort Castle in the deepest incursion into the country since 2000.

The push on the edge of

Kfar Tebnit came a day after Pakistan's prime minister said United States and Iran have agreed to wording of an agreement aimed at ending their war

in the Middle East and that mediators are working with both sides to finalise a deal.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi told Iranian state TV on Friday that both sides were working toward signing an initial agreement declaring an end to the war "on all fronts, including Lebanon."

Senior Hezbollah official Hussein Haj Hassan told *Al Jazeera* TV that they have been informed by Iranian officials that Lebanon will be part of a future ceasefire deal between the US and Iran.

Iran is Hezbollah's main backer, supplying the group with different types of weapons over the past four decades as

well as billions of dollars.

Attacks by Israel and Hezbollah have continued despite a ceasefire that went into effect on April 17 and was renewed several times but remains a ceasefire in name only.

Israel continues to occupy large swathes of southern Lebanon while battling Hezbollah fighters, causing civilian casualties and damage to infrastructure. Hezbollah, which is not part of the ceasefire agreement between Israel and Lebanon, has launched frequent rocket and drone attacks.

More than 3,700 people have been killed in Lebanon in the latest fighting, according to the Lebanese Health Ministry.

Europe defence in focus as NATO prepares for a reduced US role

Associated Press
Brussels, June 13

NATO'S TOP military officer is weighing alternative plans to defend Europe should it come under attack from Russia, after United States announced that it is cutting the number of aircraft and warships that it would provide in a security crisis.

The so-called NATO Force Model is Plan A for making forces from the 32 member nations available in times of peace, crisis or war. It sets out the military assets that commanders can call on in phases over the first six months of any conflict.

But last month, the Pentagon warned its NATO allies that it would be scaling down its commitment to focus on potential threats elsewhere, notably from China in the Indo-Pacific region.

The reduction in available American military assets include an aircraft carrier strike



F/A 18 Hornet multi-role fighter jets take off from a road strip during NATO's Ramstein Flag 26 exercise in Trevo, Finland. FILE

group as well as a number of submarines, fighter jets, maritime patrol aircraft, air refueling planes and drones, according to a NATO official who was not authorized to discuss the matter publicly and spoke Friday on the condition of anonymity.

However, US space capabilities that help with targeting would still be available.

European countries and Canada had waited impatiently for over a year for the Trump administration to detail its plans after it warned that Europe is no longer a top US security priority. US Gen Alex Grynkeiwich, NATO's supreme allied commander, said that "the US is still committed to providing limited but critical capabilities to the alliance."



Kennedy Center Drops Trump Name

The wall of the John F Kennedy Center for the Performing Arts in Washington is covered in tarp after President Donald Trump's name was removed on Saturday. The removal followed a federal court ruling that the landmark cannot be renamed without an act of Congress. Workers erected scaffolding and took down the signage less than six months after Trump's name was added to the venue's facade. AP

• BRIEFLY



Police detain protestors outside Woolwich Crown Court in London. FILE

UNITED STATES

4 pro-Palestinian activists jailed over raid at Israeli firm Elbit

FOUR BRITISH pro-Palestinian activists were sentenced to a total of more than 20 years over a 2024 raid on a factory operated by Israeli defence firm Elbit which caused more than £1 million of damage, with the judge giving longer terms after determining there was a "terrorism connection." Charlotte Head, 30, Samuel Corner, 23, Leona Kamio, 30, and Fatema Zainab Rajwani, 21, were members of the banned group Palestine Action, which organised the assault on the Elbit Systems UK facility in Bristol, England, two years ago. REUTERS

NIGERIA

11 Indian sailors convicted in drug case; ship fined

ELEVEN INDIAN sailors have been convicted and their merchant vessel fined \$5.3 million by a court in Nigeria for cocaine trafficking. They were arrested around six months ago by operatives of the National Drug Law Enforcement Agency for allegedly importing 31.5 kilograms of cocaine from the Marshall Islands into Nigeria. PTI

RUSSIA

Drone strike on Temryuk port kills 1, sparks fire

A UKRAINIAN drone attack killed one person and sparked a fire at a sea terminal in the southern Russian port of Temryuk, in the Krasnodar region, governor Veniamin Kondratiev said on Saturday. Ukraine's military and the SBU security service said that Ukrainian drones hit several targets in Russia during overnight attacks. REUTERS

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

PAKISTAN

Security forces kill 21 terrorists in KPK province

SECURITY FORCES killed 21 terrorists in a series of intelligence-based operations in the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province in northwest Pakistan over the last three days, the military's media wing said Saturday. Among those killed were four ring leaders belonging to Fitna-al-Khwarizj, the military said. PTI

NEPAL

8 killed, 16 hurt after bus plunges into gorge

EIGHT PEOPLE died and 16 others sustained injuries after a passenger bus fell into a gorge in Nepal's Kaverpalanchowk district on Friday. There were 24 people on the bus when it fell 200 metres down the hilly road, police said, adding, the reason for the accident is not known yet. PTI

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North Korea condemns US missile sale approval to South Korea: Report

Reuters
Seoul, June 13

NORTH KOREA'S foreign ministry condemned a US decision to approve the sale of advanced air-to-air missiles and related equipment to South Korea, warning the move would worsen tensions on the Korean peninsula, state media *KCNA* said on Saturday.

The ministry's director-general for external policy said in a statement carried by *KCNA* that military cooperation between Washington and Seoul was being "systematically strengthened" despite what it called international concern over rising tensions in and around peninsula.

The official cited the US State Department's approval of a nearly \$300 million foreign military sale of advanced air-to-air missiles and related equipment

to South Korea as the latest example. "US arms exports are war exports," the official said, adding that North Korea would continue strengthening its self-defensive deterrent to maintain the regional balance of power.

North Korea routinely criticises US-South Korea military cooperation as preparation for war. It separately criticised South Korea's President Lee Jae Myung over a joint statement with European Union leaders during a visit to Europe, which described North Korea's status as a nuclear weapons state and its military cooperation with Russia as "illegal", *KCNA* said.

KCNA said it was a violation of North Korea's sovereignty, South Korea had shown there could be no "peaceful coexistence" between the two Koreas and Pyongyang would continue to regard South as a hostile state.

• THOUGH HIGH-END PRINTERS COST THOUSANDS OF DOLLARS, SOME 3D PRINTERS NOW CAN BE BOUGHT FOR AS LITTLE AS SEVERAL HUNDRED DOLLARS; THE DEVICES CAN MAKE TOYS, PROSTHETIC LIMBS AND AIRPLANE PARTS

As 3D-printed guns spread, US lawmakers target the machines that make them

Associated Press
New York, June 13

A FIRST-of-its-kind law in New York could force 3D printers sold for homes and business to come equipped with technology blocking them from making guns.

The new requirement, also under consideration in California, attempts to thwart the latest technique for producing untraceable "ghost guns" that have turned up in crimes. But there are questions about whether the technology can work and concerns about its affect on personal privacy and constitutional rights.

About one-third of US states already have taken steps to ban or regulate build-it-yourself

firearms that lack serial numbers and evade the background checks required to purchase guns from federally licensed dealers. What makes the new effort unique is that it targets the equipment used to produce the firearms, not the people who make them.

The blocking technology being pushed in two of the nation's most populous states has the potential to set industry standards for 3D printers.

It also could serve as a model for other Democratic-led states wanting to add to their gun regulations, which often already ban certain semiautomatic weapons and allow firearms to be temporarily confiscated from

people deemed to pose a threat to themselves or others.

Three-dimensional printers have become increasingly common over the past couple of decades. Since 2012, the number of 3D printers worldwide has grown from an estimated 30,000 to over 3 million while the industry's value has multiplied from around \$2 billion to \$26 billion annually, said Bill Decker, executive chairman of the Association of 3D Printing.

Though high-end printers cost thousands of dollars, some 3D printers now can be bought for as little as several hundred dollars. The devices can make toys, limbs and airplane parts. They also can make fire-



Ghost guns, provided by the New York City Police Department, are displayed at the Manhattan District Attorneys office, in New York. FILE

arms - or the pieces necessary to assemble them - using digital designs available online.

Homemade guns that lack

serial numbers often are called "ghost guns," because they are hard for law enforcement officers to trace.

Firearms made with 3D printers are increasingly being used in crimes, according to a US Department of Justice report released last year. The number of privately made guns recovered in crimes and submitted to federal authorities rose from about 1,600 in 2017 to nearly 27,500 in 2023, though the report didn't specify how many came from 3D printers.

In a high-profile New York case, police say a 3D-printed gun likely was used to kill UnitedHealthcare's CEO in 2024.

A New York law signed last month and a bill in the California Legislature both would direct panels of experts to come up with standards for firearm

blueprint detection algorithms. The technology would analyse every design submitted for 3D printing, compare it to a digital library of firearm parts, and reject those that are similar.

Though the study process would start now, the mandate that 3D printers come equipped with firearm blocking technology wouldn't begin until 2029 or later, in New York's case, if the study group determines it's not yet feasible.

The concept is a bit like a smartphone app that identifies trees or flowers from an uploaded photo, said Solomon Diamond, an associate engineering professor at Dartmouth College who was among several

experts at a recent online seminar about the legislation.

For 3D printers, one possible method could use a geometric analysis of shapes, dimensions and other structural features to reject print projects that closely resemble firearm parts.

"Geometric search is mature, it's deployed, it is ready to be applied to this problem," said Julian Chultarsky, a technical account manager at Physna, an Ohio-based company that develops such technology.

The Association of 3D Printing supports the legislation in New York and California, but "it's not going to work," Decker said. "It's more of a political statement than anything else."



MARKET COUPLING OPERATOR PROPOSED FOR POWER TRADING

Sole MCO plan gets pushback from Grid India, IEX

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, June 13

SUPPORTING THE rollout of a market coupling mechanism in India — that seeks to discover uniform electricity price across exchanges — Grid Controller of India (Grid India) has called for establishment of a steering committee comprising key stakeholders to act as Market Coupling Operator (MCO).

In its draft CERC (Power Market) (Second Amendment) Regulations, 2026, issued in April, the Central Electricity Regulatory Commission (CERC) had proposed designating Grid India as the sole MCO, responsible for the operation and management of market coupling.

While Power Exchange India Ltd (PXIL) and Hindustan Power Exchange Ltd (HPX) have supported designation of Grid India as MCO, Indian Energy Exchange (IEX) — the country's biggest power trading bourse — opposed the draft regulations' proposal.

India currently has three power exchanges regulated by CERC, where generators, distribution companies, traders and large consumers buy and sell electricity. IEX dominates the market with over 90% share, while PXIL and HPX account for the remainder.

Grid India, on its part, said the proposed designation of the state-owned grid operator as the sole MCO would simplify implementation and enable faster rollout of market coupling, but could also create a single point of failure for electricity market clearing.

While backing the proposal, GRID India said a regulatory fallback mechanism should be introduced to allow power exchanges to undertake price discovery in the event of a techni-



Power Exchange India Ltd (PXIL) and Hindustan Power Exchange Ltd (HPX) supported designation of Grid India as MCO. REUTERS

cal disruption at the MCO.

"... a single MCO design introduces a single point of failure. In case of any disruption, the entire market clearing function would be affected," it said, citing instances in Europe where technical issues led to partial decoupling of electricity markets.

"It is suggested that with a single MCO design, the necessary fallback regulatory mechanism may be introduced allowing the Power Exchanges to carry out price discovery in case of any technical failure at MCO," it added.

In its submission to the regulator, Grid India said the objectives of strengthening regulatory oversight and minimising the need for frequent interventions could be effectively met through a steering committee comprising CERC, Grid India, all power exchanges, and external auditors or market monitors. "The European model of round-robin implementation with a Steering Committee has been successful. This approach adds multiple (8-9) layers of redundancy, robustness, reproducibility and fail-proof price discovery, with a robust maker and checker mechanism," Grid India submitted to the regulator. The proposal in April's draft

regulation marked a shift from the regulator's earlier approach outlined in its July 2025 order directing the implementation of market coupling.

Under that framework, power exchanges were to act as the MCO on a rotational basis, with Grid India serving as the fourth MCO for backup and audit purposes.

Market coupling is a mechanism that aggregates bids from all power exchanges to determine a uniform market-clearing price for electricity.

First introduced under CERC's Power Market Regulations, 2021, the concept is aimed at improving price discovery, reducing price disparities across markets, and enhancing overall market efficiency and stability. Grid India underscored the need of an institutional ring-fencing of market-coupling operations due to the conflicting nature of market clearing and ensuring reliability.

"With transfer of CTU to Grid-India currently underway, transmission planning, system operations and market operations would be under one umbrella, which may be grounds for potential conflict," it added.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Tata's iPhone unit 'contaminated' groundwater: TN pollution body

Reuters
Bengaluru, June 13

AN INDIAN pollution regulator has alleged wastewater discharged from a Tata components factory for Apple's iPhone has contaminated the groundwater for nearby farms and warned of a forced shutdown unless Tata gives a satisfactory explanation.

Tata Electronics is central to Apple's push to diversify iPhone production beyond China and is the second-biggest supplier to Apple in South Asia after Taiwan's Foxconn.

The Tata plant under investigation is in Hosur in southern Tamil Nadu state and makes back panels and other components for iPhones. Farmland owners near the plant had complained for months to the Tamil Nadu Pollution Control Board

that wastewater from the factory was contaminating their land and open wells.

The complaints led to five state inspections between December 2025 and May 2026, according to details from a previously unreported regulatory notice dated May 25 and reviewed by Reuters.

The inspections found that Tata discharged wastewater into a rainwater harvesting pond inside its facility and that the pond overflowed to contaminate "groundwater in the open wells located in the adjacent agricultural lands", the pollution board's warning notice to Tata said.

Tata had not taken any corrective actions on instructions issued by the pollution board in a previous letter dated December 23, 2025, it said in the three-page notice.

Tata Electronics told Reuters in a statement it had commissioned an independent analysis through an accredited laboratory and that the study determined the company was "in full compliance with all regulatory norms".

Tata said it was "committed to responsible business practices and protection of the environment and local communities", and that it had responded to pollution authorities, although giving no further details.

The pollution board in its May notice asked Tata to explain why power to the unit should not be cut and the unit closed for its alleged breach of the rules. Apple, which has strict rules on how its suppliers handle wastewater, and the Tamil Nadu government did not respond to requests for comment.

Why an Assam-Nagaland pact raises hopes of higher oil & gas output from Northeast

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, June 13

THE UNION government, Assam and Nagaland Thursday signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) that paves the way for the resumption of oil and gas exploration along the resource-rich and contested boundary of the two states after three decades.

The Northeast is considered the birthplace of India's oil and gas industry and Assam is among India's major oil and gas producing states.

This agreement is part of that effort, and comes at a time when the country is grappling with high prices of imported oil and gas, as well as supply constraints, owing to the effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz amid the West Asia war.

The government has implemented several policy reforms to encourage investments in India's oil and gas exploration and production sector.

Resumption of oil, gas exploration in contested border

Although these "upstream" activities have long gestation periods, the agreement could augment the country's domestic oil and gas production in the medium to long term. According to officials aware of

the matter, the MoU specifically targets the disputed area belt, or DAB, along the Assam-Nagaland border. With the MoU in place, oil and gas exploration and production are expected to gather pace across more than 1,000 sq km along the Assam-Nagaland border.

Oil, gas, and mineral exploration activities have remained suspended in the DAB for three decades owing to law and order issues amid boundary disputes between the two states.

The DAB is expected to contain promising hydrocarbon prospects. According to the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), the MoU establishes a coordinated framework for facilitating mineral oil operations in the area, ensuring operational continuity, safety and security of personnel and assets, and effective coordination among all stakeholders.

The framework is expected to support exploration and production activities, encourage investment in the upstream petroleum sector and contribute towards the country's energy security objectives, it said.

The MHA said that both states decided that they would not allow any obstacle to India's oil exploration, and would advance on the path of mutual co-operation, as these resources constitute national wealth.

According to the MHA re-



Oil, gas, and mineral exploration activities have remained suspended in the contested area for three decades now. REUTERS

lease, apart from six designated oil and gas fields, the Nagaland government has agreed to oil exploration across Nagaland.

"He (Home Minister Amit Shah) stated that the Government of Assam is also in agreement, as this is a win-win situation for all stakeholders. The Home Minister said that this tripartite agreement will pave the way for mineral exploration and mining across the entire North-East region," the release said.

Govt sees significant oil, gas potential in region

"Since Assam alone accounts for nearly 22% of India's crude oil reserves and around 15% of the country's natural gas

reserves, while Nagaland possesses significant hydrocarbon potential in the Naga-Schuppen Belt of the Assam-Arakan Basin, resources where hydrocarbons flow naturally and those which have huge un-

explored resources, the outlook for E&P [exploration and production] activities in the North East is therefore extremely promising," Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri posted on social media platform X, adding that the MoU paves the way for Nagaland to produce oil and gas after 31 years. According to the MHA release, Shah said that the MoU could potentially help increase oil production capacity from the Northeast from the current capacity of 1,000-1,500 barrels per day by more than

tenfold, adding that the region also possesses "and immense wealth of minerals". While it is difficult to predict exactly how soon this tripartite agreement would start bearing fruit, Shah emphasised that in due course it will bring significant relief to India and enhance the country's self-reliance.

"Union Home Minister Shri Amit Shah expressed confidence that the extraction of oil and gas resources available in Nagaland would significantly reduce India's dependence on foreign sources in this sector. He said that, in the absence of such an agreement and due to certain longstanding challenges, the economic development of both states had remained affected for a considerable period.

"However, he noted that the agreement signed today will open a major pathway for the economic development of both Assam and Nagaland," the MHA release said.

"By creating a framework for cooperation between the governments, this MoU signed in the presence of HM Sh @AmitShah Ji, provides certainty to investors, facilitates operational continuity, enables regulatory coordination and creates conditions necessary for long-term investment decisions," Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri said.

BRIEFLY

No shortage of energy in country, says oil minister Puri

Chandigarh: Union Minister Hardeep Singh Puri on Saturday said there is no shortage of energy in the country and the supply situation of crude oil, LPG and natural gas is quite comfortable. Puri further asserted that, while fuel prices rose considerably in many countries, rates in India dropped by 3.1% from May 2022 to May 2026. "In India between May 2022 and May 2026, prices dropped by 3.1%. On one hand, prices rose by 70-80% in the world, but here (Prime Minister Narendra) Modi ji reduced prices by 3.1%," he said. PTI

Coal Minister Reddy flags missing 40 lakh tonnes of coal

New Delhi: Union Coal Minister G Kishan Reddy has written to the Telangana government, flagging reports that 40 lakh tonnes of coal worth about Rs 1,600 crore is missing and urging an urgent inquiry to ascertain the facts and safeguards at Singareni Collieries Company Ltd (SCCL), already strained by unpaid dues of over Rs 51,500 crore. In a letter dated June 10,

2026, to Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy, the Union Minister said that "a news item published across various newspapers relating to the disappearance of 40 lakh tonnes of coal worth Rs 1600 crore, resulting in significant financial loss to the company". PTI

Biodiversity loss can trigger sovereign debt crises: Experts

London: Biodiversity loss would see India's credit rating falling 4 grades on a 20-point scale and incur an additional \$49 billion a year in debt servicing costs, experts have warned in a new study. Pointing out that biodiverse environments provide valuable economic contributions like insects pollinating crops and oceans underpinning the seafood value chain — what economists call "ecosystem services" — the study said losing these services carries hefty costs. Sovereign ratings assess the ability of countries to repay debt, directly affecting the price governments pay to borrow; it, in turn, affects taxpayers. "The researchers' conservative estimates demonstrate that even partial collapses in fisheries, wild pollination and tropical timber would cause a global GDP decline of \$2 trillion annually," it said. PTI

• IN MARCH, THE PENTAGON HAD DEEMED ANTHROPIC A SUPPLY CHAIN RISK, POTENTIALLY LIMITING ITS USE BY FEDERAL AGENCIES

Why US has barred foreigners from accessing Anthropic's latest AI models

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, June 13

ANTHROPIC HAS suspended all foreign access to its most advanced artificial intelligence (AI) models — Fable 5 and Mythos 5 — after the US government issued an export control order citing national security concerns.

Export controls are typically used to restrict the supply of physical goods to other countries, such as advanced US graphics chips to China.

WHY THE EXPORT CONTROL ORDER?

Anthropic said that it received the US government's order early on June 13, but the communication did not provide specific details of the administration's national security concerns. According to the company, the government possibly believes that it has be-

come aware of a method of bypassing, or "jailbreaking" Fable 5. In a blog post, the company said that the order would block all access to Fable 5 and Mythos 5 by any foreign national, whether inside or outside the United States, including foreign national Anthropic employees. "We reviewed a demonstration of this specific technique being used to identify a small number of previously known, minor vulnerabilities. These vulnerabilities all appear relatively simple, and we have found that other publicly-available models are able to discover them as well without requiring a bypass," Anthropic said.

But, it cautioned that the US government had only given Anthropic "verbal evidence" of a "potential narrow, non-universal jailbreak, which essentially consists of asking the



Anthropic said the US government's order did not provide specific details of the administration's national security concerns. REUTERS

model to read a specific code-base and fix any software flaws". "Our understanding is that one potential jailbreak was shared with the government. We have reviewed a report that we believe is the basis of the government's directive and validated that the level of capability displayed there is widely

available from other models (including OpenAI's GPT-5.5), and is used every day by the defenders who keep systems safe," the company said in its blog post.

In March, after talks over how Anthropic's AI could be used in military operations, the Pentagon had deemed An-

thropic a supply chain risk, potentially limiting its use by federal agencies. This came after disagreements over how the military could use Claude, with Anthropic insisting on safeguards preventing the AI from being used for mass domestic surveillance or for developing fully autonomous weapons systems.

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tems. The order comes as Anthropic is preparing for public listing in the US, after being recently valued \$965 billion.

WHAT ARE ANTHROPIC'S FABLE 5 AND MYTHOS 5?

Fable 5 and Mythos 5, launched earlier this week, are Anthropic's most advanced publicly available AI models. They are built on the underlying "Mythos-class" architecture — the company's other AI model named Mythos Preview which it has not released publicly over fears of misuse.

Anthropic had previously claimed that Mythos Preview was able to find severe vulnerabilities in "every major operating system and web browser", including one that had gone undetected for nearly three decades — spooking regulators around the world for its potential impact on critical infrastructure.

The company had started giving exclusive access to a select few organisations under its Project Glasswing. In India, Anthropic was discussing sharing Mythos Preview with a handful of entities, but was yet to share the model.

Since the company was not able to publicly release Mythos Preview, it announced earlier this week that it would launch Fable 5 and Mythos 5 instead, which are both based on the same underlying model, but have additional safeguards baked in. In particular, requests related to sensitive cybersecurity or biological domains are filtered. When the system detects a potentially high-risk query, it automatically routes the user to a less capable model rather than allowing the request to be handled by the full Mythos-level system.

"We've therefore launched

the model with safeguards that mean queries on some topics will instead receive a response from our next-most-capable model, Claude Opus 4.8.

To release the model both safely and quickly, we've tuned these safeguards conservatively—they'll sometimes catch harmless requests, though they trigger, on average, in less than 5% of sessions. With more capable models arriving in the coming months, we're working to improve our safeguards and reduce false positives as quickly as we can," Anthropic said in a blog post earlier.

The company also said that for a small group of cyber experts and infrastructure providers, it was launching Claude Mythos 5. It's the same underlying model as Fable 5, but with the safeguards lifted in some areas.

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

ई-ऑक्शन सूचना

मण्डल रेल प्रबन्धक (राशिज्म), उत्तर पश्चिम रेलवे, बीकानेर भारत के राष्ट्रपति की ओर से बीकानेर मण्डल पर विभिन्न स्टेशनों पर एसी वेटिंग रूम का संचालन, रखरखाव एवं रतनगढ़ स्टेशन पर पार्किंग के ठेको के लिए ई-ऑक्शन प्रारम्भ किये गये है जिनका विवरण निम्न प्रकार है:-

केटलॉग संख्या	कार्य का नाम व स्थान	ई ऑक्शन की दिनांक व समय
EA-WRL-BKN-01-2	1. AC वेटिंग रूम/ होल का संचालन और रखरखाव- श्रीगंगानगर, हिसार, मंडी डबवाली, सिरसा, लालगढ़ एवं भिवानी स्टेशन पर	दिनांक 29.06.2026 समय 13:00 बजे ई-ऑक्शन होगा
EA-Parking-5-26	2. पार्किंग- रतनगढ़ स्टेशन पर	दिनांक 29.06.2026 समय 15:00 बजे ई-ऑक्शन होगा

अन्य सूचना एवं नियम व शर्तों के लिये IREPS की वेबसाइट www.ireps.gov.in पर लॉगिन करें।

Please join us on  /NWRailways **861-AM/26**

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./ 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Manish Chopra, S/o: Vinod Chopra, R/o: BB 68-B, West Shalimar Bagh, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.: 10/2020, U/s: 33 Delhi Excise ACT, P.S. Subzi Mandi, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Manish Chopra** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Manish Chopra** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Manish Chopra of P.S. Subzi Mandi, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **31.08.2026**.

By Order

Sh. Preeti Rajoria
Ld. JMFC-07, Room No. 32,
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/7828/N/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person, namely, **Imran, S/o: Israr, R/o: H.No. 358, Upperkot, Main Bazar-2, Khari Kua Dehat, Loni, Ghaziabad, U.P.** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 04/2019, U/s: 379/411 IPC**, registered at **P.S.: Karol Bagh, New Delhi**, and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused person, **Imran**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person, **Imran**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said, accused person, **Imran, FIR No. 04/2019, U/s: 379/411 IPC**, registered at **P.S.: Karol Bagh, New Delhi**, is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **28.07.2026**.

By Order

Sh Nishat Bangarh
Judicial Magistrate First Class-1
(Central), Room No 180
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/7857/CD/2026
(Court Matter)

कार्यालय कार्यपालन अभियंता, ग्रामीण यांत्रिकी सेवा, सभाग जगदलपुर

ई-प्रोक्यूसमेंट निविदा सूचना क्र. 01/2026-27 (प्रथम निविदा आमंत्रण)

क्रमांक/1433/एस.ए.सी./ प्राचा सेवा/2026-27 जगदलपुर, दिनांक 09/06/2026

छत्तीसगढ़ के राज्यपाल के और से एकीकृत पंजीयन प्रणाली के अंतर्गत लोक निर्माण विभाग में सक्षम श्रेणी में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से निम्न निर्माण कार्य हेतु निविदा ऑनलाईन (online) दिनांक 16.06.2026 तक आमंत्रित की जाती है:-

क्र०	कार्य का विवरण	अनुमानित लागत (रुपए लाख में)	मैनुअल दस्तावेज कार्यालय में पहुँचने की अंतिम तिथि
1	2	3	4
1	शासकीय दृष्टि एवं ब्रवण बाधितार्थ उ.मा.वि. आडावाल परिसर में अतिरिक्त कक्षाएं एक्टिविटी कक्ष निर्माण विकास खण्ड जगदलपुर	170.76	19.06.2026

2. उक्त निर्माण कार्यों की निविदा सामान्य शर्तें, धरोहर राशि, विस्तृत निविदा विज्ञप्ति, निविदा दस्तावेज व अन्य जानकारी कार्यालयीन अवधि में कार्यालय से प्राप्त की जा सकती है। साथ ही यह जानकारी विभागीय वेबसाइट <https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in> में दिनांक 09.06.2026 से डाउनलोड की जा सकती है।

हस्ता./-

कार्यपालन अभियंता ग्रामीण यांत्रिकी सेवा सभाग जगदलपुर

NO - 262701330/6

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT, CIRCLE No.1, RAIPUR (C.G.) Tender Notice

Contractors, Registered appropriate class in **Unified Registration System** [e- Registration] invited Online tenders for the following works :-

NIT No./ System Tender No.	Name of Work	Probable amount of contract
1	2	3
76/192623	Construction Of Barrack- "A & B" for INT at Old Phq Campus Distt.-Raipur Chhattisgarh (1st Call)	Rs. 41.15 Lakh
79/192947	Ordinary Maintenance Work of Residential & Non Residential Building at Arang Section No.-1, Section No.-02 & Kharora Section, Under Sub Division No.-4(Arange), Raipur (C.G.) (1st Call)	Rs. 50.00 Lakh
78/192949	Construction of Lounge & Porch at State Hangar Mana, Raipur Chhattisgarh. (1st Call)	Rs. 78.23 Lakh
77/192953	Strengthening of Torla Kathiya Abhanpur Road (Km 1/2 to Km 3/2) Length- 2.200 Km. Dist Raipur C.G. (2nd) Call)	Rs. 185.46 Lakh
07/192954	Road Safety Work for Vidhansabha Tal To Haritage Hospital Kachna Raipur (C.G.) (3rd Call)	Rs. 131.05 Lakh

NIT No.76 System Tender No.192623, NIT No.79 System Tender No.192947, NIT No.78 System Tender No.192949 Last date of tender Download Date up to 30.06.2026 & NIT No.77 System Tender No.192953 Last date of tender Download Date up to 25.06.2026 & NIT No.07 System Tender No.192954 Last date of tender Download Date up to 22.06.2026 (Time 17:30 PM)

Note:

All eligible/interested contractors are mandated to get enrolled on the eProcurement portal (<https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in>) in order to download the tender documents and participate in the subsequent bidding process.

Sd/-

Superintending Engineer
No. 262701405/5 P.W.D., Durg Circle Durg (C.G.)

रजिस्ट्री सं.डी.एल.-33004/99

**भारत का राजपत्र**
The Gazette of India

REGD.NO. D.L.-33004/99

सौ.जी.-डी.एल.-अ.-11062026-273332

CG-DL-E-11062026-273332

असाधारण EXTRAORDINARY

भाग II-खण्ड 3-उप-खण्ड (ii)

PART II-Section 3-Sub-Section (ii)

प्राधिकार से प्रकाशित

Published by Authority

सं. 2821]

नई दिल्ली, सोमवार, जून 8, 2026/ज्येष्ठ 18, 1948

No.2821] NEW DELHI, MONDAY, JUNE 8, 2026/JYAISTHA 18, 1948

सड़क परिवहन और राजमार्ग मंत्रालय

अधिसूचना

नई दिल्ली, 8 जून, 2026

का.आ. 2915(अ).- केन्द्रीय सरकार, राष्ट्रीय राजमार्ग अधिनियम 1956 (1956 का 48) (जिसे इसमें इसके पश्चात् उक्त अधिनियम कहा गया है) की धारा 3क की उप-धारा (1) द्वारा प्रदत्त शक्तियों का प्रयोग करते हुए यह समाधान हो जाने के पश्चात् कि उत्तर प्रदेश राज्य के मथुरा जिले में राष्ट्रीय राजमार्ग सं.-44 पर से शुरू होकर यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे को जोड़ने वाले प्रस्तावित 6 लेन वृंदावन बाईपास के निर्माण के कि.मी. 0.000 से कि.मी. 15.340 तक के भू-खण्ड के निर्माण (6 लेन पेड्ड शोल्डर सहित का बनाना आदि), अनुक्षण, प्रबन्धन और प्रचालन के लोक प्रयोजन के लिए वह भूमि अपेक्षित है जिसका संक्षिप्त वर्णन नीचे अनुसूची में दिया गया है, ऐसी भूमि का अर्जन करने के अपने आशय की घोषणा करती है।

कोई भी व्यक्ति, जो उक्त भूमि में हितबद्ध है, उक्त अधिनियम की धारा 3ग की उप-धारा (1) के अधीन पूर्वोक्त प्रयोजन के लिए ऐसी भूमि के उपयोग पर राजपत्र में इस अधिसूचना के प्रकाशन की तारीख से इक्कीस दिन के भीतर अपनी आपत्ति प्रकट कर सकेगा।

ऐसी प्रत्येक आपत्ति सक्षम प्राधिकारी, अर्थात् सक्षम जिलाधिकारी (प्रशासन), मथुरा की लिखित रूप में प्रस्तुत की जाएगी और उसमें उसके आधार अधिकृत किए जाएंगे और अपर प्राधिकारी, आपत्तिकर्ता की व्यक्तिगत रूप में या किसी विधिक पेशीवर द्वारा सुने जाने का अवसर देगा और ऐसी आपत्तियों की सुनवाई के पश्चात् तथा ऐसी और जाँच करने के पश्चात्, यदि कोई हो, जिसे सक्षम प्राधिकारी आवश्यक समझे, आदेश द्वारा या तो आपत्तियों को अनुज्ञात कर सकेगा या अनुज्ञात कर सकेगा।

उक्त अधिनियम की धारा 3ग की उप-धारा (2) के अधीन सक्षम प्राधिकारी द्वारा किया गया कोई भी आदेश अंतिम होगा।

इस अधिसूचना के अन्तर्गत आने वाली भूमि के रेखांक और अन्य ब्यौरे सक्षम प्राधिकारी के उक्त कार्यालय में उपलब्ध हैं और उनका हितबद्ध व्यक्तियों द्वारा निरीक्षण किया जा सकता है।

अनुसूची

नई दिल्ली, 8 जून, 2026

का.आ. 2915(अ).- केन्द्रीय सरकार, राष्ट्रीय राजमार्ग सं.-44 पर से शुरू होकर यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे को जोड़ने वाले प्रस्तावित 6 लेन वृंदावन बाईपास के निर्माण के कि.मी.0.000 से कि.मी. 15.340 के लिए अर्जन की जाने वाले संरचना रहित अथवा संरचना सहित भूमि का संक्षिप्त विवरण।

[फा.सं. CE-RO/LKO/NH-19/2024-25/754/3A]

शेख अमीनखान, निदेशक

MINISTRY OF ROAD TRANSPORT AND HIGHWAYS NOTIFICATION

New Delhi, the 8th June, 2026

S.O. 2915(E). In exercise of powers conferred by sub-section (1) of section 3A of the National Highways Act, 1956 (48 of 1956) (hereinafter referred to as the said Act), the Central Government, after being satisfied that for the public purpose, the land, the brief description of which is given in the Schedule below, is required for Construction (6 lane with paved shoulder etc.), maintenance, management and operation of Vrindavan bypass on NH-44 connecting Yamuna Expressway in the stretch of land from Km. 0.000 to Km. 15.340 in the district of MATHURA in the state of UTTAR PRADESH, hereby declares its intention to acquire such land.

Any person interested in the said land may, within twenty-one days from the date of publication of this notification in the Official Gazette, object to the use of such land for the aforesaid purpose under sub-section(1) of section 3C of the said Act.

Every such objection shall be made to the Competent Authority, namely, ADM(E), Mathura in writing and shall set out the grounds thereof and the Competent Authority shall give the objector an opportunity of being heard, either in person or by a legal practitioner, and may, after hearing all such objections and after making such further enquiry, if any, as the Competent Authority thinks necessary, by order, either allow or disallow the objections.

Any order made by the Competent Authority under sub-section (2) of section 3C of the said Act shall be final.

The land plans and other details of the land to be acquired under their notification are available and can be inspected by the interested person at the aforesaid office of the Competent Authority.

SCHEDULE
Brief Description of the land to be acquired with or without structures for construction of 6 lane Vrindavan Bypass on NH 44 connecting Yamuna Expressway in the stretch of land from Km. 0.000 to Km. 15.340 in the state of UTTAR PRADESH.

[F.No. CE-RO/LKO/NH-19/2024-25/754/3A]

SHAIKH AMINKHAN, Director

Public Works Department

Office of The Superintending Engineer, Pwd., Raipur Circle No.-1 Raipur. (C.G.)

REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL (RFP)

(1st Call)

No. 08/Raipur/2026-27

Raipur, Dated. 08.06.2026

Public Works Department (PWD) invites proposal for Planning, Design, Estimation and related services for the work

वित्तीय वर्ष 2025-26 के बजट में शामिल छत्तीसगढ़ इंस्टीट्यूट ऑफ टेक्नोलॉजी (सी.जी.आई.टी.) रायपुर का भवन निर्माण हेतु वास्तुविद् नियुक्त करने बाबत। (वर्ष 2026-27 का बजट मद क्र.-1455)

Situated at Raipur

Probable cost of project Rs. 575.99 Lakh.

Minimum eligibility for participants shall be as below :-

S. N.	Building project cost	The applicant firms, firms forming Joint venture/ consortium shall be	Earnest money (In shape as per annexure I) Favor of Executive Engineer, PWD Division No.-02 Raipur
1	For project cost Between 01 to 10 Crore	Empanelled as architect in Class "D" & Above Class in C.G. PWD.	Rs. 3,000=00

General Condition: All the documents & Information as per para 6.4, shall be submitted through speed post/Registered post. so as to reach the office of under signed on or before dated 30.06.2026 by 17.30 hour. Any documents received after the last date and time will not be entertained.

The detailed RFP is available on the website www.cg.nic.in/pwdraipur & <http://cgstate.gov.in/> from where it can be downloaded for submission. CG&PWD reserves the right to reject all or any of the application without assigning any reason. Right to modify the process of Pre-qualification is reserved with CG&PWD.

Sd/-

Superintending Engineer
Public Works Department
Raipur Circle No-1 Raipur

No. 262701380/4

जिला अभियंता का कार्यालय जिला परिषद, रामगढ़

अति-अल्पकालीन निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

ई-निविदा सं० :- ZP/RAMGARH/04/2026-27

कार्य की विस्तृत विवरणी :- DMFT

मद -

मुप संख्या	योजना का नाम	प्राक्कलित राशि	अग्रघन की राशि	परिमाणु विपत्र का मूल्य (रु०)	कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि	निबंधन श्रेणी
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1	ग्राम रौता के कैंदिगा टोला से बन्दु टोला तक पथ निर्माण।	81,18,700.00	1,63,000.00	10,000.00	06 (छ. माह)	II
2	पंचायत हरोला स्थित सरस्वती शिशु विद्या मंदिर से बारमगढ़ होते हुए सी०बी०सी०एल० पुल तक पी०सी०सी० सड़क का निर्माण।	1,64,24,710.00	3,29,000.00	10,000.00	06 (छ. माह)	II
3	पंचायत लगगा ग्राम गेगदा महुआ मोड़ से लेकर ग्राम जराय दीपा टोला पानी टकी तक पी०सी०सी० पथ निर्माण	1,73,67,600.00	3,48,000.00	10,000.00	06 (छ. माह)	II
4	Construction of PCC (Approach Road) form Gola-Rajrapra main Road to reach Jharkhand government Tool Room ITI, Gola.	62,28,600.00	1,25,000.00	10,000.00	06 (छ. माह)	II

1. वेबसाइट में निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि- दिनांक- 20.06.2026

2. ई-निविदा डालने / प्राप्ति की तिथि एवं समय- दिनांक 20.06.2026 से दिनांक 27.06.2026 अपराह्न 5:00 बजे तक।

3. निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय- दिनांक - 29.06.2026 को पूर्वाह्न 11:00 बजे।

4. निविदा आमंत्रित करने वाले पदाधिकारी का पदनाम एवं पता- जिला अभियंता, जिला परिषद, रामगढ़।

5. ई-निविदा प्रकोष्ठ का दुरभाष नं०- 9801557645

6. निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रघन की राशि केवल **Online mode** द्वारा स्वीकृत होगी।

7. निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रघन की राशि का ई- भुगतान संवेदक द्वारा जिस बैंक खाता से किया जायेगा, उसी खाते में अग्रघन की राशि वापस होगी। अगर बैंक खाता को बैंक कर दिया जाता है। तो उसकी सारी जवाबदेही संवेदक की होगी।

8. निविदा **Double Bid** पद्धति से होगा।

9. इस निविदा में जिला परिषद, रामगढ़ के अंतर्गत पंजीकृत श्रेणी-II के संवेदक भाग ले सकते हैं।

विस्तृत जानकारी के लिए वेबसाइट Jharkhandtenders.gov.in एवं कार्यालय के सूचनापट पर देखा जा सकता है।

ह०/-

जिला अभियंता,
जिला परिषद, रामगढ़

PR 382337 District(26-27)#D

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

BORDER SECURITY FORCE

 CONSTABLE MAHLA MAHESH BHAJ 89 BN BSF 01.06.1970 – 14.06.1994	 CONSTABLE MOHD AMIN WAGY 89 BN BSF 01.02.1973 – 14.06.1994
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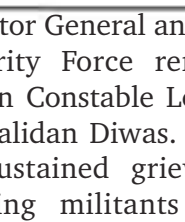
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans Constable Mahla Mahesh Bhai and Mohd Amin Wagy on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained grievous bullet injuries while fighting militants in area of BOP Sita, Manipur and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

 CONSTABLE SRIRAM MANJHI 110 BN BSF 12.01.1996 – 14.06.1993	 CONSTABLE JAGDISH SINGH 110 BN BSF 05.08.1969 – 14.06.1993
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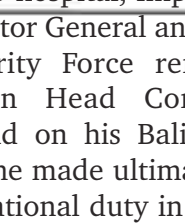
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans Constables Sriram Manjhi and Jagdish Singh on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained grievous injuries while fighting militants in Srinagar area, J&K and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

 HEAD CONSTABLE LALA RAM 191 BN BSF 01.09.1943 – 14.06.1993	 CONSTABLE DEBASHIS DUTTA 191 BN BSF 04.03.1969 – 14.06.1993
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Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans Head Constable Lala Ram and Constable Debashis Dutta on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained grievous injuries in an IED blast, triggered by Naxals in area of Karimnagar, Andhra Pradesh and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

 CONSTABLE LOKESH CHAND DAS 86 BN BSF 01.07.1949 – 14.06.1986	 HEAD CONSTABLE BAIDYANATH PRASAD 06 BN BSF 07.10.1974 – 14.06.2024
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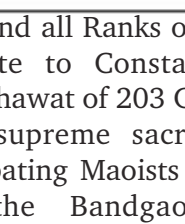
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Lokesh Chand Das on his Balidan Diwas. On 06th June 1986, he sustained grievous injuries while fighting militants on Ukhrul-Imphal road, Manipur and succumbed to his injuries on 14th June 2025 at RIMS hospital, Imphal.

 HEAD CONSTABLE BAIDYANATH PRASAD 06 BN BSF 07.10.1974 – 14.06.2024	 HEAD CONSTABLE BAIDYANATH PRASAD 06 BN BSF 07.10.1974 – 14.06.2024
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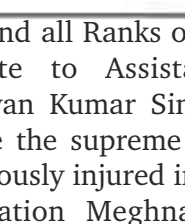
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Head Constable Baidyanath Prasad on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he made ultimate sacrifice while on operational duty in area of BOP Bheem, Jalpaiguri, West Bengal.

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE

DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Hajari Lal of 1 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating underground insurgent elements in Manipur on 14 June 1966. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

 Veer Balidani Constable Himmat Singh Shekhawat 203 CoBRA Bn 21-08-1983 To 14-06-2010	 Veer Balidani Constable Satyvan Kumar Singh 134 Bn 08-02-1991 To 14-06-2025
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DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Himmat Singh Shekhawat of 203 CoBRA Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating Maoists during an operation in the Bandgaon area of West Singhbhum, Jharkhand on 14 June 2010. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

 Veer Balidani Assistant Sub Inspector Satyvan Kumar Singh 134 Bn 08-02-1991 To 14-06-2025	 Constable Harvinder Singh
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DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Assistant Sub Inspector Satyvan Kumar Singh of 134 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice after being grievously injured in an IED blast during Operation Meghnaad in Sundargarh, Odisha on 14 June 2025. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

INDO-TIBETAN BORDER POLICE(TBP)

Constable Harvinder Singh

ITBP salutes its braveheart Constable Harvinder Singh of 24th Battalion, who made the supreme sacrifice in the line of duty on this day in J&K in 1995.

"IMPORTANT"

Whilst care is taken prior to acceptance of advertising copy, it is not possible to verify its contents. The Indian Express (P) Limited cannot be held responsible for such contents, nor for any loss or damage incurred as a result of transactions with companies, associations or individuals advertising in its newspapers or Publications. We therefore recommend that readers make necessary inquiries before sending any monies or entering into any agreements with advertisers or otherwise acting on an advertisement in any manner whatsoever.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Yogesh Kumar Sharma, S/o: Ramji Lal Sharma, R/o: B-153, E/2A, Lawyers Colony, Agra, Uttar Pradesh-282005** also at **Phase-1, Vrindavan, Uttar Pradesh** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **CT Case No.: 337/24, U/s: 138 NI ACT, P.S. Jagatpuri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Yogesh Kumar Sharma** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Yogesh Kumar Sharma** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Yogesh Kumar Sharma of P.S. Jagatpuri, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **15.07.2026**.

By Order

Sh. Akhil Malik
Ld. JMFC-02, Shahdara Distt.,
Room No. 38, Ground Floor,
Karkardooma Court, Delhi

DP/7844/SHD/2026

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

Corrigendum to Notice for Invitation of tender

For and behalf of President of India, CRSE (Chg)/NWR invites tender as per following details:FOR TENDER NOTICE No: M/442/2 Mechanized laundry/KWP dated 10/06/2025 (GeM Bid No.GEM/2026/ B/7648035) may be read as GeM Bid No.GEM/2026/B/ 7648037

858-AM/26

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

Open E-Tender Notice

For and behalf of the President of India, the Dy. Chief Engineer/Bridge Line-2/North Western Railway, Jaipur invites online open E-Tendering system(Single Packet) for the following works on prescribed electronics forms:- **Sr.No. 1. E-Tender No: DYCEBRLINE-II-2025-01. 2 Name of the work with its location:- Replacement of Bearings & other miscellaneous work of Bridge No. 124 (PSC Span- 169x18.30m) and ROR 214LA (3X18.30m) Welded composite in JP division. 3. Approximate Cost of Work: 1.38,05,080.01; 4. Earnest Money to be deposited: 2.76,100.00; 5. Completion Period: 12 Months 6. Date & Time Closing of tender: 05/06/2026 at 15:00 Hrs 7. Website particulars and notice board location where complete detail of tender can be seen : www.ireps.gov.in 860-AM/26**

Please join us on  /NWRailways

**WEST CENTRAL RAILWAY**

Q/o. Dy. CE(TM)BPL, DRM Office Building, 2nd Floor, Habibganj, Bhopal - 462 024.

E-Tendering Notice No. 02/2026-27, Dated 12.06.2026

Dy.CE(TM), WCR, BPL, acting for and on behalf of the President of India, invites E-Tender for supply of following items. Tender details and documents are uploaded on IREPS on date 12.06.2026. For more details, visit www.ireps.gov.in. Any corrigendum, if required, will be uploaded on website 10 days before closing date of bidding. Details are also displayed on notice board of Dy.CE(TM)BPL office, till the date of closing of instant tender. All the bidders must see the website before bidding. S.N.: 1. Name of work: Various type of electrical works during IOH/POH/Repair of Track Machine. Tender No.: WCRBPLTM26W05. Dated 12.06.2026. Estimated Cost of Tender: ₹ 81,09,574.78. EMD: ₹ 1,62,200/- Delivery/Completion Period: 12 Months. Date of Opening: 06.07.2026.

XEN(TM), WCR, Bhopal.

सबक भारत अभियान एक कदम स्वच्छता की ओर

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

E-Tender

DRM(S&T) NWR, Ajmer on behalf of the President of India invites E-Tender for the following work up to 15:00 Hrs. on the mentioned date. **Tender No. 1. DRM-S&T-46-2025-26-Re-tender, 2. DRM-S&T-02-2026-27-Re-tender, 3. DRM-S&T-09-2026-27-Re-tender, 4. DRM-S&T-20-2026-27; Name of Work: 1. Ajmer Division: Provision for reliability improvement and upkeep/sustaining of various components/parts of IPS at various stations over Ajmer division. 2. Ajmer Division:- Provision of S&T Associated work in C/W Chittaurgarh-Udaipur-TTR(FS+TWS+WCMSO)-45 set in Ajmer Division 3. Ajmer Division: Comprehensive Repair Maintenance Contract of Window/Split Air Conditioners (Capacity-1.5 & 2 Ton) at various stations/IBH over Ajmer Division for 03 years. 4. Ajmer Division- *Provision of 72 CCTV cameras with monitoring and recording system at all Major Booking office & PRS counters, 22 Stations (29 Locations) ."; Approximate cost of work: 1. Rs. 9887513.15, 2. Rs. 7644196.92, 3. Rs. 1499272.32, 4. Rs. 13702112.05; **Bid security:** 1. Rs. 197800.00, 2. Rs. 152900.00, 3. Rs. 30000.00, 4. Rs. 274000.00; Date & Time of opening E-Tender-08.07.2026 at 15:30 Hrs. The details of above E-Tender are available on website www.ireps.gov.in **859-AM/26****

Please join us on  /NWRailways

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Tara Chand, S/o: Rishi Ram, R/o: WZ-1488, near Tulsi Ram Bagichi, Nangal Raya, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 212/2017, U/s 427/451/306/34 IPC, P.S.: Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Tara Chand** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Tara Chand** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Tara Chand** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 212/2017, U/s 427/451/306/34 IPC, P.S.: Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** and is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **21.07.2026**.

By Order

Ms. Bharti Beniwal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05
Room No. 114, 1st Floor, Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/7768/ON/2026

(Court Matter)

**कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, 8वॉ वृत्त लोक निर्माण विभाग, नई टिहरी**

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER, 8TH CIRCLE, PWD TEHRI, TEHRI GARHWAL

E-mail.- sepwdtehri@rediffmail.com

Letter No. 2291/01Cash-Tender-08/2026-27

Date- 11/06/2026

Request for Expression of Interest (EOI)

The Uttarakhand Public Works Department invites Expressions of Interest (EOI) from qualified and experienced national and international consulting firms as follows :-

Project Title: Consulting Assignment for Preparation of Detailed Project Report for New Long Bridges on the Ring Road along the Tehri Lake. (Tentative spans of bridges :-Pipaldali-450-00m, Dobra Chanthi-500.0m, Hadhkikhala-150.00m and Koti-370.00m)

Location: Tehri Lake, situated in the Tehri Garhwal district of Uttarakhand, India.

Objective: To identify and shortlist potential consultants capable of preparing a DPR for the bridges.

Relevant details regarding consultancy work will be available on <https://pwd.uk.gov.in> and <https://tehri.nic.in> from dated 18.06.2026 onwards.

Sd/-

Superintending Engineer
8th Circle, PWD, New Tehri

BRIDGE

Last week's hand was of general interest in partnership understanding in defence. If West and East are well tuned the defence would be a cinch but, mind you, there are chances to slip and make a mistake. Dealer: West Vulnerable: Both

NORTH		EAST	
♠ 72		♠ J	
♥ A 9 4		♥ 10 6 5	
♦ A J 8 3		♦ K 10 9 7 4 2	
♣ K 7 5 4		♣ A 9 6	
WEST	NORTH	EAST	SOUTH
pass	pass	2 ♦	2 ♣
pass	3NT	pass	4 ♣
pass	pass	pass	

You are East. Partner leads the the queen of diamonds. Declarer wins the trick in the dummy and leads a trump to West's ace. West returns the two of clubs to your ace. What next? The killing defense to 4 S is easy looking at all four hands. West leads the queen of diamonds, wins the ace of trump, and leads a club to partner's ace. Then East cashes the king of diamonds and leads a third round of diamonds, promoting West's 9 of spades for the setting trick. The defense is not so easy at the table. After a 2 D opening, it's not at all clear to East that the queen lead is a singleton. And if West wins the ace of spades at trick two and switches to a club, what club spot should he lead? Suppose West leads the 2 of clubs, hoping the 2 is a suit-preference card. Declarer plays the king from dummy and East doesn't know where the queen is. He would have to play the king of diamonds and see it get ruffed.

THE WEST HAND: ♠ K Q 10 8 ♥ J 4 ♦ 10 9 5 3 2 ♠ J 10
THE SOUTH HAND: ♠ 9 3 ♥ Q 10 6 5 ♦ K 7 6 4 ♣ Q 6 3

Suppose West shifts to the 8 of clubs at trick three. East wins the ace, sees no future in clubs but still is unsure whether a diamond is cashing. Perhaps a heart shift is better, through South's queen doubleton. How can East know what to do? The answer, is that if West holds the queen doubleton of diamonds, he should continue diamonds. So when he doesn't, he has a singleton. The 2 of clubs then asks partner to play diamonds and the 8 of clubs asks for a heart. For a change, a hand on bidding.

NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ J 4		♠ K 6	
♥ A 9		♥ 10 8 7 6	
♦ J 10 3		♦ A 8 7 2	
♣ A K Q 9 7 5		♣ 8 3 2	
WEST	NORTH	EAST	SOUTH
1 ♣	2C ♣		

What does East bid now if (a) East/West play four card majors (b) East/West play five card majors?

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

I cannot live without ____ - Thomas Jefferson (S)

CLNOO

AEEKTB

THESE

ACEHLK

ANSWER: I cannot live without books - Thomas Jefferson

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Puran Dass** S/o Harender Singh R/o H. No. M-07, Galaxy Apartment, Vikaspuri, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence case FIR No. 557/2021 u/s 33/38/58 Delhi Excise Act, 188/269/270 IPC, 51 (B) DM Act & 3 Excise Duty Act at P.S. Nihal Vihar, New Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Puran Dass** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Puran Dass** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding u/s 82 Cr. P.C. has been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Puran Dass** accused of FIR No. 557/2021 u/s 33/38/58 Delhi Excise Act, 188/269/270 IPC, 51 (B) DM Act & 3 Excise Duty Act at P.S. Nihal Vihar, New Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on **17.07.2026**. By Order: Ms. Komal Garg Judicial Magistrate First Class-03 (West) Room No. 292, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, सिंचाई कार्य मण्डल, अलीगढ़

पत्रांक:- 2613 / सिकांमंअ/ ई-निविदा/2026-27, दिनांक:- 08.06.2026

अल्पकालीन ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या-02/एसई0/2026-27

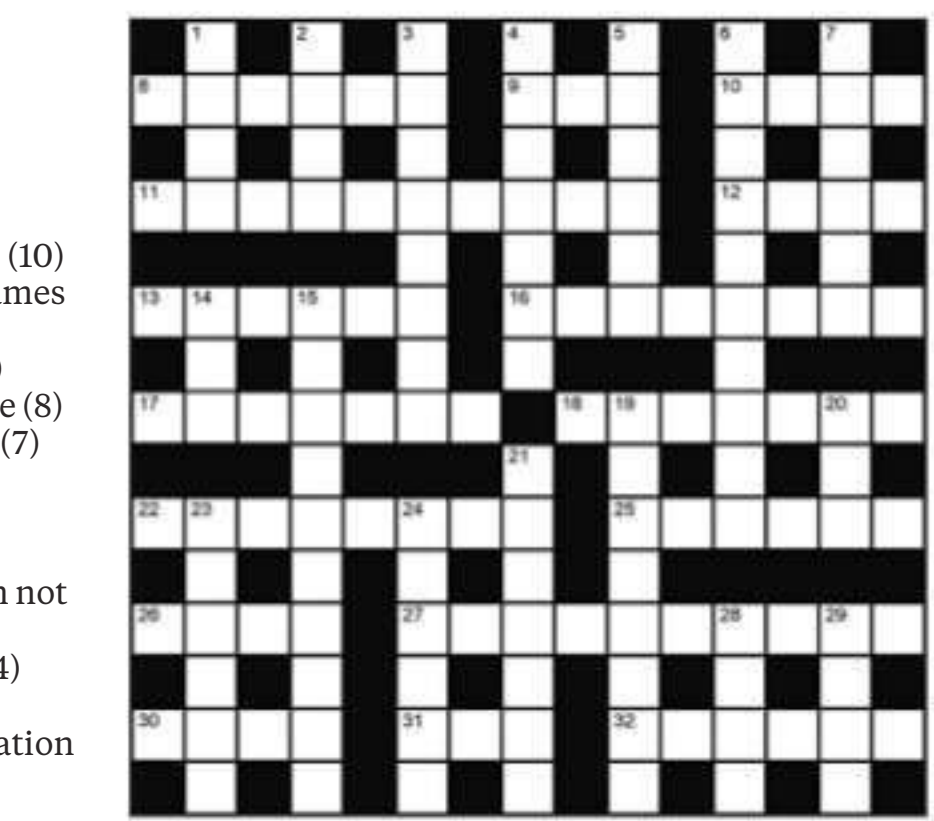
महामहिम राज्यपाल उत्तर प्रदेश की ओर से निम्नलिखित कार्यों हेतु सिंचाई विभाग में वनीकृत श्रेणी में पंजीकृत फर्म/ठेकेदारों से दिनांक 16.07.2026 रायं 5:00 बजे तक <http://etender.up.nic.in> के माध्यम से ऑनलाइन निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती हैं। निविदादाता द्वारा टेन्डरकल / प्री-क्वालिफिकेशन बिड एवं फाइनलियस बिड दिनांक 02.07.2026 को पुनः 10:00 बजे से दिनांक 16.07.2026 रायं 5:00 बजे तक ऑनलाइन डाउनलोड/अपलोड की जा सकेगी। फर्म/ठेकेदारों की टेन्डरकल /प्री-क्वालिफिकेशन बिड दिनांक 17.07.2026 को अपरान्ह 12:00 बजे अयोध्यालक्षरी के कार्यालय कक्ष में मुख्य अभियन्ता (रमंगा), सिंचाई विभाग, उ०प्र०, कानपुर द्वारा गठित समिति द्वारा ऑनलाइन खोली जायेगी। टेन्डरकल/प्री-क्वालिफिकेशन बिड में क्वालीफाइड फर्म/ठेकेदारों को फाइनलियस बिड ऑनलाइन खोली जायेगी। कार्यालय बन्द होने या राजकीय अवकाश होने की दशा में यह निविदा आगले कार्य दिवस में उसी समय पर खोली जायेगी। एक या समस्त निविदाओं को अनुबंध गठित होने से पूर्व तक आंशिक या पूर्णरूप से बिना कारण बताये संशोधित / निरस्त करने का अधिकार अयोध्यालक्षरी को होगा। ई-निविदा अपलोड करने से पहले निविदादाता कार्य स्थल का निरीक्षण एवं निविदा से सम्बंधित नियम एवं शर्तों का पली भाँति अध्ययन कर लें। कार्यों का विवरण निम्नवत है:-

क्र.सं.	लॉट सं.	कार्य का विवरण	कार्य की अनुमानित लागत (रु.सं. लाय गे) (Without GST)	खरीद राशि (रु.सं. लाय गे)	कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि	निविदा दृष्टिकोण+ जीएसटी+स्टेशन (रु.सं. में ऑन लाईन जमा करना होगा)	पंजीकृत श्रेणी	कार्य से संबंधित अधिकारी अभियन्ता सिंचाई कार्य मण्डल, अलीगढ़
1	01	मिचली गंगा नहर की किमी0 23.860 से किमी0 45.900 तक की नये चारों बैक की सोपेनशील स्क्वायर पर सुदृढीकरण हेतु बल्ली पाइलिंग का कार्य।	569.05	11.39	12 माह	7900.00	ए/एच/उपभ	अधिशासी अभियन्ता, नवील खण्ड मिचली गंगा नहर, अलीगढ़
2	02	नरौरा ईराना के बायें गाछाड बन्ध एवं पार्श्वीन बन्ध पर खाडोडा लगाये जाने का कार्य।	218.15	4.37	12 माह	4575.00	ए/एच/उपभ	
3	03	सिंचाई खण्ड, कासगंज की अनमर्गल शोरे मालवर के किमी0 0.000 से किमी0 7.440 तक नहर की पुनर्वसन एवं सीओडो लाईनिंग का कार्य।	806.12	16.19	12 माह	7900.00	ए/एच/उपभ	अधिशासी अभियन्ता, सिंचाई कार्य मण्डल, कासगंज
4	04	सिंचिया राजवाडा के किमी0 4.060 पर सीओआरएचडी (सीएस कावर्ट) के पुनर्निर्माण एवं 20-मी0 अपस्ट्रीम और 20-मी0 कावर्टस्ट्रीम में लाईनिंग एवं पुनर्वसर्पित का कार्य।	59.83	1.20	09 माह	2706.00	बी/एच/उपभ	अधिशासी अभियन्ता, सिंचाई कार्य मण्डल, पुरा
5	05	सिंचिया राजवाडा के किमी0 8.102 पर सीओआरएचडी (सीएस कावर्ट) के पुनर्निर्माण एवं 20-मी0 अपस्ट्रीम और 20-मी0 कावर्टस्ट्रीम में लाईनिंग एवं पुनर्वसर्पित का कार्य।	58.62	1.18	09 माह	2692.00	बी/एच/उपभ	
6	06	सिंचिया राजवाडा के किमी0 9.100 पर सीओआरएचडी (सीएस कावर्ट) के पुनर्निर्माण एवं 20-मी0 अपस्ट्रीम और 20-मी0 कावर्टस्ट्रीम में लाईनिंग एवं पुनर्वसर्पित का कार्य।	57.50	1.15	09 माह	2679.00	बी/एच/उपभ	

नोट: Rates will be quoted without GST which will be paid as per prevailing Govt. rules. इस ई-निविदा/बिड का विवरण सिंचाई विभाग की वेबसाइट (www.idup.gov.in) एवं ई-टेंडरिंग की वेबसाइट (<http://etender.up.nic.in>) पर उपलब्ध है।

UPID-25247 Dt. 12/06/2026 www.upidadv.gov.in

• SUNDAY CROSSWORD



- 23.** Cured (6)
24. Flourish (6)
28. Throw (4)
29. Gymnast Korbut (4)

- CRYPTIC CLUES ACROSS**
8. Because of the time taken to carry out a search (6)
9. International body may look into unopened letters to begin with (3)
10. Rent's up as stated (4)
11. Up and down they go endlessly (10)
12. Flock of quails having a drink (4)
13. Boy sent back a couple of times to see the animal ? (3-3)
16. Interlude at recent production (8)

SOLUTIONS TO 2585 QUICK CLUES ACROSS: 8 Juno, 9 Genie, 10 Been, 11 Strata, 12 Outhouse, 13 Usefully, 15 Rebuff, 17 Adjunct, 19 Trimmed, 22 Buddha, 24 Nihilism, 26 Downhill, 28 Bridge, 30 Stub, 31 Lento, 32 Lord **DOWN:** 1 Suet, 2 Pot-au-feu, 3 Agnail, 4 Antony, 5 Lecturer, 6 Absorb, 7 Peps, 14 Sadhu, 16 Flees, 18 Clavicle, 20 Multiple, 21 England, 23 Danube, 25 Hobnob, 27 Onto, 29 Gore **CRYPTIC CLUES ACROSS:** 8 Maya, 9 Forgo, 10 Elul, 11 Greta, 12 Natter on, 13 Apparent, 15 Godown, 17 Splotch, 19 Certain, 22 Blow up, 24 All right, 26 Smashing, 28 X-rayed, 30 Able, 31 Leers, 32 Auks **DOWN:** 1 Pair, 2 Santiago, 3 Of late, 4 Granite, 5 Montague, 6 Reread, 7 Hugo, 14 Pupil, 16 Weigh, 18 Capriole, 20 Tail away, 21 Cargoes, 23 Washer, 25 Laxest, 27 Mobs, 29 Eskey

SUDOKU 6349

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s INSTRUCTIONS
To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6348

6		2	3					
	8	5			2			
		5	1	8				
	3	2				7	9	
				2	9	1		
7	3							
	4				5	6		
			9	1				3

BEFORE THE HON'BLE SUBORDINATE COURT (COMMERCIAL COURT), KOCHI

E.P No. 52025 IN CS No. 1/2022

Chakiat Agencies : V. Decree Holder
CLS Logistics Pvt. Ltd. : Judgment Debtor

TO
M/s. CLS Logistics Pvt. Ltd.
Registered Office at House No. 846, Sector - 31, Gurgaon, Haryana - 122001 & Office at: Plot No. B-18, Institutional Area, Sector-32, Gurgaon, Haryana - 122001

Take notice that the above Execution Petition was filed in the above Commercial Suit for execution, along with Application for Attachment in E.A. 70025 in E.P. 05/2025 in C.S. 01/2022. When the above petition was posted on 20.05.2026 for your appearance, The Hon'ble Court was pleased to order notice to you through paper publication returnable on 30.06.2026. The above petition is posted for your appearance on 30.06.2026 at 11.00 a.m. before the Hon'ble Court, in which you may appear personally or through a pleader.

In case you fail to do so, the case will be decided in your absence.

Sd/-
Counsel for Decree Holder
Adv. Sandeep Gopalakrishnan

उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार
निदेशालय पशुपालन विभाग, उत्तर प्रदेश, लखनऊ-226007

संख्या: 53/पैरावेटरनी सेल/2025-26, दिनांक: 10 जून, 2026

"पशुपालन क्षेत्र में सुनहरा अवसर"
"उत्तर प्रदेश में पैरावेटरनी शिक्षा के क्षेत्र में निवेश का स्वर्णिम अवसर"
"पशुधन क्षेत्र में कौशल विकास एवं रोजगार सृजन की महत्वपूर्ण पहल"
उत्तर प्रदेश शासन के शासनदेश संख्या-07/2024/आई/798726/37-3099/8/2023, दिनांक 18.11.2024 के अनुपालन में प्रदेश में पैरावेटरनी डिप्लोमा पाठ्यक्रमों के संचालन हेतु नये महाविद्यालयों एवं संस्थानों की स्थापना एवं संबद्धता की व्यवस्था लागू की गयी है। इस पहल का मुख्य उद्देश्य पशुपालन क्षेत्र में शिक्षा और प्रशिक्षण को बढ़ावा देना, पशु स्वास्थ्य सेवाओं को अधिक सहज बनाना, पैरा-वेटरिनरी सेवाओं की उपलब्धता बढ़ाना, ग्रामीण एवं शहरी क्षेत्रों में पशुपालकों को बेहतर सेवाएं उपलब्ध कराना, प्रशिक्षित मानव संसाधन तैयार कर पशुपालन क्षेत्र में विकास को गति देना है।

इच्छुक संस्थान विभागीय वेबसाइट से आवेदन पत्र डाउनलोड कर आवश्यक अभिलेखों सहित आवेदन पत्र कार्यालय निदेशक, प्रशासन एवं विकास, पशुपालन विभाग, उत्तर प्रदेश लखनऊ-226007 को प्रेषित कर सकते हैं। विस्तृत विवरण विभागीय वेबसाइट <http://animalhusb.upsdc.gov.in> पर उपलब्ध है। पशुपालन शिक्षा के क्षेत्र में अपनी संस्था की नई पहचान बनाएं एवं ग्रामीण विकास में सहभागी बनें।

निदेशक,
प्रशासन एवं विकास
पशुपालन विभाग, उ०प्र०।

Office of the Superintending Engineer
Central Equipment & Stores Procurement Circle-II,
Irrigation Department, Uttar Pradesh,
Ganga Sinchai Bhawan, Telibagh,
LUCKNOW-226025

GeM CUSTOM BID NOTICE
GeM Bid No. GEM/2026/B/7603536, Date 12.06.2026

On behalf of the Honourable Governor of Uttar Pradesh, Online GeM Bid No. GEM/2026/B/7603536, Date 12.06.2026 are invited by the undersigned only from BCH/LK(L&T)/HAVELLS/SIEMENS/SCHNEIDER /ABB/C&S Original Manufacturers or from their dealers/distributors/ reseller/channel partner authorized by the firm to participate in this bid, for the supply of Automatic Air Break Star Delta Starter Panel of ratings 15.0 HP to 45.0 HP to be used on state tubewells for Submersible/VT Pumps for water handling and catering irrigation to farmers, conforming to IS/IEC 60947-4-1:2000 & latest amendments if any. Last date of participation in the bid is dated 30.06.2026 at 11.00 AM. Details for eligibility, qualification, technical and other conditions of bid etc. are available in the GeM Bid Document uploaded on the GeM Portal. The undersigned reserves the right to cancel any or all the e-bids/annual the bidding process without assigning any reason.

Santosh Kumar Sonkar
Superintending Engineer
Central Equipment & Stores
Procurement Circle-II, Irrigation
Department, U.P., Lucknow

UPID-252565, Dt. 12/06/2026 www.upidadv.gov.in

2586

niece (6)

DOWN

- 1.** Many old boys form unruly gangs (4)
2. Ground rent deposit (4)
3. Went ashore to be silenced at the kennels (8)
4. In car, hit when the batsman is back safe (3,4)
5. Five hundred over paper money, for a change, indicates inaction (6)
6. Help group? (3,7)
7. Public relations and I have little time for hedging (6)
14. Grandson's add-on, maybe (3)
15. Sort of dislike the theatre-goer has of being in the pit ? (4-6)
19. Showed indifference as second husband gets rough (8)
20. It's a headache that gives Meg such an edge (3)
21. Quiet broadcaster hopes to hear crime writer (1,1,5)
23. Not so far from finishing a meal when a listener comes in (6)
24. Gallant Eugene shows singular spirit (3,3)
28. Where to get a divorce in the forenoon ? (4)
29. Don't go straight for the food (4)

SATURDAY JUNE 20: Success comes when you look on the bright side. Wherever you are, whatever you are doing, your best efforts will be rewarded.

IF IT'S YOUR BIRTHDAY

SUNDAY JUNE 14: This is a pleasant year for socialising and enjoying life. Nurture the happiness you have within. Let your guard down and loosen up a bit, but don't lose sight of your goals.

MONDAY JUNE 15: This is a year of building for you to create both internal and external structures. Simplicity is key. Take charge of your health. Get organised to accomplish your goals.

TUESDAY JUNE 16: This year exciting changes will bring you increased freedom. Stay flexible. Let go of things that hold you back. Seek out new opportunities and be ready to act fast. Expect to travel and expand your horizons.

WEDNESDAY JUNE 17: Stick close to people you know best and feelings which are tried, tested and understood. Focus on partnerships which will help achieve your goals.

THURSDAY JUNE 18: This is a year of learning and teaching. Take time to renew your spiritual or religious beliefs. Explore philosophies that give you a better self-awareness.

FRIDAY JUNE 19: You will reap the benefits of all your hard work. Expect awards and acknowledgement. Seize opportunities and act on them. The spotlight is on you.

• YOUR WEEK AHEAD

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Today's New Moon is the best day of the year for you to think about something exciting that you can learn— something interesting, fresh and different. It will be helpful, and fascinating. This Week: Romance and moneymaking opportunities.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): The New Moon today offers you a chance to think about moneymaking ideas. You might see ways to take better care of the things that you own. You want to feather your nest in a practical way. This Week: You're energetic. Entertain at home.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Today the New Moon is in your sign, which makes it the best day of the year to take a look in the mirror to see what you can do to improve the image you create on the world. Ideas? This Week: Appreciate your surroundings.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): You're eager to chat. Venus and Jupiter in your sign make you charming and entertaining. Today is a good day to think about your spiritual or religious values. This Week: Conversations.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): This is the perfect day to think about what friendships mean to you. (It's a rare thing to have one good friend in your life.) Have you thought about what kind of friend you are to others? This Week: Shop for wardrobe goodies.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Scrutinise how you deal with the authority figures in your life. How can you improve your relationship with parents, bosses or teachers? This Week: You look wonderful to everyone.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): This might be the best day of the year to ask yourself how you can enrich your life by learning or travel. What can you do to expand your experience of your world? This Week: Travel, learn and talk to bosses.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Today's New Moon is an excellent time to think about how to get out of debt. You also might think about how you handle shared property and shared responsibilities with someone else. Can you improve anything? This Week: Be patient with partners.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): In a successful relationship, you must be as good for your partner as he or she is for you. Today's New Moon is opposite your sign, offering you a chance to think about how you can improve your closest relationships. Ideas? This Week: Work hard, party harder.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Confucius said, "Choose a job you love and you will never have to work a day in your life." This is something to think about for today's New Moon, because it's the only New Moon in your House of Employment all year. This Week: Get started.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Today's is your chance to ask yourself how well you're doing at the art of living. Do you balance work and play in your life? Too much of either is not ideal. This Week: Friendships and romance.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): What can you do to improve your relations with family members? Likewise, what can you do to improve where you live so you are happier living there. These are the opportunities that today's New Moon offers you. This Week: Be friendly.

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Tender Notice
E-TENDER NOTICE No. SG-664-08-Sig-2026-27
E-TENDER IS INVITED ON BEHALF OF THE PRESIDENT OF INDIA FOR THE UNDERMENTIONED WORKS.
SI.No.: 1. Name of the work: In connection with signaling work related to (1) Interlocking of 4 Nos. of L.C. Gates having TVU more than 20000 in Dhanbad Division. (2) Interlocking of One (01 No.) L C Gate whose TVU is more than 10000 in Block section of Jamunilandang Halt - Chandrapura of Dhanbad Division. **SI.No. : 2. Approx. Cost of the work:** ₹ 3.57,36,986.06 (Approx.) **SI.No.: 3. Earnest Money:** ₹ 7,14,700.00 **SI.No.: 4. Date & time for closing of tender:** 02.07.2026 at 12:30 Hrs. **SI.No.: 5. Any E-Tenders which is sent by Post / Courier / FAX or self, Manual proposals although the letter is on firm's letter pad or received in time will not be accepted. The above E-Tenders, E-Tendering document alongwith full information is available on website i.e. <http://www.irops.gov.in> Note - Tenderers are requested to visit the website <http://www.irops.gov.in> atleast 10 days before last date of closing for latest corrigendum / corrections etc. in response to this E-Tender. Sr. D.S.T.E. East Central Railway, Dhanbad**
PR/0388/DHN/S&T/T/26-27/40

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

E - Tender
CPM/GSU/NWR/Jodhpur on behalf of The President of India invites E-Tenders for the following work up to 15.00 Hrs. on the mentioned date.
Tender No. SNT-GSU-JU-2026-27-02; **Name of work:** S&T work in Connection with 'Proposed New Block Station along with development of Goods Shed at Manklay Station'. **Approximate cost of work:** Rs. 4,71,25,807.08/-; **Bid Security:** Rs. 9,42,600.00/-; **Date & Time of closing E-Tender** 07.07.2026 at 15.00 Hrs. **Date & Time of opening E-Tender:** 07.07.2026 at 15.30 Hrs. The details of above E - tender are available on website www.irops.gov.in 865-AM/26
Please join us on /NWRRailways

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

E-Auction Programme July-2026
On line auction sale through www.irops.gov.in for disposal of scrap Ferrous, Non-Ferrous Scrap comprising of Rails on line, other P Way Scrap, M.S. Sheet, Axles, Machines and condemned wagons/coaches will be held as per schedule programme given below:

Depot/ Division	Ajmer Depot	Ajmer Division	Jodhpur Depot	Jodhpur Division	BKN Depot & Division	Jaipur Division
July-2026	03.07.26 23.07.26	07.07.26	08.07.26	09.07.26	10.07.26	14.07.26

Note: The amendments regarding the date of auction can be seen on IREPS site only. No publication will be done in news paper in future. 1. Indian Railway is selling all the scrap through e-auction. Bidders are requested to get registered for E-auction with www.irops.gov.in at an early date.
2. Bidders should obtained class-III digital certificate with firm's name before registration. For payment, bidders will have to open an account with SBI (saras/vyapar) with net banking Rights for depositing earnest money etc. For any detail please contact concerned officers of depot Dy.CMM's and HQ office stores department, Jaipur.
Please join us on /NWRRailways 864-AM/26

BANARAS LOCOMOTIVE WORKS, VARANASI - 221004

BID No. E-10/2025-26 **Date: 10.06.2026**
E-Tenders are invited for & on behalf of the President of India for the supply of following items. Only e-tender will be accepted for which vendors must have class-III Digital Signature and registration on IREPS. The details of tenders are in the following sequence: **S. No. ; Tender No. ; Due Date; Description ; PL No. and Quantity ; 1: 10261035; 17.06.2026; Air duct ASM-BL; 16080063; 55 Nos. 2: 10261035; 17.06.2026; Air duct ASM-LB; 16080105; 69 Nos. 3: 10261300; 30.06.2026; Ring Gear; 16191900; 150 Nos. 4: 10261042; 01.07.2026; Exhaust chamber assy intermediate rare; 16080154; 66 Nos. 5: 10261042; 01.07.2026; Exhaust chamber assy intermediate front; 16080142; 74 Nos. 6: 09251119; 23/08/2026; PAD BONDED CONTACT for PL No. 16120600; 1008 Nos. 7: 09261259; Open Tender (24/06/2026); SNAP RING; PL No. 19340011; Qty. 17146 Nos. 8: 06261043; 02/07/2026; Low Maintenance Lead Acid Battery; 19640011; 85 Nos. 9: 03251223A; (08.07.2026), Wiper Assy Complete PL NO. 29169446; 208 set. 10: 01261039; (29/06/2026), CAMSHAFT ASM-LB, PL No. 16030308; 278.00 Numbers. 11: 01261041; (06/07/2026), इंडोले कर एएसएम, पीएल नंबर 16020406, 11545 Numbers. The details of above Tenders are available on website www.blw.indianrailways.gov.in and www.irops.gov.in Corrigendum:-12. 04251104; E-30/2025-26; 07. The tender has been revised and now the same will be opened on 15/07/2026 instead of 30/08/2026. **Note:** All other terms and conditions will remain unchanged for above tenders.
PRO/BLW/S-10 **Principal Chief Material Manager**
 /blwvaranasi **Website: blw.indianrailways.gov.in****

Tacos, tortillas and football gods: Mexico City’s charm



Sandip G
Mexico City, June 13

THE COLOURS are loud and vivid in Mexico City. The home team’s jersey is blazing green, the Azteca turns into a green, giant monster with a thousand hands on match days. The food stalls that stream endlessly from one street to another, like the coaches of a train jostle for attention with splashes of fluorescent, overlarge fonts and quirky designs.

The brighter the better, says Martina, who runs a tortas stall near the stadium. “The shop needs to stand out. Every food shop in Mexico City sells the same snacks and food, but you need to show you are different,” she says.

The shop is named Stadium Tortas. The name board has a picture of Pele and Diego Maradona, face to face, as though they are striding out of the tunnel for a game. The menu on the storefront has tortas named after every famous footballer. Pele, Maradona, Alfredo di Stephano, Franz Beckenbauer and local king Hugo Sanchez hoard prime real estate on her show-

case and are displayed prominently. The rest, Zinedine Zidane, Mario Kempes and Iker Casillas are bunched in a different section, and priced lower.

The theme was an idea of her football tragic husband. “He told me, “most of them come here to watch matches”. So if we name them after famous footballers, people would be curious and the business will improve. Of course, our tortas are the tastiest in the vicinity, but you need to sell it and draw more customers,” she says. Business is brisk; foreigners comprise half the scattered queue. Every word has a different colour.

It’s not only the menu but the graffiti beneath the showcase that woos attention. Hers was recently done. “Made by computer,” she shouts. It is a melange of Mexican footballers on both sides. At the centre is a young, chubby chef with a tortas. She says she would have preferred hand-painted ones, but there has been a dearth of painters and those that are there quote exorbitant prices.

There are ample footprints of the hand-painted ones in the city. Every wall, even in plushier locales, has a mural or graffiti. Every mural is a story, the locals believe. The walls of stately buildings have issued a stern warning: “Graffiti strictly prohibited; those found would be shot!” A giant fish adorns several walls in the city centre. The



Clockwise: World Cup graffiti on Mexico City’s streets; a tortilla shop with Pele and Maradona pics; a woman walks past street art. SANDIP G



locals call it the axolotl, a kind of salamander native to the ancient waterways of Mexico City and that has existed since the Aztec days. “The size is only in the painting, it is actually smaller than your palm,” says Federico, who runs a tacos shop, named Taco de Enorme. The Big Taco.

All stalls display the cuisine prominently. It’s not merely tacos, tortas or quesadilla. But “giant tacos” “super tacos” or “monster tortillas”.

In some, animals become characters. A chicken shack’s hoarding is a chicken slaughtering another chicken with a huge axe. There were more but under the previous mayor’s orders stalls

Every street leads to a marker, colourful clothes swaying in the light breeze from thick racks. Vendors selling grilled corn swirl in their rusted bicycles, blowing loud whistles.

were erased. “She wanted to beautify the city, she only destroyed its charm,” Federico says. Many are scrubbed bare to their metallic bones. And what does his successor do: Paint most walls with axolotls. “Just to scare kids!”

On either side of Avenida de los Insurgentes, one of the longest avenues in the world measuring 30 kilometres, streets flow into streets, Paristo Berlin, Berlin to Vienna.

There are Zurich and London too. They have turned naming streets into a whole-hearted business, cutting across cultures and continents and vocations.

For music: Bach and Beethoven; for literature: Shakespeare and Victor Hugo; for geography: Himalayas and Alps; for medicine: Cardiology and Orthodontist; animals: Shrimp and Squid. As many as 24 are named Peace Streets.

Not far from it is the High Tension Street (although it’s

calmer than many peace streets, the locals banter). It helps that Mexico City has 70,000 odd streets to name them as they wish to.

Every street leads to a marker, colourful clothes swaying in the light breeze from thick racks. Vendors selling grilled corn swirl in their rusted bicycles, blowing loud whistles. Grocers have a different modus: to play a popular jingle from their phone. Some have ancient tape recorders too, which is far from extinct in the country. Everything, of course, is wrapped in colours that first sting your eyes and then fill your tummy. It’s the vivid and loud colours that you take away from Mexico too.

● **RESULTS**
GROUP B
Canada 1-1 Bosnia
Toronto Stadium
GROUP D
USA 4-1 Paraguay
Los Angeles Stadium

● **MATCH SCHEDULE**
GROUPE
Germany vs Curacao
Houston, **2230 hrs**
GROUP F
Netherlands vs Japan
Dallas, **0130 hrs** (Monday)
GROUP E
Ivory Coast vs Ecuador
Philadelphia, **0430 hrs** (Monday)
GROUP F
Sweden vs Tunisia
Monterrey, **0730 hrs** (Monday)
ZEE5 OTT & UNITE8 CHANNELS

Canada draw 1-1, earn first-ever World Cup point

LATE SUBSTITUTE Cyle Larin scored in the 78th minute and co-host Canada earned its first point in its third World Cup appearance - and first on home soil - by rallying for a 1-1 draw against Bosnia-Herzegovina on Friday. Playing in the shadow of Toronto’s iconic CN Tower, and in front of a sea of red “Ca-na-da!” chanting fans that included hockey star Connor McDavid and actor Ryan Reynolds, Larin converted Promise David’s pass a mere two minutes after entering the game. The goal was only the second in World Cup play scored by Canada after the team lost all three of its games in 1986 and again four years ago at Qatar. AP

Under the Hollywood lights of LA, Pochettino’s side thrashes Paraguay 4-1 and delivers a performance that could turn curiosity into mania

Sandip G
Mexico City, June 13

WHEN THE final whistle blew, the beatific Los Angeles Stadium was a blizzard of miniature US flags fluttered in the stadium.

The stands fully enjoyed a blockbuster evening, arguably the co-hosts’ most authoritative display in the World Cups. The 4-1 scoreline, Giovanni Reyna splashing the icing on the cake in the last minute, fully captured their domination over an unusually frazzled Paraguay.

So joyous the occasion was that the celebrations brought bedlam. They piled onto each other near the corner flag, some weeping, some screaming, before they huddled bang in the middle of the pitch, joined by the support staff. In the broadcast-ers’ box, Zlatan Ibrahimovic gave the appraisal. “We were speaking before the game about believing. My message to the American people is, if you didn’t believe before the game, that performance in the first half — start believing. This American team can do something big.” It’s a wave that could spill on and grip the entire nation in football mania.

The first half was ripped from a Hollywood thriller in its

searing intensity. The Mad Max types where the movie rolled at a frenetic pace, the audience holding their breath and adrenalin shooting through the roofs.

At the heart of the demolition were Christian Pulisic and Folarin Bolagun, the creator and the destructor. Pulisic was in an inspired mood, like in his Chelsea spring, playmaking frictionlessly and findingspace wherever he drifted in. The opening goal stemmed from a delightful pass of his; the second was a beautiful cut back to Bolagun, the former Arsenal striker, who hammered past the goalkeeper to double the lead. A minute earlier, he had a goal disallowed for off-side after another move that Pulisic initiated.

In the 15-minute spell, the buzzing US could have fired in half a dozen goals. Their moves were svelte and precise, no amount of energy wasted, no pass misplaced. Before the half-time, Bolagun nicked his second goal in the final minute of the stoppage time. He picked a pass in his box, then feigned to stumble and let the defender commit to him, before he spun past him and blasted the ball into the left corner, before teeing off to celebrations.

The USMNT’s desperation to land Bolagun stood vindi-



USA’s Folarin Balogun (R) scores against Paraguay on Friday. AP

cated. He was born to Nigerian parents in Brooklyn, but raised in London. His eligibility to play for the US was accidental. His mother Florence had come for a vacation in the US where her sister lived. She was seven months pregnant then. So the airplane denied her entry into the return flight, as she could not present a letter from her doctor in London. She stayed back and gave birth to Balogun. So, when her son was confused to choose between nationalities — he had played for the US at the U-17 level but was turning up for England U-21 and had strong interest from Nigeria — she persuaded her to choose the US. “Even when he wasn’t even thinking of making an international decision, I’d already made up my mind that he is going to play for America,” Florence told ESPN television. She was in the stands, tears overflowing, as her son completed a strange destiny.

The USMNT were aggressive in their pursuit of him, a fleet-footed centre forward

with pace to burn, hammer for a right foot and nourished by exposure in Europe. Mauricio Pochettino would call him the missing piece in his puzzle, for they faced an acute shortage of goal-scoring forwards. The pursuit was intense and public, and the player would say that US fans would bombard his Instagram account with emojis of the American flag.

Football is steadily hooking them. The exuberant audience at the Los Angeles Stadium testified to the game’s swelling pull in the country. Nights like these help in raising the profile. Barely had the crowd settled into their seats that they leapt out of it. Roughly seven minutes had passed when the hosts struck the first goal, inducing panic in a stingy backline.

Paraguay had conceded only 10 goals in their last 18 games, but Pulisic disarrayed their organisation with a scything pass to Weston McKennie. Paraguay’s Damian Bobadilla’s endeavour to clear ended in an accidental poke towards

his own goal, in a sequence eerily resembling the in US’s opening game in the 1994 World Cup against Colombia, where the unfortunate Andre Escobar unwittingly deflected a ball into his own nets. He was shot dead shortly after he returned home.

If the goal was the reward for a composed start, the hosts did not retreat to their own half and defend. They pushed Paraguay further into the back-foot, their men caught between panic and the rush to equalise. Seldom has their backline been probed as relentlessly as the US had. Pulisic was the creator, conducting the game’s tempo with his imagination and courage. Paraguay tried to stifle him with men, but he would wriggle past the muscled chamber with a pickpocket’s cunning.

Paraguay grew physical but only ended up conceding fouls and free-kicks. They looked rattled, and at their wits’ end. Their fabled defence lay in tatters.

It was the perfect night that reeked of Americanness from the moment the opening ceremony began. Chicago Bulls’ famous anthem Sirius crackled in the stadium, the packed stands waving miniature sang along passionately. The players strode out thunderous applause, the intensity stirring them towards their most memorable World Cup hour. A pity that the president was not in the stands to watch the show. It was pure Hollywood, and made for America’s ultimate showman.

Sans stars, Dutch hope to end 50 years of World Cup hurt

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, June 13

ROB RENSENBRINK’S shot hit the post in the dying minutes of the 1978 World Cup final. An inch either way and the Netherlands would have been world champions. Instead, Argentina lifted the trophy on home soil, and Dutch football was left to contemplate, again, the particular cruelty of almost. They had done it four years earlier too, against West Germany, inventing the future of the sport and losing the tournament. Total Football, Johan Cruyff, the spinning orange: a revolution that changed everything except the scoreline.

Going into the 2026 FIFA World Cup, the Netherlands remain the only nation to have appeared in three finals without winning one. They have also, in the years between, failed to qualify for tournaments entirely, oscillating between revelation and invisibility as if one were the price of the other.

What makes this edition different is not what this team has. It is what it doesn’t. No Cruyff bending games to his will. No Bergkamp, that still-point in a moving world. No Robben cutting inside, making it happen with the inevitability of something predetermined.

The recent results don’t inspire confidence: a draw against Ecuador, a loss to Algeria, a last-minute penalty to beat debutants Uzbekistan. There is very little on paper to suggest the Netherlands will trouble the favourites.

And yet. Under Ronald Koeman, this team reached the Euro 2024 semi-final, one minute and a penalty shootout from the final, only eight years after failing to qualify for the same tournament. In qualifying for this World Cup, they went unbeaten across eight games, scoring 27 goals and conceding four. That is not a small thing. It represents a structural recovery: improved depth, collective shape, a defensive solidity that the Cruyff-era sides, for all their genius, rarely bothered with. The improvement belongs to no single man, which is precisely what makes it interesting.

Frenkie de Jong does not look like a player carrying a team. He looks like a player doing his job with unusual thoroughness, winning the ball back, finding the pass, doing it again. The numbers from the 2025-26 La Liga season are quietly extraordinary: highest pass completion rate in the

final third, third in passes completed per 90. That combination, creative and relentless at the same time, is rarer than sounds. Behind him, Virgil van Dijk no longer generates the headlines that once followed him everywhere. He just plays. Every minute of Liverpool’s Premier League campaign, reliable like a load-bearing wall is reliable: you only notice if it isn’t there. Donyell Malen will be nobody’s tournament poster. He scored 14 goals in 18 Serie A appearances for Roma. Nobody in Italy’s top flight scored more often per 90 minutes. Bart Verbruggen and Jean Paul van Hecke represent no traditional big-six club in England, yet they were central to Brighton securing European football for next season, unglamorous work, done well, in front of small audiences.

The Netherlands arrive without Matthijs de Ligt and Xavi Simons. Jurrien Timber pulled out days before departure, a last injury in a long list of them. Memphis Depay, 32, carrying a hamstring, is in the squad on faith, Koeman’s faith specifically: “I selected Memphis because of who he still is. I don’t see anyone else in that position who can do it.”

The squad carries no baggage, no expectation, no obvious ceiling to disappoint against. The orange strip has never been less burdened by what it used to mean.

The phrase Dutch Courage was coined by the English after the Anglo-Dutch Wars, a pejorative for bravery borrowed from gin rather than grown from conviction. The implication being that it isn’t real courage. That it requires something external to hold its shape.

For the Malens and the van Heekes, walking into a World Cup in a country that alternates between world-beaters and invisibility, it may be the only kind on offer. Nobody outside the squad believes in them particularly. The bookmakers don’t say favourites. The rankings don’t say top five. The absent superstars don’t say this is our moment.

What they have is the particular freedom of a team with nothing to lose and enough quality to be dangerous on a given day. It has produced results under Koeman before. It is the only thing that can produce them now.

Rensenbrink’s shot hit the post. The Dutch have lived in that inch for nearly fifty years. In the 2026 World Cup, the men nobody fancied get to decide whether it ends.



Netherlands players during a training session. AP

England’s balls and shoes stolen at Kansas base

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 13

ENGLAND ARE just about four days away from starting their 2026 FIFA World Cup campaign with a match against Croatia in a rematch of the 2018 semi-final, but they have been left without any boots to wear for the match!

The Football Association are scampering to procure equipment, including the players’ match shoes, with the vehicles transferring them to their Swope Soccer Village base in Kansas City being broken into.

The heist has reportedly left England, who boast some of the most prominent names in the sport in their lineup, with just one football remaining for training. Thomas Tuchel and his

squad are scheduled to arrive at the in Kansas City on Saturday afternoon and the equipment was due to be in place beforehand, according to *BBC Sport*.

They are scheduled to have their first full training session at the site on Sunday and the theft could disrupt some of these plans.

Among other items being transported from Florida were analysis equipment, tactical whiteboards and massage tables used by Tuchel’s coaching staff.

The Kansas City police department is investigating the incident and has confirmed that two suspects have been apprehended. “Two subjects of interest were taken into custody pending further investigation,” a police spokesperson is quoted as saying by the *Guardian*.

● **GERMANY’S AMERICAN DREAM**

After consecutive debacles, Germany turn to Musiala for revival

Shashank Nair
New Delhi, June 13

THEY CALL him Bambi. Not for fragility, but for the way he carries the ball in traffic, his cleanness of movement. Jamal Musiala had 40 Germany caps and was being called the next Lionel Messi before he was 20. Then on July 5 last year, Gianluigi Donnarumma went for a loose ball and collided with him. Musiala fell screaming. His fibula fractured, his ankle dislocated. Donnarumma held his head in his hands.

Nagelsmann visited him at home afterwards. No phone call. He went in person, to tell him there was no rush. “It’s better if I come back in top form at the end of the season, and at the World Cup,” Musiala said. He did. Scored against Finland last month, completed 90 min-

utes since March, started against the United States on June 6. Bambi is back. Whether old Bambi is back is question this World Cup will answer.

Germany arrive carrying two consecutive group-stage exits and a goalkeeping controversy. Manuel Neuer retired after Euro 2024, said his piece, made his peace. Then came Bayern against Real Madrid at the Bernabeu: nine saves, man of the match, reaffirming his 14-year status as their number one. Nagelsmann picked up the phone. Oliver Baumann, told just a week earlier that he would start the World Cup, found out when the squad was announced. Sami Khedira had gone on television to defend him: “We are killing Oli Baumann right now. We are killing him in the media.” Forty, fifth World Cup. Some decisions



Musiala is seen as one of the most talented players in this WC. AP

make themselves.

Lothar Matthaus and Thomas Mueller are already at loggerheads. Mueller wants Musiala brought on at tired legs. Matthaus accuses him of destabilising the team. The debates don’t stop there. Joshua Kimmich’s best position remains a national conversation. The centre-back pairings are un-

settled. A decade-long argument Germany have not produced an out-and-out striker since Miroslav Klose grows louder each year. What were once the basics of a Turniermannschaft, a tournament-growing team, are now lost. Philipp Lahm calls for a return to the archetype. Nagelsmann plays with what he has.

What remains is a strong attacking front and a hastily assembled core. Take Kimmich and Jonathan Tah out and what is left is ordinary. Nico Schlotterbeck, valued by Nagelsmann, started eleven of Dortmund’s fifteen clean-sheet matches and is only recently back from injury. These machines break down often.

The pattern of the past four years is clear. Germany beat the teams below them. Against the best, Japan and Spain at Qatar, Spain again at Euro 2024, France and Portugal in the Nations League, the gap outside the front four becomes apparent. Group E, with Curacao, Ivory Coast and Ecuador, should allow them to progress. That is not the question. The question is the ceiling.

Matthias Sammer staked his prediction on patience: “I’m

absolutely convinced Musiala will improve significantly as the tournament unfolds. Maybe not the first match, maybe the second. Then comes the knockout stage and suddenly he’ll explode.”

The old Germany did not need one player to explode. The system exploded. The Turniermannschaft grew with each match, arrived at finals as different teams than the ones that had kicked off in the group stage. That version of Germany did not depend on one player finding himself. This one does. Nagelsmann visited Musiala at home and told him there was no rush. Musiala came back anyway, scored against Finland, started against the US, arrived in Winston-Salem ready.

Germany open on Sunday. Bambi is in the building. Now he has to run.

Russell takes pole at Barcelona GP; leader Antonelli third on the grid



George Russell of Mercedes. AP
Associated Press
Barcelona, June 13

FORMULA 1 leader Kimi Antonelli will face the toughest test of his breakout season at the Barcelona-Catalunya Grand Prix after he managed only the third best time in qualifying on Saturday.

The young Italian will now have to find a way past pole-sitter George Russell, his Mercedes teammate, as well as a resurgent Lewis Hamilton, to make it six wins in a row.

Antonelli's spectacular winning streak includes four victories from pole and one from a second-place start.

But a not-so-perfect qualifying session on Saturday means the 19-year-old Antonelli is off the front row for the first time this year.

"I am not really happy, I'm struggling with the feeling of the car," Antonelli said as he faces the first dip in performance since becoming the sensation of F1. The good news for Antonelli is that he can afford to not take the full 25 points for a race victory. He has already tallied 156 points after just six races. Hamilton is next with 90, while Russell has 88. Russell, however, looked like a man who banished some demons with his pole position.

The English driver entered the season as Mercedes' presumptive top driver. And with the German outfit producing the best car, Russell looked poised for a title run when he won the season-opening Australian GP.

Then came the explosion of Antonelli, which, combined with some team errors, left Russell floundering as he failed to score any points in his last two races. "Nice to feel the groove again," Russell told his team radio on locking up the first sHamilton is back in the fight with FerrariAfter struggling last year with Ferrari, Hamilton is on the rebound and entered this race after back-to-back runner-up finishes.

Now, the seven-time world champion believes he may be close to ending a nearly two-year wait to add to his record haul of 104 grand prix wins.

"I will give it ago," Hamilton said about Sunday's race at a track where he has won six times, but not since 2021 while with Mercedes. "These guys (Russell and Antonelli) still seem to have something extra in the pocket every time we bring an upgrade, but this is great for us."

1ST ODI: INDIA V AFGHANISTAN

Gill overshadows Gurbaz's ton to get India's ODI show on road

In a game reduced to 25 overs a side, skipper guides 195-run chase after Gurnoor, Dubey impress on debut

Lalith Kalidas
Dharamsala, June 13

AFTER EIGHT hours of incessant rain, the skies cleared over Dharamsala as the majestic Dhauladhar slowly revealed itself from behind sooty grey clouds. It allowed a 25-overs-a-side game in which the hosts registered a seven-wicket win with 13 balls to spare, a bit of a canter at the end, despite a 51-ball 102 from Rahmanullah Gurbaz.

The curtailed game eased India's white-ball core, regrouping after an exhaustive IPL season. A target of 195, could have been tricky but they were steered home by captain Shubman Gill (84 not out).

Opening contrast

Azmatullah Omarzai sprayed wides on either side, conceded five extras and overstepped the popping crease before Rohit Sharma could even get a feel of the ball. When it eventually arrived, it pinged into his right wrist.

The former skipper had cut a lone figure for most of the evening, fielding at long-on and backward point after Gill opted to bowl first in glistening conditions. Returning to the ODI fold after five months, questions hung over the 39-year-old, his relevance and recovery from a recent hamstring injury probed every minute.

The confidence appeared shaken, and the pull-shot maestro missed out on a short-liss free hit altogether. A lot of hand-wringing later, he stayed

on. The pull connected next time, sending Omarzai over the mid-wicket fence. Gill played out the next two overs before Rohit exited.

Blinded by bowler Allah Ghazanfar in front of him, Gill turned down a single with Rohit half-way down the pitch. The captain signalled a u-turn, but it was too late for Rohit to recover.

After an edgy start against incoming deliveries from the seamers, Gill kicked into overdrive, latching onto looseners from his IPL teammate Rashid Khan and veteran offie Mohammad Nabi with two sixes and three fours in successive overs. A quickfire 34 from wicketkeeper Ishan Kishan settled the contest to a great degree. With a series of jabs and cuts, Gill soon marched past 3,000 ODI runs - the quickest Indian to the mark - and saw off proceedings alongside a flawless KL Rahul (39* off 19).

Brar takes flight

Gill handed out ODI caps to seamer Gurnoor Brar and left-arm spinner Harsh Dubey, and soon a swinging full-toss from the pacer caught Ibrahim Zadran by surprise. It was Zadran's first ball of the series after missing the one-off Test in New Chandigarh.

Gurbaz cut and charged Arsheep Singh in the first over, dispatching a four through backward point and a six over the sightsscreen.

Brar's strengths are height and bounce, but he operated in contrast to the apparent



Shubman Gill was unbeaten on 84 as India chased the target in a rain-curtailed game. AP

strengths that fast-tracked his debut. The son of a Punjab Police ASI, Brar was gifted with the basketball genes of his father. He instead devoured the menacing art of Dale Steyn on YouTube for hours - the booming outswingers, outright pace and the gift of lengths - the entire package.

When the ball finally hit the right length, Zadran would taste why India could have considerable time on their hands honing the 6'5" pacer. The ball swerved away late, the leading edge off Zadran's drive finding Gill. Brar's Punjab statemate and captain, at mid-off.

He cranked up the speed gun effortlessly - seven of his first nine deliveries zoomed over 146 kph - exhibiting nous

to steer away from his innate hit-the-deck traits. After an impressive three-over burst, Brar (3/23) capped off his special evening by putting a full-stop on Afghanistan, nipping the last two wickets before the final delivery of the innings.

Rocket Gurbaz

Arshdeep had set Afghanistan back at the start, trapping Sediqullah Atal and Rahmat Shah in quick succession within the first five overs.

Gurbaz, however, pressed on despite a visible hamstring concern. Under spotless skies, the opener rained boundaries, smashing 10 of them between overs 7-11 taking on a wayward Prasidh Krishna and debutant Dubey.

Sixes with a pick-up flick off Krishna and a lofted straight drive against Nitish Kumar Reddy were the standout shots when Gurbaz doubled his 28-ball fifty within the next 20 deliveries - a dazzling 48-ball ton the fastest-ever by an Afghan batter. Gurbaz's (102) automated assault off the shorter lengths was eventually halted by Nitish, whose inswinging yorker uprooted his middle stump and with it, Afghanistan's momentum.

BRIEF SCORES: Afghanistan 194 all out in 24.5 overs (Gurbaz 102; Brar 3/27, Dubey 3/47) lost to India 195 for three in 22.5 overs (Gill 84 not out, Rahul 39 not out) by seven wickets

Deepti, Shafali, Richa: Key to India's title hopes



Richa Ghosh will be one of India's trump cards at T20 WC. FILE/PTI

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, June 13

When India last travelled to England for a major global event, they returned heartbroken but transformed. Harmanpreet Kaur's unforgettable 171 against Australia in the semifinal and a runners-up finish at the 2017 ODI World Cup ignited a surge in interest, which gave a big boost to women's cricket in the country. Nine years on, only Harmanpreet, Smriti Mandhana and Deepti Sharma remain from that squad - but they return as reigning ODI world champions with a chance of completing a historic white-ball double. They open their campaign against Pakistan in Birmingham on Sunday.

Since 2017, India has reached two Women's T20 World Cup semifinals and a final, establishing themselves as consistent contenders on the biggest stage. What has eluded them, though, is the final step. As another T20 World Cup begins, India's hopes will inevitably rest on familiar names such as Harmanpreet, Mandhana and Jemimah Rodrigues. But if they are to convert years of promise into a maiden title, the decisive contributions may have to come from three players who don't always dominate the headlines.

Hidden heroes

Deepti, Shafali Verma and Richa Ghosh perform vastly different roles, yet each influences a phase of the game that could determine whether India finally goes the distance.

The most indispensable of the trio is Deepti. While Mandhana, Harmanpreet and Rodrigues attract attention for their batting, Deepti provides the balance every side needs and has quietly developed into arguably India's most complete T20 cricketer. The numbers underline her importance. The 28-year-old became the leading wicket-taker in women's T20Is in December and is also the first player in women's cricket to score more than 1,000 T20I runs and scalp 150 wickets.

Just as importantly, she is one of the few bowlers India can trust at any stage of an innings. Deepti has claimed 47 wickets in the Powerplay at an economy rate of 5.99, another 58 through the middle overs at 6.14, and 53 at the death, going at 7.55. Few bowlers in the women's game offer that kind

of versatility.

That facet of Deepti's game could become even more valuable at this World Cup. While Arundhati Reddy and Renuka Singh Thakur provide experience and Nandni Sharma has made an encouraging start, India don't possess intimidating pace, placing even greater responsibility on her. Recent form, however, is mixed. Since taking 5/19 against South Africa in April, she has managed only four wickets in her next five matches and did not bowl in either warm-up fixture. Her highest score across her last nine innings is an unbeaten 36.

If Deepti provides balance, Shafali offers explosiveness that opposition teams fear.

India's batting has occasionally been criticised for lacking sustained firepower. Shafali changes that dynamic. Since 2018, the right-hander has had the best strike rate in women's T20Is (138.30) and hit more sixes (50) than anyone else.

During India's 5-0 T20I sweep of Sri Lanka in December, she struck 69, 79 and 79 in successive matches. Although she managed only 259 runs in 10 matches of WPL 2026 and endured a modest tour of England before the World Cup, she remains capable of giving India an early advantage.

Finishing touches

Then comes Richa, perhaps the most destructive batter in India's line-up. Over the past few years, she has established herself as India's designated finisher, scoring 815 runs in the death overs at a blistering strike rate of 164.3. Few players in the women's game can transform an innings over the final five overs as quickly as she can.

But the 22-year-old's highest score in her last eight innings is an unbeaten 34, with five of those knocks ending in single figures. But she offered a reminder of her quality by smashing a 36-ball 68 against England in the final warm-up game.

Opposition teams will devote most of their planning to Mandhana, Harmanpreet and Rodrigues. Championship-winning sides, however, are rarely carried by their biggest stars alone. India also have the benefit of a favourable group featuring Pakistan, Bangladesh and the Netherlands, giving them an opportunity to build momentum before sterner challenges arrive.

(With stats inputs from Lalith Kalidas).

Sindhu, Lakshya spearhead Asian Games squad

Express News Service
Mumbai, June 13

A FULL-strength men's squad has been named by the Badminton Association of India (BAI) for the 20th Asian Games, set to take place in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan, from September 19 to October 4. India's bronze-winning Thomas Cup team gets a second shy at a team title, with the same personnel except Tharun Manneppalli slotting in place of Kiran George.

India have unfinished business from Hangzhou, where they lost 3-2 to China in the men's team final.

Lakshya Sen, Ayush Shetty, HS Prannoy and Kidambi Srikanth are the prominent singles names for the team which bagged silver in 2022. Sen and Ayush will get a chance to pick their first individual medal at

the continental Games.

Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty will defend their title, this time with a stronger second doubles in the form of Hariharan Amsakarunan and MR Arjun. Mixed specialist Dhruv Kapila will also try and make the most of his upsurge of 2024.

Treesa Jolly-Gayatri Gopichand return after Treesa suffered a collision with her mixed doubles partner and injured herself a day before Uber Cup.

PV Sindhu, who claimed silver - India's best singles showing at the 2018 Games - will play the individual event with Unnati Hooda also making the grade. In the team event, Devika Sihag, Isharani Baruah and Tanvi Sharma can alternate on WS 2, 3 duties behind Sindhu who has re-entered the top 10.



PV Sindhu will lead the Indian women's team at Asiad. FILE

Shruti Mishra missed out, with Kavipriya Selvam and Simran Singh picked for the second doubles.

"Over the last few months, we have seen encouraging signs across the board, Satwik-Chirag back to their best, Lakshya returning to the world's top 10, the men's team reaching

another Thomas Cup podium, Sindhu and our senior players delivering consistently, and younger athletes stepping up with strong performances and important results internationally. This squad reflects that journey, a blend of experience, depth and emerging talent," BAI secretary Sanjay Mishra said. India heads into Aichi-Nagoya carrying strong momentum - with Satwik-Chirag winning Singapore Open Super 750, Shetty reaching the Asian Championships finals, Sindhu making quarters consistently, Devika Sihag picking a Super 300 title in Thailand and Sen making the All England finals. HS Prannoy defeated Jonatan Christie.

Indian badminton has won 13 medals in Asian Games history, including a breakthrough gold medal at the previous edi-

tion. The 2022 Games marked India's most successful badminton campaign with one gold, one silver, and an individual bronze.

TEAM CHAMPIONSHIP: Men's Team: Lakshya Sen, Ayush Shetty, H. S. Prannoy, Kidambi Srikanth, Tharun Manneppalli, Satwiksairaj Rankireddy, Chirag Shetty, Hariharan Amsakarunan, M. R. Arjun, Dhruv Kapila; **Women's Team:** PV Sindhu, Unnati Hooda, Devika Sihag, Tanvi Sharma, Isharani Baruah, Treesa Jolly, Gayatri Gopichand Pulella, Kavipriya Selvam, Simran Singh, Tanisha Crasto **INDIVIDUAL: MS:** Lakshya, Ayush; **WS:** Sindhu, Unnati; **MD:** Satwik/Chirag, Hariharan/Arjun **WD:** Treesa Jolly / Gayatri Gopichand Pulella; Kavipriya Selvam / Simran Singh; **XD:** Dhruv Kapila / Tanisha Crasto

● THE SELVA PRABHU STORY

From a doctor's room in Madurai to NCAA champion

Prithish Raj
New Delhi, June 13

THIRUMARAN DID not know what to do with his son. The boy would not stop running. He was everywhere, always moving, always restless. So the farmer from Madurai took Selva Prabhu to a doctor.

"He was very hyperactive. When the doctor asked what he wanted to do, he stunned everyone by saying that he wanted to win a medal for the country," Thirumaran told The Indian Express from Madurai. "We never told him anything about sport. His elder brother used to play football but the answer was quite amusing to me. That is when I decided to take him to the nearest stadium."

On Friday in Eugene, Oregon, that child jumped 16.92m to win the NCAA Outdoor Track and Field Championships triple jump title, becoming only the fourth Indian to win an NCAA championship. It was not straightforward. He struggled to find the board on four of his six attempts. But his second jump, 16.92m, held up against a 24-man field for the full competition. He is the first Kansas State men's outdoor tri-



Selva Prabhu jumped 16.92m to win the triple jump title. KANSAS STATE

ple jump champion since 1986.

Thirumaran is a traditional farmer who plants seasonal crops. He sold four acres of his land to fund his son's early career. "He started early and showed promise in the long jump. We had to take him to different competitions, so I sold my land whenever needed to fund his trips and training then," he said. The sacrifice was made without certainty, on the word of a hyperactive boy in a doctor's waiting room.

"My family has supported

me from day one. They're proud of how far I've come and this title belongs to them as much as it does to me because of all the sacrifices they've made for me," Selva told The Indian Express after winning the NCAA title.

Selva's talent caught the eye of coach Sreenivasan at the Sports Hostel in Tiruchirappalli. "I saw him at the Sports Hostel meets. He won medals at Junior State meets and school nationals. But I always thought that he would make a better tri-

ple jumper," the coach said.

The switch was built on a specific observation. "It is rare to have an athlete who has good balance in both legs and equal strength. Usually, triple jumpers rely on speed but Selva is explosive. So, I asked him to make a switch and after the switch he started to improve every year," Sreenivasan explained. After the switch, Selva climbed from 14m to 16m across three seasons. The biggest moment before Friday came at the U20 World Championships in Colombia, where he jumped 16.15m to win silver.

He moved to the Inspire Institute of Sport, where he trained alongside national record holder Praveen Chithravel under two-time Olympic medallist Cuban Yoandri Betanzos. At the national camp in 2022, Sreenivasan had to make his own choice.

"I had to move to National camp in 2022 and pick a specialization. I picked sprints and Selva moved to train under coach Betanzos where he improved further," the coach said. While Sreenivasan went on to spot another future record holder in Vishal TK at the camp, Selva chose his own di-

rection: Kansas State University, joining in January last year.

He arrived as a freshman in a foreign country and within two years had become a national champion. The American circuit suited him from the start. This season alone he has crossed 17m twice, once while breaking the indoor national record with 17.05m, and then reaching 17.19m with wind assistance.

"Everything became more professional and structured. Balancing academics and athletics taught me discipline, time management, and how to take care of my body every day," said Selva about his move to the US. Friday's title is his second major medal on the NCAA circuit after silver at the Indoor Finals earlier this year. He joins a short list: Mohinder Singh Gill, Vikas Gowda, Tejaswin Shankar and Lokesh Satyanathan are the only other Indians to have won NCAA championships.

Thirumaran watched from Madurai. "Whatever he said as a kid, I want that wish to come true," he said. "He wants to win a medal for India. He has the potential."

The farmer who sold his land is still waiting for that one. So is his son.

Prithish Raj
New Delhi, June 13

LAST MONTH at the Federation Cup in Ranchi, hurdler Tejas Shirse lost what looked like his last chance to qualify for the Commonwealth Games, clocking 13.67s and 13.50s. Then the Athletics Federation of India announced the Indian Athletics Series in Ludhiana as a final qualification event, giving Shirse another chance.

He took it. On Friday, he not only breached the qualification mark of 13.39s but clocked 13.27s to lower his own national record of 13.41s on the track at Guru Nanak Stadium. The celebration that followed told you everything about what it meant for the 24-year-old who had spent four months on the sidelines wondering if he would make it back in time.

"That celebration came from inside, you know. I wasn't expecting anything today. This meet was not even in my plans. Usually, my instinct is to take pressure off the qualification but today, I was just enjoying it out there," Tejas told The Indian Express after his national record.

Tejas has been India's top



Tejas Shirse broke his previous national record of 13.41s. AFI

hurdler since he broke the national record for the first time in 2024, clocking 13.41s. But he could not go below that mark until Friday. "I knew that it was coming. My timings were good but it was not getting any better. When I returned from my injury this time, I told everyone that I can break the national record," he said.

Return from injury

An ankle injury kept him out for four months. His return was swift and better than anyone expected. He clocked 13.43s at the

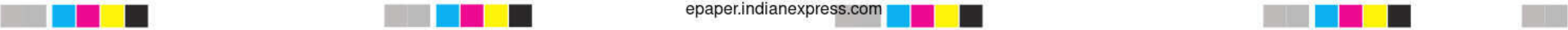
Indian Athletics Series in May, within touching distance of the record. "When we were deciding to come back, the Commonwealth Games was not in the plans. We had thought of Asian Games but not CWG. It looked like a miracle when I was fit to have two attempts at the CWG qualification. But I think we followed the process and kept our approach simple which resulted in me getting back to my best very quickly," he explained.

The Commonwealth Games field will be competitive. The 2022 edition gold medallist in 110m hurdles, Rasheed Broadbell, won a bronze medal at the Paris Olympics. Then reigning Olympic champion Hansle Parchment of Jamaica was one of the finalists in Birmingham.

Tejas is not intimidated. "I think I am ready for the big stage. I need a big stage and if I can be in the right mindset, I think a good performance is round the corner."

"The Commonwealth Games will be a great learning experience for me. I am looking to get out of my zone and just perform at the highest level."

Friday in Ludhiana was the proof that he means it.





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The suspense of everyday

How the director, writers and actors brought the peculiar world of *Maa Befien* to life

Chef Amrita Raichand's big life



lia in Bengal to put out a line of linen saris in 2011. “This was a pristine space with no legacy to be followed. I chose to highlight design more than just craft,” she says. The result was a new clientele. Bengaluru-based marketing professional Sujata Narayan says she bought her first Anavila sari because it felt “less intimidating” and could be worn to work as easily as to family gatherings. “It didn’t feel like extra effort. It felt like me,” she says.

Although all these labels claim to be age-agnostic, they resonate with the younger crowd. Misra gets orders on borderless saris from students for their graduation day. Rai prefers to look at buyers “psychographically” and has found that they are self-assured and globally aware, “but with a strong appreciation for local brands, craft and cultural context.” Raw Mango widens the definition of youth. “Be it 20 or 60, handloom is definitely not restrained. Being young is about being open. It is an attitude and not a number. Perhaps that’s why we resonate with everybody,” explains Garg.

Besides, these labels create an alternative space far away from fashion weeks, celebrity endorsements and elite retail spaces. “The people who started working after 2005 are now mid-career. They want to look unique in their wardrobe, are hungry for a fashion edge beyond commercial labels, and are ready to pay. Luxury couture stays static for its takers, the assembly line is for the masses but this middling gap is what’s fuelling the mainstreaming of alternative labels,” says trend analyst Subhash Singh Rajput, a NIFT graduate and head of India wear at Landmark Group, which operates brands such as Lifestyle and Max.

The art of storytelling

Raw Mango defies conventional rules of fashion marketing and believes in digital storytelling. When it launched its collection Agama, featuring outerwear and saris made from mashru, mashru ikat and kantha, Garg shot a video against the backdrop of Kausambi, a 12th-century BCE archaeological site along the Yamuna in Allahabad, symbolically linking the past to the future and threading them with the running Kantha stitch. The Kantha jackets themselves incorporate offcuts or leftover material from the designer’s studio. This constant conversation with culture and sustainability has won over a new thinking demographic.

Krishnan worked on a feedback loop with offline pop-ups and travelling exhibitions that enabled her understanding of what people wanted. “Maati had one store in Mumbai and there was a time when it was listed as a shopping destination for tourist groups. Then they made reels that amplified our arc. That real world connect helped us transition online better,” she adds. The digital interface helped Rai build an online community around a shared way of living. “This has helped us enter real lives and real homes, often in ways that are more relatable than traditional advertising,” he says. Their fortnight long Nico dress carousel on Instagram, featuring regular women in real world settings, generated not only 5X return on ad spend, but a 30 per cent lower cost per purchase. Mostly it encouraged women who had never worn a dress to wear one. And find themselves not in conflict with either their sari or workwear. “Such digital stories help because consumers then see themselves as participants rather than buyers,” explains Prof Rana.

The retail strategy

Now that disruptive fashion labels have claimed mainstream attention, people want more offline stores for the touch-and-feel experience. Both Krishnan and Misra are now thinking of expanding their footprint beyond Mumbai for the first time by curating sensory displays and backstory workshops at their new outlets. “People know Maati like a family, like a baby growing up. We will be supplementing our new store with childcare and menswear accessories, providing more value,” says Krishnan.

Garg has consciously located his stores in heritage buildings, like a 1900s Art Deco building in Kolkata or a modernist villa in Hyderabad. His pieces are kept in almirahs, glass cabinets or behind curtains to let the buyer explore, a deliberate moving away from swanky uniformity of boutique stores. “I entered for the experience first and ended up buying a sari,” says Sripama Sarkar, a first-time label buyer in Kolkata.

In many ways, these brands have reversed old rules of the game. Instead of celebrities creating demand, demand among consumers has attracted celebrities. Actor Konkona Sen Sharma is seen posting reels whenever she wears Raw Mango while Vidya Balan, Farah Khan and Ratna Pathak Shah have been endorsing Maati. “But these are organic, not paid partnerships. I still prefer knowing each of my buyers firsthand,” says Krishnan.

The in-betweeners have not only been disruptive but split the fashion industry wide open. Big corporates like Tata and the Aditya Birla group have launched retail chains, Taneira and Aadyam, to sell handwoven Indian textiles sourced from weaver clusters. In the face of such a competitive challenge, can scale and sustainability co-exist? “We were always and will be away from noise and focus instead on ease of being,” says Rai. “Sonali Bendre once said that our saris call out to her. Till we have that, we will be around,” says Misra.

CHANGING THE MOTHER TONGUE OF FASHION

While it has always been about labels, clothes are now speaking in a language that is accessible, disrupting the business of legacy couturiers

Rinku Ghosh

FASHION IS often perceived to be a space lit by strobe lights. But this is a story of those who came in from the penumbra and changed the lights altogether. Ten years ago, Raul Rai, who was transitioning from his banker profile, pondered over a key question, would he wear something off the ramp? More importantly, would he wear what he designed himself and carry it through the day, from desk to dancing? “There were many like me who wanted a simpler, more relaxed and effort-less comfort wear. There was space for an alternative aesthetic that felt just as glamorous but with an Indian point of view, without being viewed through a Western lens or feeling overtly ethnic,” says the co-founder of Nicobar, which is one of the leading disruptors in the fashion space once dominated by legacy couturiers and their pret lines.

Before him, another finance professional, Jayashree Krishnan, who was thick into capital markets, found existing fashion brands rigid. Having worked with logistic chains of established fashion brands, she decided to break away on her own in 2009. “Even those rooted to textiles were not doing what the customer wanted. They did nothing for artisanal livelihoods so that our craft printing traditions could command a market,” says the founder of Maati Crafts, known for giving jumpsuits an Indian, free-flowing, body-inclusive look.

A train journey turned out to be the calling for Kirti Poonia, who had been working with the Tata group in 2007. As part of the corporate’s Jagriti Yatra in 2010, she travelled to Mithapur. The village was in the Okhamandal region of Gujarat, where a severe drought had farmers lose their livelihood overnight. Then Ramiben, a skilled applique artisan, took it upon herself to train women and make garments for local markets. With support from the Tatas and some training, she started Okhai in 2002, one of the first fashion brands to have craftspeople as stakeholders. When Poonia met them, she was stunned not only by their talent but their pride of owning their craft. “Everybody needed to see this craft which was at once hyperlocal and global in appeal,” she had said at the time. She created an e-marketplace with the Okhai website in 2015, got the women trained in contemporary styling and post Covid, made it a thriving online brand.

A decade ago, Indian fashion largely occupied two ends of the spectrum — couture reserved for weddings and celebrations and mass-market apparel stripped of craft. Today, a growing crop of design-led labels is building an alternate space, where handloom saris can enter board-

THE RISE OF INDIE LABELS COINCIDES WITH THE EMERGENCE OF PROFESSIONALS IN THEIR 30S AND 40S WITH GROWING DISPOSABLE INCOMES, STRONG DIGITAL HABITS AND A DESIRE TO BUY FEWER BUT BETTER THINGS

rooms, block prints can become workwear and craft can be worn every day rather than saved for special occasions. A slew of labels has frothed up, broken the elitism of fashion and become part of everyday life.

Instead of relying on the ramp, modern labels pull inspiration directly from everyday life and a deep engagement with online sub-cultures. Most importantly, they have opened up the fashion market to people whom traditional designers previously ignored — the workplace Indian, the aspirant Indian and the conversation-starter Indian.

“India’s fashion industry is not just going through disruption. It is undergoing a deeper structural transition. The shift is from designer-led, personality-driven brands to systems-driven, consumer-responsive businesses. What we are seeing today is not simply the emergence of new brands but a redefinition of how value itself is created and perceived. The rise of digitally native, scalable and sustainability-oriented brands reflects this shift,” says Prof Nirbhay Rana, faculty member at IILM University Gurugram. But what has surprised him is the growing emphasis on *karigar*-focused approaches, both independent and corporate-led. “What is significant is that scale and craft, once seen as fundamentally incompatible, are now being negotiated within the same business models,” he adds.

A study by Deloitte shows the emergence of a new segment called premium apparel, typically priced between Rs 3,500 and Rs 7,000. “Premium apparel is projected to grow even faster, at over 45 per cent CAGR, driven by rising aspirations, improving disposable incomes and increasing willingness to invest in quality-led fashion,” says the report. Businesswise, these brands are catching up with the big players. Nicobar has already crossed Rs 200 crore in annual revenue without any external venture capital. Raw Mango’s has touched a little higher than Rs 100 crore. Compare that to the revenue of the Tarun Tahiliani brand, which was Rs 350 crore.

The rise of the disruptors

Industry observers say the rise of these labels coincides with the emergence of a new Indian consumer — professionals in their 30s and 40s with growing disposable incomes, strong digital habits and a desire to buy fewer but better things. They are willing to pay more than fast-fashion prices but are not necessarily looking for couture.

Prof Rana argues that these brands succeed because they solve three long-standing problems. “First, they offer thoughtfully created products at more accessible price points. Second, they foreground narratives around



sourcing, production, ethics and sustainability. Third, they align with a generational shift in consumption, where buyers are not only purchasing products but subscribing to values and identities. Equally important is their ability to bypass retail constraints through direct-to-consumer models.”

Nicobar chose the anti-fit trend and ticked off the checklist of body inclusivity. “In fact, when we launched our first collection in black-and-white, many people thought we were crazy to do so in a country known for its love of colour. But we believed there was space for a more understated way of dressing. Now customers have evolved with us and have a greater openness to exploring contemporary silhouettes and ways of dressing,” says Rai, who conceived of the brand with wife Simran Lal. Now it is the cubicle-to-club favourite.

Meanwhile, Maati works on smart and crisp communication. “Chikankari has a legacy of 100 years. But look at its popularity today, which was missing even 10 years ago. That’s where communication and adaptability come in,” says Krishnan, who has contemporised block prints. And unlike designer pret lines, which are trimmed down versions of their couture lines and may not always adapt to standardised size curves or diverse body types, she focuses on where the construction of a dress has to be loosened,

tweaked or cinched. She did 15 different iterations of the jumpsuit in silk and cottons. “I do fit checks across sizes, looking at how a garment is riding up when the wearer lifts their arms or moves,” says Krishnan.

The rise of a parallel market

Twenty years ago, textile designer Sanjay Garg was quite done with the embellished look of a sari as ceremonial wear. Either that or an elderly drape. He decided to challenge the sari stereotype by transforming Chan-deris and Banarasis into modern, minimalist, airy silhouettes that sit as easy in a metro as in a boardroom. Earlier this year, he showed how Kanjivaram silks could be both luminescent and sedate at the London Fashion Week. “There is still a strong association between Indian fashion and a certain kind of aesthetic — heavy gold embroidery and maximalist ensembles. Indian fashion is too often quantified — it’s not seen for its innate aesthetic value but the number of hours it took a weaver to create a garment. It’s a surface-level engagement that sometimes drowns out the beauty of the weave itself,” says the founder of Raw Mango.

Designer Anavila Misra, who briefly worked on a project with the rural development ministry, realised that she needed a sari that was work-friendly in bureaucratic spaces. She worked with weavers from Phu-

THE NEW STYLEBOOK (Clockwise from top left): The viral linen sari by Anavila Misra; Raw Mango’s celebration wear; Nicobar’s contemporary and free-flowing aesthetic; Maati’s anytime workwear

Dispelling the Dream

Tanul Thakur's Wild Wild East is a must-read for the way it punctures holes into existing assumptions on the H-1B visa issue

Rishika Singh

WHO DESERVES a place in the “land of the free”, a shot at living out the “American Dream” — to make it in life regardless of your background, as long as you put in the work? Versions of this question have been raised since the uniquely consequential election in November 2024.

The dominant political ideology today argues that to immigrate to the United States, only the best and the brightest should be considered. During Donald Trump's first presidential campaign, Mexicans were seen as a monolith representing low-skill labour and thus disqualified from a chance at this privilege. In 2026, the clamour from Trump supporters has grown to target the supposed *crème de la crème* — white-collar workers on H-1B visas for “specialty occupations.” Foreign workers are seen as undercutting American ones by accepting lower pay and poorer work conditions. Or, they are viewed with suspicion simply based on a racist worldview.

And yet, this category of workers (often Indians associated with science and technology) found powerful defenders in US tech companies, politicians and others who described them as meritorious workers filling a supply gap. *Wild Wild East* by former H-1B worker-turned-journalist Tanul Thakur challenges these perceptions and more, beginning to end — from how Indian tech workers reach the US to what life really looks like for many of them.

Conceptually, H-1B evokes an image of a Silicon Valley giant offering a job to a skilled candidate, sponsoring their visa and bringing them to the country on a six-figure salary. The book shines a light on a not-so-small share of workers whose journey involves layers of middlemen helping US companies recruit workers of lower calibre, with no fancy degrees or the bare minimum required of them.

These “*desi* consultancies” or “body shops” take a cut of the candidates’ pay in exchange for bringing them to the US, sometimes for the entire duration of their working career. Their degrees, resumes, work experience and even job interviews can be faked. For the candidates, the depth of the shady systems at play often doesn't fully reveal itself until they are deep in the trenches. By then, they have already paid large sums to get overseas. Left with limited options, many agree to a reduced pay and continue being moved from project to project, company to company.

While between projects, they may have to live in the consultancies’ “guesthouses” with multiple room-mates and no guarantees of the next job. The precarity running through these stories — usually associated with blue-collar workers in West Asia — feels unbelievable, especially for this part of the first world.

How exactly does this happen? Who benefits from it? Why is so little known about it? Thakur joins the dots through stories of three men — two Indian H-1B hopefuls who slowly

discover the systems at play, and an American tech worker who steadily loses out on work and dives into this world to understand the root causes. All of them cycle through hope and dejection, with little in the name of redemption.

Thakur highlights data that makes one wonder why such an obvious link has not been examined before. Perhaps, as he points out, it has to do with the tone of the current debate, where any criticism of the H-1B programme is seen as racist when coming from Americans, and anti-national when coming from Indians.

Various data points raise red flags. For instance, he cites a study that asks if H-1Bs represent some of the most highly skilled workers; why have their salaries been flat for many years? He also cited the example of Infosys settling a US investigation into alleged visa fraud for \$34 million in 2013, without admitting to further widespread wrongdoing.

Thakur argues that these are not anomalies; the systems are working exactly as they were designed to. He stresses avoiding easy generalisations — that Indians are only caught in the crosshairs of a larger anti-immigration sentiment, that there is a persistent dearth of US graduates in technical fields, or that such programmes always benefit the native population. He attaches 125 pages of notes at the end to supplement his arguments.

The writing mimics the free-flowing conversational style of its protagonists. Some of the technical terms associated with engineering and tech jobs also distract from the larger story at times.

The book is a must-read for anyone interested in the current H-1B debate for the way it pokes holes into existing assumptions. Through years-long meticulous research, Thakur pieces together a complex puzzle. This includes the caste and regional profile of the Indians who qualify for H-1B through unscrupulous means, the role of media and universities in amplifying pro-H-1B voices, and why, at the end of it all, workers — both American and foreign — emerge as the biggest losers.

Saptarshi Basak

THERE ARE books that should be read because of what they say, and those that must be read because of what they say and who says it. Israeli-American historian Omer Bartov's *Israel: What Went Wrong?* belongs in the latter category. Bartov is the Dean's Professor of Holocaust and Genocide Studies at Brown University, and grew up with Zionist ideals and served in the IDF. His book serves as a reckoning, both moral and historical, for the State of Israel. It is essential reading for anyone seeking to understand how a nation founded in the shadow of the Holocaust and under the banner of “Never Again”, now finds itself confronting allegations of genocide in Gaza before the International Court of Justice.

The book traces the origins of the Israel we see today, showing how a series of critical decisions in its formative years set the country on a path of moral and political decline that has left it increasingly isolated on the world stage. Bartov's lament is unmistakable. The book is animated by a recurring conviction: It did not have to be this way.

Of the many questions the book poses, three stand out, and it is these that distinguish Bartov's work from much of the existing critical literature on Israel that focuses on its military adventurism or Ben-

Bartov dedicates an entire chapter to the killing of children in Gaza, describing the silence over it within Israel as the product of a self-indulgent preoccupation with one's own pain and suffering

jamin Netanyahu's appetite for perpetual conflict. This Bartov addresses in the first chapter but his book's lasting significance lies in what follows. These three questions demand serious engagement not only from Israelis but from the wider Jewish public if the “race to the abyss” is to be stopped.

The first question concerns the distinction between antisemitism and anti-Zionism, one that has moved to the centre of political debate and policymaking in both Israel and the United States. The stakes became evident when, not too long ago, university campuses in the US witnessed arrests, suspensions, expulsions and other disciplinary measures against students protesting Israel's bombing campaign in Gaza and continued American support for it. That many of these students were branded antisemitic is precisely the conflation Bartov seeks to untangle.

He begins by acknowledging that Judeophobia or antisemitism has a long and pernicious history, culminating in the horrors of the Holocaust. But he argues that anti-Zionism is categorically distinct. Zionism, as an ethnonationalist political project, extended beyond the goal of protecting Jews from persecution and entailed the displacement and dispossession of the existing Palestinian population in the territory that Zionist pioneers described as “a land without a people for a people without a land.” To criticise the



THE NEW YORK TIMES

Moment of Reckoning

In Omer Bartov's Israel: What Went Wrong? traces the origins of the state and a series of critical decisions that set it on a path of moral and political decline

CRISIS HOUR
US President Donald Trump with Israel Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu

State of Israel, whose founding ideology is Zionism, is not, in Bartov's view, to replicate the antisemitism that Jewish communities have endured for centuries. He navigates this distinction with considerable precision, arriving at what may be the chapter's sharpest observation: that defining criticism of Israel as antisemitic is, in his words, “the best way to help the current Israeli leadership practise unchallenged extremist, racist policies.”

The second question is about the Holo-

caust, and this, perhaps, is the most provocative chapter in the book. Bartov frames his inquiry plainly: “It is important to consider some fundamental questions regarding the use and abuse of the Holocaust as a historical event, a traumatic memory, and a warning to future generations.” The chapter explores the Holocaust's historical uniqueness, its centrality in Israeli political and public life, and how it has become a justification for Israel operating as a unique entity, exempt from the

The author seamlessly carries this tenderness into the web of complex human emotions in the titular story. The narrative beautifully illustrates how love exists beyond the confines of caste, region, religion, bias and a judgmental world. The poignant longing of a child born out of an inter-faith union mirrors the author's own deep empathy. As the text reflects: “Manu wondered about his father... Whenever he asked who his father was, Shakuntala always gave the same answer: ‘Your name is Manu and you are the son of the Sun. Be patient, for that is the patience of your love for your father.’”

Reflecting on his craft, Verma notes: “Beyond geographies, all stories of the world are about love, longing, separation, hate, and despair. But a particular region brings its own distinct value to it. I am not sure what is uniquely Purvanchali about my tales but one thing is certain — they are reflections of a lived life. If they find a connection with readers thousands of miles away from India, it feels as though

rules and logic that govern other nations.

It takes considerable courage to challenge established narratives around an event as tragic as the Holocaust, and Bartov does not hold back. “The Shoah and the Nakba are inextricably entangled,” he writes. How many Western historians, let alone Israeli ones, would place the Holocaust and the mass displacement of Palestinians in 1948 in the same frame? He goes further, arguing that the catastrophe of the Holocaust became “a vast fig leaf” whose “lamentable effect” combined Israeli “self-victimisation and self-pity with self-righteousness, hubris and the euphoria of power.” Bartov's conviction is that only by discarding the senseless competition for victimhood and by reflecting jointly on both events can Israelis and Palestinians arrive at any genuine mutual understanding. He concedes, however, that at this juncture, it is a tall order.

The third question concerns Israel's missing constitution, a striking absence for a country that presents itself as the sole democracy in West Asia. Bartov's central claim is that the illiberal practices of the State of Israel today — systemic discrimination against Palestinians, the concerted effort to transform the demography of occupied territories, the ongoing judicial overhaul — can all be traced back to “the unresolved question of how a multi-faith

state can remain both Jewish and democratic.” Drawing on historical documents, Bartov shows how Israel's first prime minister, David Ben-Gurion, resisted the adoption of a constitution, and how his approach to Israel's Declaration of Independence — a progressive document that does address equal rights for all but one not en-

shrined in any of the country's laws — was driven entirely by foreign policy and propaganda considerations.

No where is Bartov's sense of regret more evident than here. A constitution grounded in the Declaration, he writes, would have “served to constrain the worst impulses of Zionism.” For him, this is a missed opportunity that has exacted a high toll on Israeli politics and society, for a commitment to constitutional values and human rights might have produced a public response to Israel's cruelty in Gaza and the West Bank very different from the “astounding indifference” he sees today.

Finally, Bartov dedicates an entire chapter to the killing of children in Gaza, describing the silence over it within Israel as the product of a self-indulgent preoccupation with one's own pain and suffering. At the time of writing, more than 75,000 people have been killed in Gaza, over 20,000 of them children, and more die every day as Israel pays little heed to the October ceasefire with Hamas. Will it end soon? Bartov has his doubts. His conclusion is ominous: Without being compelled to face the limits of its power by the one actor capable of doing so, the US, Israel will continue down this catastrophic path.

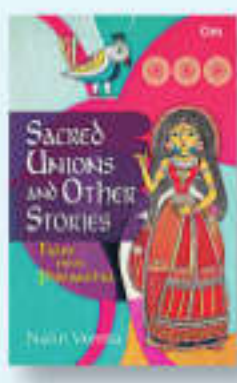
This is a book without a happy ending. But it is an essential one, and among the most important contributions to the literature for anyone wanting to know how Israel arrived here and where it is headed.

my flower girl is offering a universal rose to all beholders of love.”

The collection also gestures deftly toward the dramatic transformations ushered in post-1990s, when liberalisation, migration and digital technology fundamentally altered both rural and urban topographies. The advent of the internet and smart phones exposed communities, once rooted for generations within fixed geographical and cultural frameworks, to an entirely new social order. For younger readers growing up in an era of instant messaging and social media, these stories offer a nostalgic glimpse into how their parents and grandparents loved, longed, communicated and resisted in a world untouched by digital connectivity.

At its core, *Sacred Unions and Other Stories* is a masterful exploration of memory, belonging, desire and shifting social tides in the Hindi heartland, a deeply moving literary journey through the emotional and cultural landscape of Purvanchal.

SANTOSH SINGH



SACRED UNIONS AND OTHER STORIES: TALES FROM PURVANCHAL

NALIN VERMA
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SHELF LIFE

Lores of the Past

FROM DEMYSTIFYING politics to co-authoring Lalu Prasad's autobiography, *Gopalganj to Raisina Road* (2019) to chronicling the folklores of Bihar, Nalin Verma has cast his lens wide. With his latest book, *Sacred Unions and Other Stories* that follows his *Greatest Folk Tales of Bihar* (2019) and *Lores of Love & Saint Gorakhnath* (2025), he continues to document the culture of Purvanchal. The subjects of his works may be diverse but the common thread that runs through them lies in the empathy and sensibility with which he treats them.

In *Sacred Unions and Other Stories*,

Verma, a veteran journalist with a career spanning over 30 years, transports his readers straight into the heart of the rural landscape, unearthing raw emotions and intrinsic values that have been on the retreat in urban India. Having spent a significant part of his formative years in his ancestral village in Siwan, Verma captures and conveys this world in rich, evocative detail.

On the surface, *Sacred Unions and Other Stories* is an anthology of five tales, yet the Purvanchal setting and its characters are a microcosm of this world. The story, “The Flower Girl”, evokes the author's own days at Patna University where his hostel overlooked the majestic Ganga. The river, with its undulating waves and passing boatmen, breathes a sense of serenity and peace into the prose. It is near these banks that he encounters the flower girl. Verma is drawn both by her and the flowers; the rose she generously gifts him continues to nestle against his fingers long after he returns to his hostel room.

everything — from early Bengal of the 13th century through colonial transformation, Mughlai influence, and the confluence of cultures that made this city unlike any other, landing finally in contemporary Kolkata.

The book draws on an accomplished roster of contributors — Malini Banerjee, Amrita Das, Priyadarshini Chatterjee, Pinaki Bhattacharya and Dolon Dutta Chowdhury — each bringing a distinct voice to a city that has never suffered from a shortage of opinions about its own food.

What makes the book different from other coffee table or recipe books is the considered choice of not standardising the measurements, giving weight to a grandmother's pinch and an aunt's “until it feels right.”

And then there is the street food: the telebhaja or the deep-fried fritters, onomatopoeic phuchka and the jhal muri, which



SLICE OF CITY
A jhal muri stall in a park in Kolkata

moves between the personal and the historical without losing its footing. A six-part culinary history runs through



HEIRLOOM CITIES: KOLKATA
MADHUSHREE BASU ROY AND ANINDYA BASU
Sri Bodanapu
378 pages
₹7,500

made a political debut in the assembly elections this year.

The photography is the real standout as there are no marble countertops and pristine overhead shots of ingredients arranged like jewellery. A hand grips a newspaper cone and an older woman lifts steamed buns from a vast pot, steam rising around her — these images are the throbbing heart of any city and its people.

If there is a frustration, it is one born of appetite rather than disappointment. *Heirloom Cities: Kolkata* is a luxury object — Bodanapu's press materials call it a print collectible and the production value lives up to it. One might raise an eyebrow at that framing for a book so devoted to street corners and home kitchens. But then, the tiger's milk was always going to cost you something. The question is whether it is worth it. It is.

Kolkata on a Plate

Heirloom Cities moves between the personal and the historical to capture the soul of the City of Joy through its food

Aishwarya Khosla

BURIED in the glossy pages of *Heirloom Cities: Kolkata* is a phrase that reveals the soul of the city it is trying to capture: *New Market e bagher doodho pawa jaye* (In New Market, you can find even a tigress' milk). In the City of Joy, myth and fact have always been comfortable neighbours, argued over cups of cha and folded into inherited recipes.

Sri Bodanapu, who founded this imprint out of San Francisco with an ambitious thesis about Asian culinary identity, has found in Kolkata a rich subject. The first volume on Mumbai won the Gourmand Awards. This second volume confirms it

was not a fluke. He writes, “Our food is extremely regional: no two cities share the same history, influences, or culinary evolution, and Kolkata is a powerful reminder of this.”

The editors, Madhushree Basu Roy and Anindya Basu, write in their foreword that “the goal wasn't to create another cookbook, but to capture the soul of the city through its food.” Their Kolkata is built from morning fish markets and Mughlai kitchens, from Park Street's iconic restaurants alongside contemporary cafés, from the Chinese eateries of Tangra carrying forward generations of quiet, stubborn dreaming, from sweet shops where sweets transcend dessert to become “pure emotion.” The writing



THE SUSPENSE OF EVERYDAY
(Above) Madhuri Dixit, Triptii Dimri and Dharna Durga in a still from *Maa Behen*; writer-director Suresh Triveni and co-writer Pooja Tolani

The Curious Case of a Mother and her Daughters

How writer-director Suresh Triveni, co-writer Pooja Tolani and an unabashed trio of Madhuri Dixit, Triptii Dimri and Dharna Durga brought the peculiar world of *Maa Behen* to life

Alaka Sahani

WRITER-DIRECTOR Suresh Triveni's brief to Madhuri Dixit, Triptii Dimri and Dharna Durga — who essay their characters of a dysfunctional mother-daughter trio in *Maa Behen* — was to be *beshamam* (unabashed). That's something they kept in mind when messy mother Rekha (Dixit) has a meltdown; Jaya (Dimri) blasts her husband for his entitled behaviour or Sushma (Dharna) asserts her individuality. Along with that Triveni was quite certain that he wanted to bring out the "quintessential Madhuri Dixit", whose charm and appeal have an enduring impact on pop culture. He wanted to draw the audience into the story of a mother and her estranged daughters attempting cover up a crime in a nosy residential colony. For the role of Rekha, who has always been perceived as a 'scarlet woman' by the neighbours, Dixit was Triveni's choice from the beginning. Many, however, discouraged him from approaching the actor, famous for her performances in blockbusters such as *Hum Aapke Hain Koun..!* (1994), *Dil To Pagal Hai* (1997) and *Devdas* (2002). She won't play a mother to grown-up daughters was the common assumption. "Eventually, I decided that if I have to hear a 'no', then I will hear it from Madhuri Ma'am," recalls Triveni. *Maa Behen*, a crime comedy that reflects how society judges unconventional women, is currently streaming on Netflix. In 2024, Triveni and his co-writer Pooja Tolani set out from Mumbai's Andheri to Dixit's residence in Worli to give her a narration. On their way, they played popular songs picturised on Dixit. Not only did they get an affirmation from her to play Rekha, but they ended up spending close to four hours with her. After that, Triveni says in a lighter vein, they used "We have Madhuri

Dixit on board" as a trump card. Triveni recalls using that when he met Dimri in Bhopal, where she was shooting for *Dhadak 2* (2025). "After watching her in *Bulbul* (2020) and *Qala* (2022), I was keen to cast her as Jaya. A month after our meeting, *Animal* (2023) became a massive hit. While congratulating her, I asked, 'Will you still do my film?' Her reply was: 'Nothing changes, I'm doing your film'," recalls Triveni, who earlier directed *Tumhari Sulu* (2017), *Jalsa* (2022) and *Subedaar* (2025). To cast Durga as Jaya's half-sister Sushma was Tolani's idea. "I followed Dharna on social media and I really like her videos because she is uninhibited. There is something nicely awkward about her, which in my mind is how Sushma is," recalls Tolani. When Dharna was called for a test, she arrived with a packet of coriander leaves. "Dharna knew she had to enact the kitchen scene where she is plucking the leaves and angrily reacts to her sister's claims," shares Tolani, who grew up in Kolkata and, in 2008, graduated in screenwriting from the Film and Television Institute of India (FTII), Pune. Both Triveni and Tolani agree that a number of scenes in *Maa Behen* lean into physical comedy. Those scenes work because Dixit, Dimri and Durga worked on their chemistry. Reading and rehearsals apart, what helped was the workshop, with exercises specially designed for the three of them, conducted by Puja Sarup, actor and theatre practitioner. They

played games, had fights and sang together. "We also had a lot of samosas during those sessions. I believe food breaks the ice every time," says Triveni, who studied engineering and had a career in advertising before he veered into filmmaking. Much before the three leading ladies came together, the journey of *Maa Behen* started when Triveni roped in Tolani as a "collaborator". He was stuck after writing nearly 60 pages. Though Triveni had reached the mid-point, he was not able to carry the narrative forward to resolution. After they started jamming, Tolani not only nudged Triveni to question what he was trying to convey but gradually reworked the screenplay around the mother who makes a frantic call to her daughters to help her dispose of a dead body. With the focus on "the complexities that women deal with while leading a life without men", Tolani overhauled the script. "The body in a trunk is one of the oldest tropes in cinema. How does one tell the story differently? We wanted to bring in the flavour of Hindi and Malayalam pulp magazines. A few months

THE BODY IN A TRUNK IS ONE OF THE OLDEST TROPES IN CINEMA. HOW DOES ONE TELL THE STORY DIFFERENTLY? WE WANTED TO BRING IN THE FLAVOUR OF HINDI AND MALAYALAM PULP MAGAZINES. A FEW MONTHS PRIOR TO THE SHOOT, WE CAME UP WITH THE IDEA TO USE THAT TREATMENT DURING FLASHBACK SEQUENCES
SURESH TRIVENI
Writer-director

prior to the shoot we came up with the idea to use that treatment during flashback sequences," recalls Triveni, who was influenced by Manmohan Desai, Mani Ratnam, Ram Gopal Varma and Sai Paranjpye. During every flashback, whether it is related to the character of Rekha, Jaya or Sushma, there's an exaggeration in the narration and performances. Though some are calling this over-the-top, Triveni says it's deliberate. "All the flashbacks are scenes that feature all rumours. Rumours are exaggerated and don't have details. In flashbacks, Rekha is wearing one sari across various days. That's deliberate too," says Triveni and adds he wanted to add a touch of magical realism while keeping it entertaining. Even though the film explores several feminist themes, Triveni believes that's a by-product of having women as protagonists. "It's not like you start with a situation where you want to smash patriarchy. Gender politics will come into the picture organically when it's a woman's story because that is their motivation. For instance, Rekha wearing sleeveless blouses is about her choice," says the writer-director. Tolani agrees with him and says, "For me, it started off with these three women who are carrying such a broken sort of personality. The dysfunctionality comes from the complex that each one of them had about growing up without a man. The film is about them coming together and healing in a way where they realise that they don't need a man." Earlier, Tolani with Konkona Sen Sharma wrote the segment that the latter directed for *Lust Stories 2* (2023). Even as *Maa Behen* is trending on Netflix, it has received mixed responses. "If our form of art creates a conversation, there is no bigger satisfaction than that. You can't have everyone liking it. The chatter — whether it is about the narrative or form — is good," says Triveni, who wants to work on a psychological horror or a musical next.



Find your Tribe

Director Abinash Bikram Shah and producer Anup Poudel on making history with *Elephants In The Fog*, their film from Nepal that picked up an award at Cannes



BUILDING COMMUNITIES
A still from *Elephants In The Fog*

Shubhra Gupta

WHEN THE strikingly atmospheric film *Elephants In The Fog* won the Un Certain Regard Jury prize at the recently concluded Cannes film festival, it was a moment: the first film from Nepal to have been officially selected at the festival going straight into the winners list; it was no less than a dream coming true. It may be set in a small village among the members of the Kinnar community, which stretches across the South Asian nations of Nepal, Bangladesh, Pakistan and India, tapping into its rules and rituals, but at heart, it is a film about love and belonging. Specific yet universal, in the way the best films are. The Metis or Kinnars (called *Hijras* in India) have traditionally struggled for acceptance and a life of dignity, denied on the basis of them not fitting in: It's only in the last few years that legal recognition of the 'third gender' has begun. It is against this backdrop that films featuring the community have their own struggle: how do you create authenticity while showing a group of people who have been forced into adopting exaggerated claps, one of their distinctive features, and ultra-colourful attire to be able to stand out, as well as fit in? How does a filmmaker gain trust in an atmosphere of distrust, which has hardened lines over generations? When we meet the day after the award, both director Abinash Bikram Shah and producer Anup Poudel — as well as other members of the ecstatic team, are recovering from the celebrations that stretched well into the morning. The two, who have worked closely together for over 15 years, recount how they discovered the Kinnars through their vibrant Tik Tok channels during Covid. Through NGOs like Blue Diamond who've worked extensively with the Kinnars

WHEN YOUR OWN FAMILY ABANDONS YOU AND YOU ARE TAKEN INTO ANOTHER FOLD AND YOU FIND THE LOVE, YOU CREATE YOUR OWN FAMILY

and trans people in Nepal, they found the people they were looking for, and won their trust over a period of time: that rare insider access, the comfort between the people being filmed and those behind the camera, is clearly evident in the film. I ask them how they are feeling after creating history, and both have thoughtful answers, the elation laced with the exhaustion that goes hand in hand with making independent cinema with 'a certain regard', the cobbling together of development funds and post-production support (the film is a co-production between Nepal-France-Germany-Norway-Brazil) and other roadblocks. "We were having champagne in the green room, and our names were called, and my first reaction was, we did it," says Poudel. "As a creative producer, my work lies in finding and supporting stories that are not heard in mainstream cinema, even if it is very difficult to work in the international arena." The work that goes into researching and trying to find funds. The news of the selection. The standing ovation and the tears. It's all so clear in Shah's emotional response to the award, which he, like the other members of the cast and crew, is still processing. "It could easily have turned into an ethnographic film, but I didn't want that. From my childhood I have been fascinated with families, and it shows in all my writing," Shah says. "During our research we saw how strong the ties were between the Guru Maa and the rest, so I wanted this film to be about mothers and daughters." And that is the central concern of the film: when your own family abandons you, and you are taken into another fold, there to find the love and affection missing in your life, you create your family. It is not about bloodlines, it is about finding your tribe. That's been a running thread in the other films revolving around the 'third gender' and the numerous sub-groups within that label. Kalpana Lajmi's 1997 *Darmiyaan*, with Arif Zakaria in a striking central role, remains one of the best representations of the third gender. More recently, in Cannes itself, Saim Sadiq's *Joyland* (2022) won both the Jury prize as well as the Queer Palm for the best LGBTQI-themed film. And *Elephants In The Fog* takes that much-needed, crucial conversation further down the road.

What Bollywood can learn from these two horror hits

The takeaway from the global success of *Obsession* and *Backrooms* is about trusting writers and backing bold ideas

Alaka Sahani

BEFORE ESTABLISHED masters Steven Spielberg and Christopher Nolan released their latest movies — *Disclosure Day* on June 12 and *The Odyssey* on July 17, respectively — Hollywood has experienced an upheaval with two indie horror films from Gen Z filmmakers — *Obsession* directed by Curry Barker and *Backrooms* by Kane Parsons — becoming major international successes. The success of YouTubers-turned-filmmakers, many assume, signals the beginning of a new phase for Hollywood that might challenge conventions. Writer-director Vasana Bala believes that

it's not Hollywood which bet on Barker and Parsons. "These young filmmakers bet on themselves. Instead of reacting to their success, film professionals should react to their process. All this comes down to originality in filmmaking," says the *Mard Ko Dard Nahi Hota* (2018) director. The Hindi film industry, according to him, shows a similar reaction when a *Dhruv* or *Saiyaara* is a hit. "The breakout films themselves, however, didn't follow formulas or tropes," says Bala. *Obsession*, a psychological horror movie written and directed by 26-year-old Barker, follows a lonely music store employee who uses 'One Wish Willow' to win the love of his long-time crush. *Backrooms*, which is



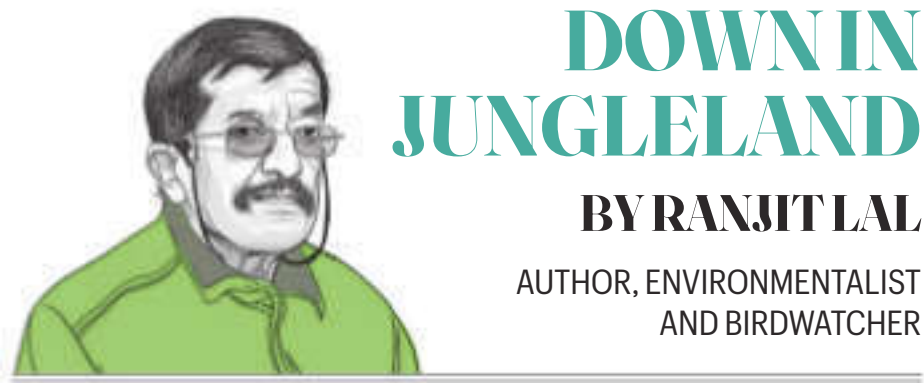
LOVE INTERRUPTED
While *Backrooms* (above left) follows the story of a furniture store owner, in *Obsession*, we meet a lonely music store employee



based on 20-year-old Parson's web-series by the same name, follows a furniture store owner (Chiwetel Ejiofor) who finds a secret doorway that leads him to a seemingly endless stretch of nondescript rooms. Both

these inventive movies have generated incredible buzz outshining recent releases *Star Wars: The Mandalorian* and *Grogu* and *Masters of the Universe*. Indian filmmakers who are obsessed with playing safe, however, might not be taking a leaf out of their success just yet. The current ecosystem is "risk-averse". Green-lighting a project often depends on how commercially viable a project is. However, writer-director Arati Kadav believes that "there is a lot of plurality in the Indian industry" and is hopeful that "there will be producers who would believe in nurturing unique minds and radical ideas". Director of sci-fi feature *Cargo* (2019) and social drama *Mrs.* (2023), Kadav says, "I want to see a big production house take a chance where I would feel: 'Wow, where did they find the madness to go all the way out on stories like this'. That's what I felt when I watched *Everything Everywhere All At Once* (2022) or *Project Hail Mary* (2026). One of the Indian filmmakers, who did something

insane is SS Rajamouli and his machinery put their might behind his vision." Before *Strree* (2018) became a franchise and horror-comedy became a bankable genre, the movie was considered a risky proposition. Bala says the real issue is whether filmmakers are given the space to pursue their process. "The industry will probably react to a new thing with a lot of suspicion. The filmmaker then has to go beyond that suspicion," he adds. Advocating "relentlessness of process", the *Monica, O My Darling* (2022) director says the filmmakers have to relentlessly go about writing their stories, pitching them and finding creative partners. And trends in cinema are often cyclical. Horror-comedies can replace social dramas but later make way for hyper-masculine action films. "The next breakthrough almost always comes from somewhere unexpected. We are in a state of constant change and no one knows when the next wave is going to come," says Bala.



DOWN IN JUNGLELAND

BY RANJIT LAL

AUTHOR, ENVIRONMENTALIST
AND BIRDWATCHER



PRAGYA BISWAS

ROAR OF CHANGE
A tigress in Bandhavgarh Tiger Reserve, Madhya Pradesh

Cats' Whiskers

What happens when the big ones come calling

THE INTERNATIONAL Big Cat Alliance Summit was supposed to be held in New Delhi in the beginning of June. Down in Jungleland (DjJ) takes a swing at what could be the points of view from the big cats who will be the subject of the summit.

TIGER: We need more territory and there must be a ban on pushing expressways through our forests.

LION: (interrupting) Excuse me, I think I should talk first. I am the King of the Jungle after all.

TIGER: (growling) And I am the national animal of the world's biggest democracy and this is my domain. So wait your turn.

LION: You — not even 4,000 — are only found in this godforsaken subcontinent where the mantra is to cut down the forests and build roads and dams. And in China, they farm you for skin and bones, bah! We roam the Gir forests and the vast plains of Africa where thousands of tourists and photographers make documentaries of us.

LEOPARD: Wait, we need to discuss more important matters. We leopards are being persecuted everywhere. In national parks and sanctuaries, all that people want is to see the tiger, not us. When we entered cities like Mumbai and Gurugram, they got after us, for killing their dogs.

LION: (shuddering) In Gir, they are turning us into pussycats. With forest guards sitting casually nearby babysitting us all the time. They are damn lucky we are so congenitally lazy and they're so scrawny. We want to move out. What if there's a Covid equivalent virus that strikes us here?

TIGER: (smirking) You're stuck in Gir because you're the PM's pet! Kitty-kitty! Puddy-tat! And yes, they call you Indian loins don't they? (laughter)

CHEETAH: (anxiously) Hey, don't get any ideas of migrating to Kuno! We have a tough enough time as it is dealing with you guys (points towards the leopard) murdering our babies, with feral dogs and hyenas.

JAGUAR: If you let me have a word. I think we jaguars are the most important big cats on the planet. We live in and protect the great Amazon rainforest, without which the Earth would just shrivel up and die.

SNOW LEOPARD: And we guard the mighty Himalayas, the source of freshwater and holy rivers for an entire civilisation. Spiritual books have been written about me. They need to give us top priority.

PUMA: Hold on, do you know I have the most names? Puma, cougar, mountain lion, panther... I am found in the greatest country in the world, the USA besides South and Central America.

PUMA: Well, the Brits and Maharas nearly wiped you and your lion friend out completely.

CHEETAH: They succeeded with our Indian cousins, didn't they? And now they go around saying 'Make in India'.

LEOPARD: (Grinning) You are making in India — and very tasty babies too!

CHEETAH: (Bristling and turning to the others) Hey, did you hear that? And you will say nothing about it?

TIGER: (Turning to the lion) You better watch out: I heard that they are going to serve you dhoklas.

LION: (roaring) Over my dead body!

PUMA: No worries for me! It's beef burgers for me!

TIGER: Kindly do not use the 'b' word... We do not tolerate intemperate language. We are a civilised country with a 5,000 year history!

SNOW LEOPARD: So where do we go from here?

TIGER: We pass a unanimous resolution. I propose: No more felling of forests anywhere or building expressways through them, no more tunnelling through mountains and building tower block resorts in hill stations, expansion of our protected areas, tourists to keep a minimum of 500 metres away from us at all times, with not more than two Gypsies allowed at any one time, Indian lions to be allowed to go to any suitable habitat of their choice — except Kuno and Africa... a statue be built of the Asiatic cheetah, in Kuno to commemorate the last of the local species, all poachers to be brought before us to deal with in any way we like...

LION: (shaking its mane) You know they will never agree... like Iran and America.

TIGER: Then we take direct action: We tigers will leap into tourist Gypsies and you lions go on a fast-unto-death if served dhoklas. Remember they have been invading our territories for years, it is time we defended our precious habitats.

PUMA: And be allowed to carry arms...

TIGER: (showing him his teeth and unsheathing his claws) Well, we are armed at all times...

JAGUAR: Si, senors, and we should be allowed at least one gringo a month.

PUMA: (licking its chops) Oh yeah, all those XXL fast food junkies! Delicious

TIGER: (Grimacing) All skin and bones this side! But if we do, they'll come after us with guns regardless of our protective status and take us down like that guy did to Avni... But you guys are welcome to go ahead!

CLOUDED LEOPARD: Excuse me, sirs...

(They all look around surprised and spot him).

TIGER: Where the heck did you come from? And who are you?

Chef Amrita Raichand on her mother's cooking, balancing nutrition and taste, and her YouTube series

Heena Khandelwal

IN A comfortable two-bedroom-hall-kitchen house, a young Amrita Raichand (nee Saluja) would be plonked on a stool next to the kitchen counter while her mother Prakash Kaur cooked. That kitchen in her house in Jama-doba in Jharkhand's Dhanbad became her first culinary school. She learnt the chops by observing and put her first meal together when she was eight — Bihari dal, tamatar ki chutney, aloo-beans bhujjiya and rice.

"My mother could make anything taste good, be it *tauri* or *lauki* or *tinde*. My birthday parties — where she would make everything from scratch, including a cake, chole tikki, frankie rolls, chilly chicken — were the talk of the town," she says, sitting in her spacious sea-facing duplex in Colaba. Right behind her is a photo of her mother who passed away this April after battling Parkinson's.

"The saag mutton was originally my *maasi*'s recipe but my father loved it, so my mother learnt it," she says. Her father, a senior engineer with Tata's Tisco in Jamshedpur, was such a foodie that he made her mother take gourmet cooking classes. "My father also pushed her to do her MA and learn driving," she shares. Amrita was only three-and-a-half when her father passed away, leaving her mother, who was 32 at the time, to raise Amrita and her two older brothers single handedly. She took up a job with Tata Hospital and they moved to Dhanbad. And while they had to downsize their lives a bit, a proud Amrita says her mother ensured the house was filled with joy and food. "I don't remember wanting something and not getting it," she says.

In her home kitchen, she is hands-on. Her German knife, which she is particularly protective of, has come from her mum's house in Parel. She uses it to chop the onions into big chunks. Soon a cooker is put on a large flame, oil goes in, followed by *tej patta*, onions lightly tossed, then tomato, chunks of mutton, salt and a paste of ginger, garlic and chillies. "We don't mix the paste, otherwise it will remain at the bottom, we just leave it at the top," she says. Soon, pots and *kadhai*s are brought out and all five stoves are aflame. She is fixing aloo-beans bhujjiya — not *sabji* but *bhujjiya*, where it retains the crunch — in one *kadhai*. Parallely, she opens the cooker of boiled toor dal and fixes the consistency while preparing the tempering — oil, onion, *jeera* and *hing* — which goes in the middle of the cooking and not at the beginning to prevent burning. In another pan, there's tamatar ki chutney.

With most flames on high and so much cooking happening simultaneously, it naturally gets hot but Amrita doesn't complain. Instead, there is a familiar smile on her face, one we have all seen on television. Cooking comes naturally to her. She took to it as fish takes to water. She has had a team to look after day-to-day cooking for decades now, but the instinct never left — she impressed



PHOTOS: NIDHI JACOB

CHEF AT HOME

MUM'S the word

THE BIG LIFE

Chef Amrita Raichand in the kitchen of her Mumbai home; saag mutton

her teachers at The Lawrence School, Sanawar, cooked all meals by herself for nearly two years when she was living with her brother in Andheri East, pursuing double majors in economics and commerce from St Xavier's College, where she topped. Modelling happened almost by accident. Advertising veteran Suguna Swamy found in her the 'Pond's girl'. "I got paid Rs 75,000 for it, my brothers put Rs 50,000 in an FD that I still have," she smiles. The famous Whirlpool ad, in which she played a mother of two, happened when she was only 19.

Cooking resurfaced again, courtesy motherhood. "When I became a mother in 2007, I didn't want to work anymore. But while weaning Agastya, I started experimenting with food. Soon came the offer for *Mummy Ka Magic* — it gave me the opportunity to work at my pace. The biggest joy was that I was getting to educate other parents." While she was confident with Indian cuisine, she felt the need to refine her skills in international

cooking and attended At-Sunrice Global-Chef Academy in Singapore in 2015 for an advanced culinary course, followed by an online nutrition course at Le Cordon Bleu. "Nutrition has always been central to what I make. My motto is 'healthy isn't boring'."

Back in the Mumbai kitchen, Amrita opens the cooker with mutton, adds blanched *palak*, salt, pepper, *dhaniya* and red chilli powder for seasoning. In the drawing room, the table is set. She complains that the flowers she bought that morning haven't been placed, but there is simply no room — there is too much food. There's her mother's signature saag mutton, Bihari dal, a sweet-

sour tamatar ki chutney, crispy aloo-beans bhujjiya, rice and boondi raita. On the side are homemade mango and lemon pickles.

She has also baked the Queen of Puddings or "mom's pudding", as she calls it, topped with beautifully torched meringue flowers, as the finale. "This would see all of us siblings fighting for the meringue flowers. Mine are fine. Hers were perfect."

The whole meal, which she returned to after many years following her mother's passing, encapsulates "childhood, mother's love and memories." In the process, she created *Maa Ki Yaadein*, her new series on YouTube. "It is my way of keeping her alive."



SAAG MUTTON

INGREDIENTS

● 1 kg Mutton (on the bone); ● 400 g Palak (Spinach); ● 4-5 large onions, roughly chopped; ● 4 tomatoes, roughly chopped

FOR THE PASTE

● 1 whole pod of garlic, peeled; ● 1 big piece of ginger, peeled; ● 4-5 green chillies; ● 1 medium tomato; ● 3 bay leaves; ● 1 tsp turmeric powder; ● 2 tsp red chilli powder; ● Salt to taste; ● ½ tsp coriander powder; ● 1 tsp black pepper powder; ● 3-4 tbsp oil

METHOD

BLANCH THE spinach. Cook for 1-2 minutes until wilted. Remove immediately and place in cold water. Drain and keep aside

PREPARE THE paste. Blend together

garlic, ginger, green chillies and 1 medium tomato into a smooth paste. Keep aside

HEAT OIL in a pressure cooker. Add bay leaves and let them sizzle for a few seconds. Add roughly chopped onions and sauté until they turn slightly translucent

ADD ROUGHLY chopped tomatoes, turmeric powder and red chilli powder. Mix well and cook for 2-3 minutes until the tomatoes soften

ADD MUTTON and salt. Mix everything together well

NOW ADD ginger-garlic-green chilli paste over the mutton. Do not mix it in

PRESSURE COOK for 3-4 whistles. Allow the pressure to release naturally

ONCE OPENED, add the blanched spinach, coriander powder and black pepper powder

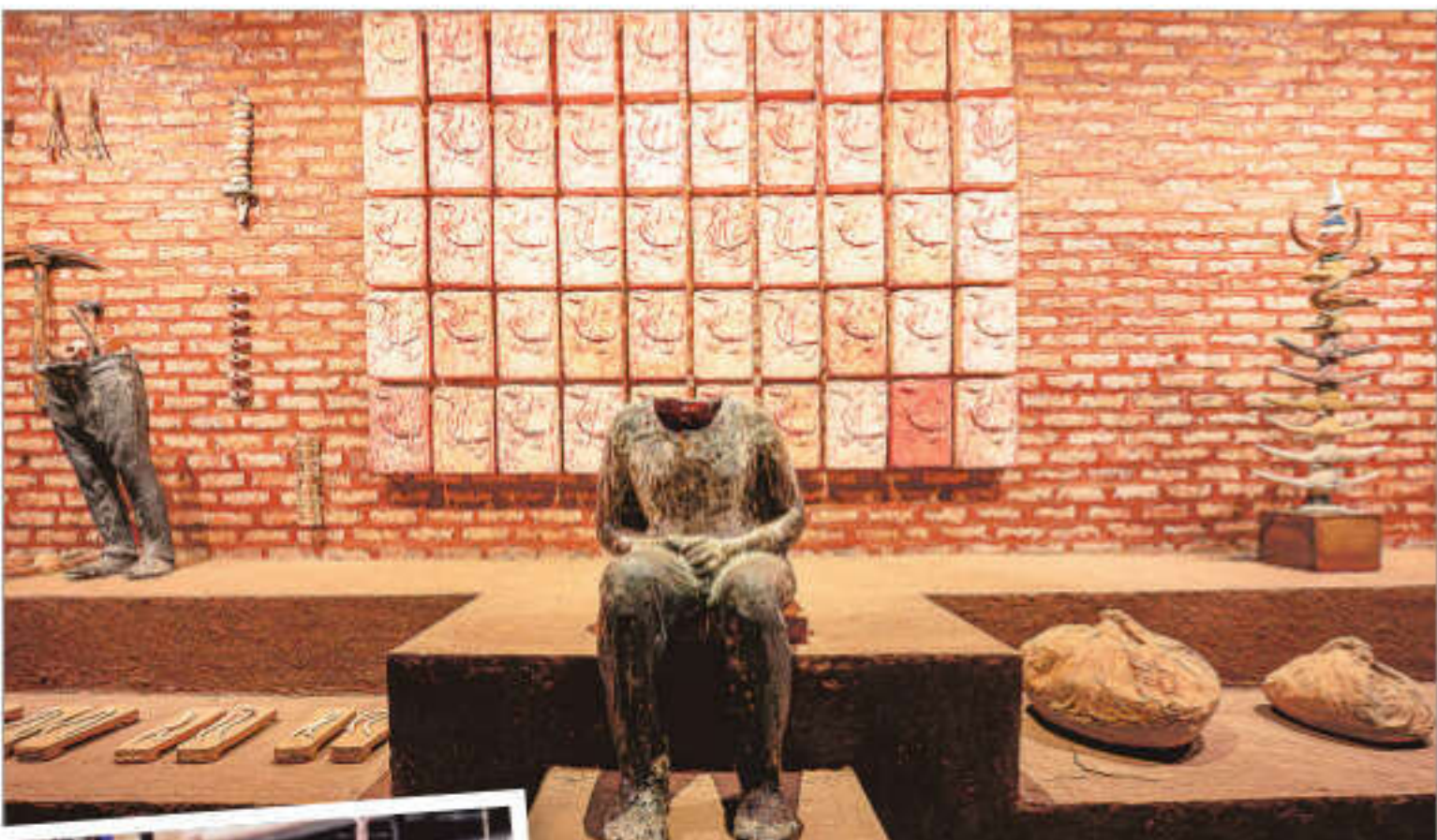
TURN THE heat to high and cook uncovered, allowing the spinach and mutton to cook together

CONTINUE COOKING, stirring occasionally, until the spinach is completely incorporated, the mutton is tender and the gravy reaches your desired consistency

ART FUTURES

Firing Intent

Artist Birender Yadav on his uncustomary exploration of labour and knowledge through clay, a medium that gives more than it takes



KOCHI BIENNALE FOUNDATION

MOULDING DUST

Only the Earth Knows their Labour at the 6th Kochi-Muziris Biennale; (left) Birender Yadav at his studio in Delhi



MOHAMMED SHAFIQ

makes it seem as if he found his subject organically, but it was a rather winding road to his calling. Born in Ballia, Uttar Pradesh, he migrated to the mining town of Dhanbad in Jharkhand as a child with his blacksmith father. Having grown up around his father's intricate drawings of tool lacing — which he recreated in clay as *Inherited Lines* at last year's Serendipity Arts Festival — he felt instinctively pulled towards art, an interest that found encouragement from his family. He went on to pursue a BFA at Banaras

Hindu University (BHU, 2009-13) where, like most aspiring artists, he enrolled in painting. Unfortunately, it never spoke to him.

Things took a turn only in his final year after a chance encounter with a group of *nikashi* workers from Jharkhand. "They worked in the kilns in Mirzapur. We just naturally became friends and I started visiting them," recalls Yadav. The arbitrary visits became frequent when he moved to the College of Arts, Delhi, in 2013, and routine — twice every month — when he started conducting workshops for ArtReach with the children of kiln workers. Even as he taught them to shape clay, he himself learnt more. "It was a collaboration — I brought the design, and they had the technical knowledge of firing and clay preparation," he says.

But it was only during the Covid lockdown, with a physical distance between him and the kiln, that he truly processed the significance of their skill, realising how it remains undocumented. Yadav's practice strives to fill that gap. "While most people make labourers the subject, I wanted to focus on their skill and technique — I come from that background and wouldn't want someone to make a portrait of my father — and create an archive," says the artist whose works are priced upwards of Rs 2 lakh.

The act of documentation is the driving force of his practice, and his studio is its evidence. The seemingly repetitive sculptures are test pieces that serve as logs of his experiments with clay, heat and pigments, eventually firing the ultimate act of creation. "These test pieces are like my diary. Whenever I want a particular colour, combination, shape or strength, I just go back to them," says Yadav, whose art is an alchemy of memory, material and knowledge — both inherited and acquired.

Beginning today, a fortnightly series will feature new voices in art